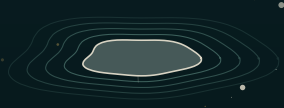


The Mercy of the Uncorrelated

Correlative Horror, Cosmic Indifference, and the Abyssal Realism of the Cthulhu Mythos

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair





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Abstract

This thesis advances a new interpretive and philosophical framework for the corpus of fiction, correspondence, and derivative cultural production known, since August Derleth's posthumous coinage, as the Cthulhu Mythos. It takes as its axiom the opening proposition of H. P. Lovecraft's "The Call of Cthulhu" (composed 1926; published 1928): that the most merciful thing in the world is "the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents." The received categories through which Lovecraft's achievement has been theorized (cosmicism, cosmic indifferentism, weird realism, the horror of philosophy) each describe a content, whether an indifferent universe, a withdrawn real, or a world-without-us, rather than the cognitive operation by which that content becomes unbearable. That operation is correlation: the binding of dispersed data into a total pattern. The thesis names the affect proper to this operation *correlative horror* and defines it as the dread that attends a finite intelligence's completion of a pattern whose completion annuls the centrality of the intelligence that completes it.

Correlation is shown to be the hinge on which every register of the Mythos turns, and the concept's own history, running from Aristotle's correlatives through Kant's transcendental synthesis, Francis Galton's statistics of heredity, and Klaus Conrad's psychopathology of apophenia to the correlational epistemology of machine learning, is reconstructed as the hidden genealogy of Lovecraft's sentence. Metaphysically, correlation names the zero-correlation between human value and cosmic process that Lovecraft distilled from the atomism of Democritus and Lucretius, the monism of Haeckel, the mechanism of Hugh Elliot, the philosophies of Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, and Spengler, and the post-Euclidean physics of Riemann, Einstein, and Planck. Epistemologically, it names the *Miskatonic method*, the narrative procedure through which scientific inference and paranoid apophenia become indistinguishable. Linguistically, it names the *analogia monstri*, a regime of avowedly failed analogy that supplants the scholastic *analogia entis*. Temporally, it names the stratigraphic correlation of deep time and the anthropology of survivals, condensed in the Mythos's own buried pun on an *eternal lie*. Biopolitically, it names the Galtonian reading of lineage that converts cosmic horror into the horror of heredity and

hybridity, and so discloses the cosmic Outside as the projection onto the stars of what Boaventura de Sousa Santos calls the *abyssal line* of colonial modernity. Technologically, it names the mimetic servitude of the shoggoth, whose borrowed cry anticipates the anxieties now gathered around artificial engines of correlation without interiority.

Proceeding by a constellational comparatism across literature, philosophy, scripture, myth, cinema, television, games, music, the visual arts, occultism, and network folklore (from Job, Hesiod, the *Enūma Eliš*, and the *Apocryphon of John* to Pascal, Burke, Kant, Otto, Levinas, Meillassoux, Harman, Thacker, and Fisher; from Poe, Machen, Dunsany, Blackwood, and Chambers to Lem, the Strugatskys, Liu Cixin, Watts, VanderMeer, LaValle, Jemisin, and Emrys; from Carpenter and Tarkovsky to *Bloodborne* and the SCP Foundation), the thesis concludes by constructing a new philosophical position, *abyssal realism*. Abyssal realism is neither correlationist (being is only ever being-for-us), nor speculative-realist in the received sense (the in-itself is accessible to mathematics or to allusion), nor cosmic-pessimist (the world-without-us is pure horror). It holds that the real is what remains uncorrelated within every relation, and that the most exacting form of relation is the one that preserves the uncorrelated as such. Drawing on Édouard Glissant's right to opacity and on the Afro-diasporic counter-mythology of Drexciya, the thesis reconstructs Lovecraft's "mercy" as an ethical and political maxim for an age of planetary computation and climatic catastrophe, and relocates the moral centre of the Mythos from the sleeping god of R'lyeh to the hybrid city of Y'ha-nthlei.

Contents

The thesis runs to eight chapters: an introduction establishing correlation as the axiom of the Mythos, six chapters each devoted to one register of correlative horror, and a conclusion constructing the position of abyssal realism.

1 The Most Merciful Thing 13

Correlation as the Axiom of the Mythos

1.1 An Axiom Disguised as a Sentiment 14
1.2 The Object of Study: Corpus, Protocol, Afterlife 16
1.3 Four Waves of Reception and the Missing Operation 18
1.4 A Genealogy of Correlation 22
1.5 Correlative Horror: Definition, Distinctions, Corollaries 26
1.6 Beyond Apologia and Indictment: The Dialectic of Correlation 29
1.7 Method: A Constellational Comparatism 31
1.8 The Architecture of the Argument 33

2 A Mechanistic Cosmos 37

The Philosophical and Aesthetic Genealogy of Lovecraftian Indifferentism

2.1 The Atomist Inheritance: Democritus, Epicurus, Lucretius 38
2.2 Infinite Spaces: Copernicus, Bruno, Pascal 40
2.3 The Darwinian Decentring: Huxley, Haeckel, and Hugh Elliot's Mechanism 43
2.4 Will, Value, Decline: Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, Spengler 45
2.5 Non-Euclidean Anxieties: Riemann, Hinton, Einstein, Planck, and the Physics of the Outside 47
2.6 The Aesthetic Lineage: Poe, Machen, Dunsany, Blackwood, Chambers, and the Augustan Ideal 50
2.7 Indifferentism as Statistical Independence 53
2.8 Aesthetic Traditionalism: "The Silver Key" and the Local Re-correlation of Value 54
2.9 Comparative Coda: Russell, Zapffe, Camus, Ligotti, Brassier, Lyotard 56

3 The Miskatonic Method 59

Forbidden Knowledge, the Archive, and the Epistemology of Correlative Horror

3.1 Eden, Prometheus, Faust: A Prehistory of Interdicted Knowing 60
3.2 The *Necronomicon* and the Imaginary Library: Borges, Eco 62
3.3 The Dossier: Clippings, Testimonies, Photographs, Phonographs 65
3.4 Science and Paranoia: Apophenia, Pynchon, and the Evidence Wall 68
3.5 Umwelt and Mesocosm: Uexküll, Vollmer, and "From Beyond" 70
3.6 Pnakotus: The Archive of the Great Race and the Subject as Specimen 73
3.7 Comparative Coda: Lem, the Strugatskys, VanderMeer, Found Footage, the SCP Foundation 75

4	**Analogia Monstri**	**79**
	The Unnamable, the Sublime, and the Theology of Failed Analogy	
4.1	Adjectival Excess and Its Critics: Wilson, Leiber, Harman	80
4.2	The Sublime and the Numinous Reconsidered: Burke, Kant, Otto	82
4.3	Via Negativa: Pseudo-Dionysius, Eckhart, Cusa	83
4.4	The Collapse of the *Analogia Entis*: Aquinas, Przywara, Barth, and "The Colour Out of Space"	85
4.5	The Blind Idiot God: Gnostic Acosmism, Jonas, and a Cosmos Without a Pleroma	88
4.6	The Tentacle and the Real: Miéville, Lacan, Kristeva	90
4.7	Xenoglossia: R'lyehian, Aklo, and the Grammar of the Unspeakable	91
4.8	Worship Without Reciprocity: Mauss, Bataille, and the Cults of the Great Old Ones	93
4.9	Comparative Coda: Job, Kafka's Odradek, Borges, Ito, Ligeti, *Bloodborne*	95
5	**The Eternal Lie**	**99**
	Deep Time, Survival, and the Undead Text	
5.1	Deep Time: Hutton, Lyell, Kelvin, and the Arche-Fossil	100
5.2	Survivals: Tylor, Frazer, Murray, Machen	102
5.3	Root-Races and Lost Continents: Theosophy and Occult Prehistory	104
5.4	Imprisoned Elders and Cycles of Ruin: Hesiod, the *Enūma Eliš*, the Yugas, Ragnarök, Spengler	106
5.5	The Horror of Being: Levinas, the *Il y a*, and the Impossibility of Death	108
5.6	*Nachleben*: Warburg, Didi-Huberman, and the Afterlife of Forms	110
5.7	Hyperstition: The *Necronomicon* After Lovecraft	111
5.8	"This Place Is Not a Place of Honor": Nuclear Semiotics as Applied Mythos	113
5.9	Comparative Coda: Wells, Hodgson, Stapledon, *Mass Effect*, *Dark Souls*, *Outer Wilds*	116
6	**The Abyssal Line**	**119**
	Degeneration, Heredity, and the Colonial Unconscious of Cosmic Horror	
6.1	The Record Without Euphemism	120
6.2	Degeneration and Eugenics: Morel, Lankester, Nordau, Galton, Grant, Stoddard	121
6.3	Brooklyn, 1924–1926: The Immigration Act and the New York Tales	123
6.4	Reverse Colonization: Arata, Rieder, and the Specimen's Nightmare	124
6.5	The Boomerang: Césaire, Arendt, Fanon, Wynter	126
6.6	The Abyssal Line Projected onto the Stars: Santos and the Cosmic Outside	127
6.7	Mothers of the Abyss: Lavinia Whateley, Shub-Niggurath, Asenath Waite	129
6.8	The Counter-Mythos: Drexciya, Okorafor, LaValle, Ruff, Emrys, Jemisin, Solomon	131
6.9	After the End of the World: Indigenous Futurisms and the Far-Right Afterlife	133
7	**Tekeli-li**	**137**
	Shoggoths, Servitors, and the Mimetic Machine	
7.1	Protoplasmic Labour: The Shoggoth in *At the Mountains of Madness*	138
7.2	From Pym to Antarctica: The Genealogy of a Borrowed Cry	140
7.3	Mimesis and Psychasthenia: Plato, Benjamin, Caillois	142
7.4	Golem, Robot, Servitor: Scholem, Čapek, Butler, Wiener	143
7.5	Brains in Cylinders: The Mi-Go, the Great Race, and the Extended Mind	145
7.6	The Mask and the Mass: The Shoggoth in Contemporary Discourse on Artificial Intelligence	147
7.7	The Mythos as Shoggoth: Pastiche, Play, Plush, and the Cute	149
7.8	Comparative Coda: *Blindsight*, *Solaris*, *Ex Machina*, *Westworld*, Chiang	150

8 Abyssal Realism 153
The Mercy of the Uncorrelated
8.1 A Map of Positions: Correlationism, Speculative Realism, Cosmic Pessimism, Dark Ecology 154
8.2 Withdrawal and Opacity: Harman with Glissant 156
8.3 The Faceless Other: Levinas and the Night-Gaunt 157
8.4 Chthulucene, Hyperobject, Weird Ecology: Haraway and Morton 160
8.5 R'lyeh Rising: Climate, Ghosh, and the Great Derangement 161
8.6 The Right to Be Uncorrelated: Planetary Computation and the Ethics of Opacity 163
8.7 Y'ha-nthlei: The Deep Ones and the Ethics of Relation 165
8.8 The Most Merciful Thing, Revisited 166

Bibliography 169

Keywords 184

Figures

1.1	*Four waves of reception*	20
1.2	*The five strata of correlation*	25
1.3	*Correlative horror and its seven corollaries*	30
2.1	*Three geometries*	48
2.2	*Three cosmoi*	53
3.1	*The media of correlation*	67
3.2	*Umwelten*	72
4.1	*Via negativa, via abyssalis*	85
4.2	*Correlation in the spectroscope*	87
5.1	*Exham Priory in section*	103
5.2	*A cycle on an arrow*	108
5.3	*A shunned place*	115
6.1	*The abyssal line projected onto the stars*	129
7.1	*The career of a cry*	141
8.1	*A chart of positions*	158
8.2	*Two abysses*	162

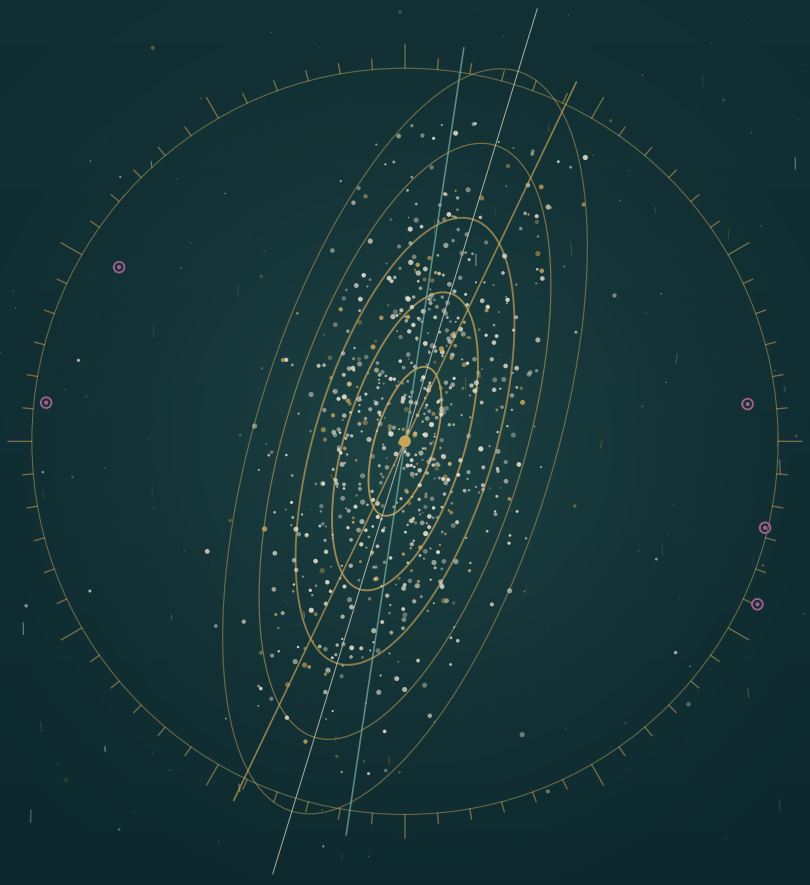
Note on Texts, Citations, and Conventions

Lovecraft's fiction is cited by title and, at first mention, by year of composition, with the year of first publication supplied where the interval is significant: *At the Mountains of Madness*, composed in 1931, did not appear until 1936, and *The Case of Charles Dexter Ward*, composed in 1927, not until 1941. Texts are those established by S. T. Joshi for Arkham House (1984–1989) and refined in the variorum *Collected Fiction* (Hippocampus Press, 2015–2017). The essays are cited from Joshi's edition of the *Collected Essays* (Hippocampus Press, 2004–2006), and the letters from the five volumes of *Selected Letters* (Arkham House, 1965–1976) and the Hippocampus Press editions of individual correspondences. Quotation from primary texts is deliberately sparing: the argument proceeds by paraphrase and analysis, and reserves direct citation for phrases whose wording is itself the object of analysis.

Secondary and comparative works are cited by author and date, with the date of original publication in square brackets where a translation is used, as in Meillassoux 2008 [2006]; complete references are collected in the Bibliography. Classical, scriptural, and philosophical texts are cited by their standard divisions: Aristotle by chapter, Kant by A/B pagination, Aquinas by part, question, and article.

Three conventions govern terminology. "Mythos," capitalized, designates the correlative system defined in Chapter 1 (corpus, protocol, and afterlife) rather than August Derleth's dualist redaction, which is called the Derleth Mythos after Tierney (1972). "The Outside," capitalized, follows Lovecraft's own usage for the exterior of human cognition and its correlates; it is compared with, but not identified with, Meillassoux's "great outdoors" and Thacker's "world-without-us." Terms coined in this thesis (correlative horror, the Miskatonic method, the *analogia monstri*, the eternal lie, the abyssal line in its cosmological extension, and abyssal realism) are defined at first use and gathered among the Keywords.

Chapter One



The Most Merciful Thing

Correlation as the Axiom of the Mythos

Le silence éternel de ces espaces infinis m'effraie.

Blaise Pascal, *Pensées*, 1670

The axiom

Chapter One

The Most Merciful Thing

1.1 An Axiom Disguised as a Sentiment

The Cthulhu Mythos begins with a theorem of mercy. The first sentence of "The Call of Cthulhu," composed in the late summer of 1926 and published in *Weird Tales* in February 1928, declares that the most merciful thing in the world is "the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents." Few sentences in American letters have been quoted so often or read so little, and its grammar is stranger than its fame. Mercy, *misericordia*, is in the scholastic tradition the virtue of one who has, in the formula Aquinas takes from Augustine, a *miserum cor super miseria alterius*, a heart made wretched by another's wretchedness, and who acts to relieve the other's defect (*Summa theologiae* II–II, q. 30, a. 1). Lovecraft's sentence transfers the predicate from an agent to a privation. No one is merciful; an incapacity is. Salvation is relocated from a disposition of the divine will to a limitation of the human cognitive apparatus, and the relocation is announced with a hedge ("I think") that assigns the theorem to a narrator, Francis Wayland Thurston of Boston, whose manuscript reaches us as something "found among the papers of the late." The axiom of mercy is pronounced by a correlator already destroyed by correlating. The frame performs what the sentence asserts.

The continuation of the sentence specifies the danger with a precision that its notoriety has obscured. The sciences, "each straining in its own direction," have hitherto done little harm; catastrophe will come from "the piecing together of dissociated knowledge," which will open such "terrifying vistas of reality," and of our place within them, that we shall either go mad from the revelation or flee into "the peace and safety of a new dark age." The threat is located neither in any single discipline nor in the unknown as such, but at the junction of knowledges, in synthesis. It is perhaps the most frightening sentence ever written about interdisciplinarity. What William Whewell had celebrated in 1840 as the "consilience of inductions," the leaping-together of independent lines of evidence that he took to be the signature of

truth, and what E. O. Wilson would still celebrate in 1998 as the unity of knowledge, appears in Lovecraft's proposition as the precondition of apocalypse. The governing image of the opening paragraph, a "placid island of ignorance" amid the black seas of infinity, is answered by the tale's central event, in which an island of an altogether different kind, the drowned city of R'lyeh, rises out of the South Pacific. The island of ignorance is menaced by its own geographical antithesis: an island of knowledge that ought to have stayed submerged.

The sentence is, in addition, a precise inversion of the Enlightenment's founding imperative. Kant's answer to the question "What is Enlightenment?" (1784) defined it as humanity's emergence from a self-incurred immaturity, *selbstverschuldete Unmündigkeit*, and took as its motto Horace's *Sapere aude*. Lovecraft's axiom recodes immaturity as asylum and the limit of understanding as the last shelter of the species; it is the counter-Enlightenment compressed into a single period. Yet the paradox that makes the tale a narrative rather than a homily is that it consists entirely in the violation of its own premise. Thurston correlates. He assembles the clay bas-relief and the notes of his grand-uncle George Gammell Angell, professor of Semitic languages at Brown; the dream-record of the young sculptor Henry Anthony Wilcox, whose visions cluster between 1 March and 2 April 1925; the testimony of Inspector John Raymond Legrasse concerning a raid on a Louisiana swamp-cult in 1907, presented at the 1908 meeting of the American Archaeological Society in St. Louis, where it is matched by Professor William Channing Webb's account of a Greenland rite observed nearly half a century earlier; a cutting from an Australian newspaper; and the manuscript of the Norwegian sailor Gustaf Johansen, obtained in Oslo from his widow. Three continents, two decades, five media, a single pattern. The tale is a *reductio ad horrorem*: it proves the axiom by deriving the catastrophe that follows from its negation.

A second coordinate is fixed before the first sentence is reached. The tale's epigraph, from Algernon Blackwood's *The Centaur* (1911), proposes that of certain great powers or beings "there may be conceivably a survival" from an epoch immensely remote, remembered by poetry and legend under the names of gods and monsters. The paratext thus establishes two axes: *survival*, the diachronic persistence of the archaic into the present, and *correlation*, the synchronic binding of the dispersed into a pattern. The Mythos is the field these axes generate, and the second governs the first, for a survival becomes horrifying only when correlated: the Greenland rite and the Louisiana rite are curiosities apart and a revelation together. Criticism has, with few exceptions, attended to what correlation discloses (an indifferent cosmos, intelligences older than life on Earth, the insignificance of the species) rather than to correlation itself. This thesis wagers that the form of the disclosure is the secret of the thing disclosed, and the decisive evidence is comparative. The

Epicurean universe of Lucretius was as infinite, as godless, and as indifferent to human concerns as Lovecraft's, and it was offered as consolation: *De rerum natura* undertakes to dispel the terror of the gods by demonstrating that nothing exists but atoms and void, and it promises to the one who understands this the untroubled calm of *ataraxia*. The contents of the two cosmologies are nearly identical; their affects are antithetical. What differs is the mode of access. Lucretius gives the universe as doctrine, deduced and taught; Lovecraft gives it as evidence, assembled and suffered. The materialist cosmos consoles when it is taught and annihilates when it is found out. Cosmic horror, on this account, is not a property of the cosmos but a property of a relation to it: the relation of a correlator to a pattern that he completes and that does not contain him.

1.2 The Object of Study: Corpus, Protocol, Afterlife

"Cthulhu Mythos" is not Lovecraft's phrase. In his letters he spoke facetiously of "Yog-Sothothery" and of "Cthulhuism," and he received with polite ambivalence August Derleth's proposal, made during his lifetime, to call the whole the Mythology of Hastur, remarking that his gradually accreting theogony owed more to Machen and Dunsany than to the Bierce–Chambers line from which Hastur descends. The designation that prevailed was popularized by Derleth in the years after Lovecraft's death in Providence on 15 March 1937. The act of naming was itself a correlation, binding a heterogeneous body of tales composed between 1917 and 1935 under a single sign, and the sign chosen was telling. It privileges the most anthropomorphic and theologically legible of Lovecraft's entities, a winged and tentacled priest-god who sleeps, dreams, is worshipped, and will wake, over the more radical figures of the corpus: Azathoth, the blind idiot god who seethes at the centre of infinity; the Colour, which is not demonstrably a being at all; the Great Race of Yith, which is less a pantheon than a historiography. The name was already a domestication.

The corpus has a core and three surrounding strata. The core is a sequence of tales running from "Dagon" (1917) and "The Nameless City" (1921) through "The Festival" (1923), "The Call of Cthulhu" (1926), "The Colour Out of Space" (1927), and "The Dunwich Horror" (1928) to the great late works: "The Whisperer in Darkness" (1930), *At the Mountains of Madness* (1931), "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1931), "The Dreams in the Witch House" (1932), "The Thing on the Doorstep" (1933), "The Shadow out of Time" (1934–35), and "The Haunter of the Dark" (1935). The first surrounding stratum is the Dunsanian "Dream Cycle," which followed Lovecraft's discovery of Lord Dunsany in 1919 (he heard Dunsany lecture in Boston that October) and culminated in *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath* (1926–27), whose geography of Leng and Kadath, whose Pnakotic Manuscripts,

and whose messenger Nyarlathotep interpenetrate the Mythos so thoroughly that any strict separation of the cycles is a critical convenience. The second is the body of revisions and ghost-writings, among them "The Curse of Yig" and "The Mound" for Zealia Bishop, "Out of the Aeons" for Hazel Heald, and "The Diary of Alonzo Typer" for William Lumley, in which Lovecraft's cosmology is often developed with a freedom his signed work did not permit. The third is the essays, above all "Supernatural Horror in Literature" (1925–27), together with a correspondence of almost unparalleled volume, conducted with a circle of writers who repaid Lovecraft's inventions in kind. Clark Ashton Smith contributed Tsathoggua and the *Book of Eibon*; Robert E. Howard, von Junzt's *Unaussprechlichen Kulten*; Frank Belknap Long, the Hounds of Tindalos; Robert Bloch, Ludvig Prinn's *De Vermis Mysteriis*; Henry Kuttner, further tomes and deities. Each writer cited the others' inventions as though they were independent attestations, so that the fictitious books acquired the appearance of a bibliography and the invented gods the appearance of a comparative religion. The Mythos is in this sense the first modern mythology composed by post: a distributed mythopoeia whose infrastructure was the postal service, the amateur press associations in which Lovecraft served his apprenticeship, and the pulp magazines, and whose method was the manufacture of corroboration.

Derleth then redacted what he had preserved. Having founded Arkham House with Donald Wandrei in 1939 in order to bring Lovecraft into hard covers, he reorganized the cosmology in his own fiction and commentary. He installed a dualism of benign Elder Gods and rebellious Great Old Ones, imprisoned after a war in heaven and awaiting release. He distributed the Old Ones among the four classical elements (Cthulhu to water, Hastur to air, Nyarlathotep to earth, and, to fill a vacancy that Lovecraft had never perceived, the invented Cthugha to fire), a scheme codified with the help of Francis T. Laney's glossary of 1942. And he propagated, as Lovecraft's own summary of his fiction, a statement grounding the whole in the expulsion of an elder race for the practice of black magic. That statement derived not from Lovecraft but from a recollection supplied to Derleth by Harold S. Farnese; Richard L. Tierney's "The Derleth Mythos" (1972) laid bare the larger distortion, and David E. Schultz (1987) demonstrated the quotation's apocryphal character. The redaction converted a mechanistic cosmos into a theodicy with a Miltonic plot of rebellion, fall, and promised return. In the vocabulary of Harold Bloom's *The Anxiety of Influence* (1973) it was a *clinamen*, a swerve, and the irony of Bloom's term is exact, since he borrowed it from Lucretius, for whom the *clinamen* was the minute, uncaused deviation of falling atoms. The materialist swerve of matter became, in the Mythos's first great misprision, the theological swerve of a redactor.

The restoration that followed, led in the 1970s by Dirk W. Mosig and Tierney and consolidated by S. T. Joshi's corrected texts and philosophical biography, disen-

tangled Lovecraft from Derleth, while Robert M. Price, founding *Crypt of Cthulhu* in 1981, brought the instruments of biblical criticism to bear on the Mythos's development. The analogy can be pressed further than polemic usually allows. The Mythos has passed through every phase of scriptural formation: an archaic stratum of prophetic texts (Lovecraft), a redactional stratum that harmonized them into a theology (Derleth), a scholarly recovery of the sources against the redaction (Joshi), a proliferating apocrypha (pastiche), a liturgy (role-playing scenarios and occult rites), and a heterodox commentary (philosophy and counter-fiction). Like scripture, it is less a text than a process of textualization.

This thesis accordingly uses "Mythos" in three senses held together. As *corpus*, the term designates the texts Lovecraft wrote, revised, or co-authored, read in Joshi's editions. As *protocol*, it designates a generative grammar, closer to a programming language than to a canon, consisting of recombinable names; citable books; a fictive New England of Arkham, Dunwich, Innsmouth, and Kingsport that readers came to call "Lovecraft Country"; characteristic time-scales measured in hundreds of millions of years; and characteristic procedures, from the scholarly narrator and the documentary frame to the deferred revelation and the final sentence in which the last datum clicks into place. Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale*, published in Leningrad in the same year as "The Call of Cthulhu," showed that the wondertale is generated by a finite set of functions; the Mythos is a deliberately engineered system of such functions, designed for extension by others. As *afterlife*, finally, the term designates the transmedial formation that has grown from the protocol: Derleth's continuations, Chaosium's role-playing game (1981) and its descendants, cinema and television, video games, music, occult practice, and network folklore. The three are treated here as a single correlative system, and the formulation on which much of what follows depends can be stated at once. The Mythos is the first modern mythology whose principle of extension is the very operation its stories represent as catastrophic. Every pastiche correlates; the Mythos grows by doing what it forbids.

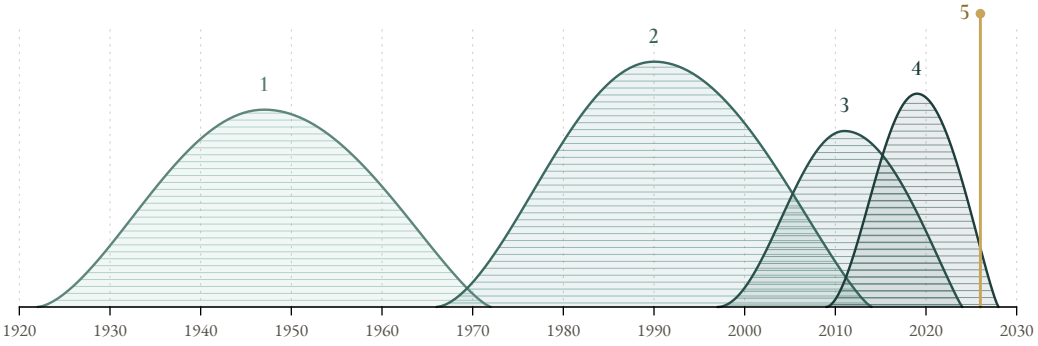
1.3 Four Waves of Reception and the Missing Operation

The first wave of reception, extending from the founding of *Weird Tales* in 1923 to the consolidation of the Arkham House canon in the 1960s, was conducted largely within the institutions of the pulps and of fandom. Lovecraft's lifetime readership was that of *Weird Tales* under Farnsworth Wright, who rejected *At the Mountains of Madness* in 1931, and of *Astounding Stories*, which printed that novel in an editorially truncated form in 1936. The mainstream verdict was delivered by Edmund Wilson in *The New Yorker* in November 1945: Wilson ridiculed the adjectival machinery of the tales, dismissed them as hack-work, and conceded merit only to the critical essay

on supernatural horror. The decisive counter-statement came from within the genre. Fritz Leiber's "A Literary Copernicus" (1949) argued that Lovecraft had moved the focus of supernatural horror away from humanity and its local world, gods and devils included, toward the cosmos at large: the stars and the black gulfs between them. Leiber's metaphor is the seed of the present argument, for it raises a question he did not pose. If Lovecraft is a Copernicus, which Ptolemy did he dethrone? Section 1.4 proposes an answer. Lovecraft's European afterlife, meanwhile, took a course of its own. In France, Jacques Bergier, who claimed to have corresponded with Lovecraft, and Louis Pauwels enrolled him in the "fantastic realism" of *Le Matin des magiciens* (1960), a founding text of the counter-cultural occultism that would read the fiction as veiled disclosure. Borges, dedicating "There Are More Things" (1975) to Lovecraft's memory while confessing in the same volume that he regarded him as an involuntary parodist of Poe, registered the ambivalence of the great master of the imaginary library toward its most lurid practitioner.

A second wave of philological and biographical recovery followed. Its landmarks are Maurice Lévy's *Lovecraft ou du fantastique* (1972), the dismantling of the Derleth Mythos by Tierney and Mosig, Barton Levi St. Armand's *The Roots of Horror in the Fiction of H. P. Lovecraft* (1977), Donald R. Burleson's deconstructive *Lovecraft: Disturbing the Universe* (1990), and the work of Joshi, whose corrected texts (1984–89), whose *H. P. Lovecraft: The Decline of the West* (1990), and whose biographies (1996; expanded as *I Am Providence*, 2010) made Lovecraft legible as a coherent thinker: a mechanistic materialist, an atheist, a cosmicist, and a political conservative who turned, late and partially, toward the socialism of the New Deal. The journals *Lovecraft Studies* (1979–2005) and *Lovecraft Annual* (from 2007) institutionalized the field. The achievement of this wave is beyond question; its limitation is methodological. The doctrine reconstructed from the letters tends to function as a key that unlocks the fiction, as though the tales illustrated positions independently established. But the letters can state cosmic indifference with equanimity, while the tales make it unbearable, and the difference between enunciation and enactment is precisely the difference that correlation makes. A doctrinal reading has no place for it. Michel Houellebecq's *H. P. Lovecraft: Contre le monde, contre la vie* (1991) stands athwart this wave as a novelist's polemic. It presents Lovecraft as a writer who refused realism, money, and sexuality wholesale, and it finds the catalyst of the great tales in the racial hatred that crystallized during his years in New York. Houellebecq's merit is to have refused the cordon sanitaire between the style and the hatred. His defect is to have treated the hatred as an aesthetic stimulant rather than as an epistemic structure, which is what Chapter 6 will argue it was.

A philosophical turn began with the workshop on "Speculative Realism" held at Goldsmiths, University of London, on 27 April 2007, at which Ray Brassier, Iain



1 Pulp and fandom

1923 *Weird Tales* founded
1945 Wilson
1949 Leiber
1960 *Le Matin des magiciens*

2 Philology

1972 Lévy, *Lovecraft*
1984 Joshi's texts
1990 Burleson; Joshi
1991 Houellebecq

3 Philosophy

2007 Goldsmiths workshop
2008 *Collapse* IV
2011 Thacker
2012 Harman, *Weird Realism*

4 Politics

2011 Okorafor
2014 Emrys
2016 LaValle; Ruff; Haraway
2020 Jemisin; HBO

5 The operation A fifth-wave reading (2026): correlation, the act of disclosure shared by doctrine, ontology, affect and politics

1.1 *Four waves of reception.* The reception of the Mythos as overlapping waves, with landmarks from each: pulp and fandom, from the founding of *Weird Tales* in 1923 to the 1960s; philological and biographical recovery, from 1972; the philosophical turn, from 2007; and the critical and political wave, from 2011. The present reading, operational rather than doctrinal, ontological, affective or political, counts itself a fifth (section 1.3).

Hamilton Grant, Graham Harman, and Quentin Meillassoux, divided on most questions, shared a hostility to the post-Kantian restriction of philosophy to the human access to being. Lovecraft became, almost at once, the movement's literary patron. The fourth volume of the journal *Collapse* (2008), devoted to "Concept Horror," included Harman's essay on Lovecraft and Husserl and China Miéville's "M. R. James and the Quantum Vampire," which coined the *abcanny* to name the Weird's irruption of the radically unprecedented, as against the hauntological return of the repressed. Harman's *Weird Realism* (2012) read Lovecraft as a writer of gaps: a vertical gap between an object and the qualities through which it is allusively approached, and a horizontal, cubist gap in which an object dissolves into a surfeit of qualities. Eugene Thacker's *In the Dust of This Planet* (2011) defined horror as the paradoxical thought of the unthinkable world-without-us, distinct from both the world-for-us and the world-in-itself. Brassier's *Nihil Unbound* (2007), Reza Negarestani's *Cyclonopedia* (2008), Ben Woodard's *Slime Dynamics* (2012), Dylan Trigg's *The Thing* (2014), and Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) extended the conversation, as did Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* (2010), which revived Peter Wessel Zapffe's "The Last Messiah" (1933) as the charter of a pessimism in which consciousness itself is the catastrophe. The prehistory of this turn lies in the

Cybernetic Culture Research Unit at Warwick in the late 1990s, where Nick Land and his collaborators treated Lovecraft as a precursor of "hyperstition," fictions that operate causally to bring about their own reality. Its popular crest was the first season of *True Detective* (2014), whose writer acknowledged debts to Ligotti, Brassier, and Thacker. The merit of this wave is to have read Lovecraft as an interlocutor of philosophy rather than its illustration. Its limitation is a kind of philosophical extractivism, in which the tales are mined for allegories of an ontology and their politics bracketed as noise. Strangest of all, a movement that made "correlationism" its principal adversary never thematized the fact that the Mythos's founding sentence names correlation as the thing from which we must be spared.

The fourth wave, critical and political, is conventionally dated from Nnedi Okorafor's reflection in 2011 on receiving the World Fantasy Award in the form of a bust of a writer whose letters and early verse expressed contempt for Black people; a public campaign followed, and in 2015 the award's administrators retired the bust. The wave's most consequential productions have been fictional rather than critical. Ruthanna Emrys's "The Litany of Earth" (2014) and *Winter Tide* (2017) reimagine the survivors of Innsmouth as an interned and dispossessed people. Victor LaValle's *The Ballad of Black Tom* (2016) rewrites "The Horror at Red Hook" from within the Black Harlem that Lovecraft's tale could perceive only as a swarm. Matt Ruff's *Lovecraft Country* (2016) and its HBO adaptation (2020) superimpose the cosmic terror of the Mythos upon the documented terror of Jim Crow; Rivers Solomon's *The Deep* (2019) extends the Afro-diasporic mythology of Drexciya; and N. K. Jemisin's *The City We Became* (2020) casts a Lovecraftian intelligence as the enemy of a living, polyglot New York. Feminist readings have attended to the scarcity and monstrosity of women in the corpus, from Lavinia Whateley, the instrumentalized mother of Yog-Sothoth's twins, to Asenath Waite, whose body is occupied by her father; queer readings to the homosocial cloisters of Miskatonic University; disability studies to madness as the corpus's habitual telos; ecocriticism to the Mythos's planetary scale. Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) exemplifies the ambivalence of the last of these: it borrows the chthonic resonance of the name for its "Chthulucene" while expressly refusing Lovecraft's monster, taking its emblem instead from the spider *Pimoa cthulhu* and marking the difference in its spelling. Jeff and Ann VanderMeer's anthology *The Weird* (2011) meanwhile recentred the genre internationally, demoting Lovecraft from founder to node. The merit of this wave is to have ended apologia and to have demonstrated, in practice, the generativity of contestation. Its critical limitation, though not its fictional one, is a tendency to treat cosmicism as a mask for racism, whereas the counter-fictions themselves typically preserve cosmic scale and redirect it. Here the fiction is ahead of the criticism.

Four waves have thus produced four registers: doctrine, ontology, affect, and politics. Each has isolated its object with great sophistication, and none has thematized the operation the four objects share. That operation is correlation. It is correlation that turns doctrine into narrative, since what the letters assert the tales assemble; that turns ontology into experience, since the in-itself becomes horrifying only when it is pieced together from evidence; that turns affect into knowledge, since Thacker's horror of philosophy is the affect of a thought that completes itself against itself; and that turns fear of the cosmos into fear of the crowd, since both are fears of being bound into a pattern authored elsewhere. In this taxonomy the present thesis is a fifth-wave reading. It is operational rather than doctrinal, ontological, affective, or political, because it locates the coherence of the Mythos not in what is disclosed but in the act of disclosure, and it claims that once the act is understood the four registers prove to be one.

1.4 A Genealogy of Correlation

The concept to which Lovecraft's sentence appeals has a history of at least five strata, each of which the Mythos activates. The first is logical. In the seventh chapter of the *Categories*, Aristotle treats *ta pros ti*, things whose being consists in being said of something else: the double and the half, knowledge and the knowable, perception and the perceptible, master and slave. Such correlatives reciprocate, so that the slave is said to be slave of a master and the master master of a slave. From its earliest articulation, correlation named the logic of terms that exist only through one another, and it numbered domination among its paradigm cases. The scholastic doctrine of *correlativa* preserved the structure, and Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) set it in motion. The point is not antiquarian. The Mythos teems with relations of servitude that are correlations in Aristotle's strict sense, defined entirely by the asymmetry of their terms: shoggoth and Elder Thing, cultist and Old One, the Mi-Go and the human agents they suborn, and, in the corpus's racial imaginary, the "mongrel" labouring bodies of its port cities and the patrician scholars who catalogue them.

The second stratum is transcendental. For Kant, experience is constituted by the correlation of intuition and concept, a synthesis neither can perform alone: *Gedanken ohne Inhalt sind leer, Anschauungen ohne Begriffe sind blind* (A51/B75). In the preface to the second edition of the *Critique of Pure Reason* (1787), Kant likened his hypothesis that objects must conform to our cognition, rather than our cognition to objects, to the procedure of Copernicus (Bxvi). Meillassoux has argued that the comparison inverts the truth. Kant's revolution is in fact a Ptolemaic counter-revolution, recentring the cosmos on the transcendental subject at the very moment

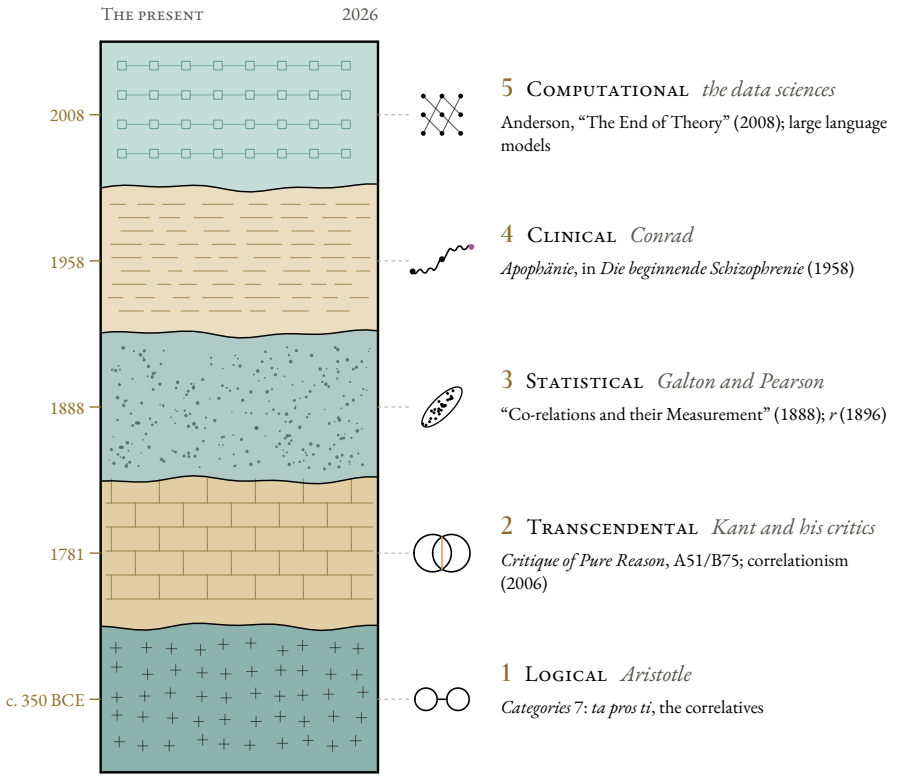
the sciences were decentring it (Meillassoux 2008 [2006], ch. 5). The resulting position, which Meillassoux names *correlationism*, holds that we only ever have access to the correlation of thinking and being, never to either term considered apart from the other. Its stumbling-block is what he calls the *arche-fossil*: the material trace of a reality anterior to all life and thought, such as the isotopic evidence that dates the accretion of the Earth to roughly 4.56 billion years ago, which the sciences state literally and which correlationism must reinterpret as a past that exists only for us. Lovecraft's late fiction is a literature of arche-fossils. The Antarctic expedition of *At the Mountains of Madness* dissects organisms preserved in strata of inconceivable age and then walks the streets of the city those organisms built; Nathaniel Wingate Peaslee, in "The Shadow out of Time," descends into the archive of a species that flourished some 150 million years before the present. Leiber's metaphor thereby acquires a precise philosophical sense. Lovecraft is the Copernicus of the Ptolemaic counter-revolution: he completes in narrative the decentring that Kant's critical philosophy reversed. His anti-Kantianism does not take the form of a refutation, since he never argues that the in-itself is accessible; it takes the form of a narration of what it would be for that access to occur.

A distinction must nonetheless be drawn here, for it is the hinge of everything that follows. Lovecraft's correlation is in the first instance intra-mental: the mind's binding of its own "contents," its knowledges, records, and memories. Meillassoux's correlation is the transcendental binding of mind to world. The Mythos stages the moment at which the first, pushed toward totality, ruptures the second. When the mind correlates all of its contents, it arrives at contents that testify to a world prior to it, indifferent to it, and capable of continuing without it, so that the arche-fossil appears as the sum of the evidence. The intra-mental synthesis, carried to completion, detonates the transcendental one. This is why Lovecraft's sentence and Meillassoux's term converge on the same word without meaning quite the same thing, and why the critical project and the Mythos are mirror-images of each other. Kant secured the peace of reason by restricting knowledge to the bounds of possible experience. Lovecraft calls that restriction mercy and tells the story of its failure.

The third stratum is statistical, and it is the one criticism has almost entirely overlooked. Correlation entered the sciences as a quantitative concept in Francis Galton's paper "Co-relations and their Measurement, chiefly from Anthropometric Data," read before the Royal Society in 1888, which established the measure by comparing, across hundreds of subjects examined in Galton's anthropometric laboratory, the length of the forearm with stature and other bodily dimensions. Galton had coined the word "eugenics" five years earlier, and *Hereditary Genius* (1869) had already proposed to read the destiny of lineages in statistical aggregates. Karl Pearson formalized the product-moment coefficient in 1896, became the first Galton Professor of

Eugenics at University College London in 1911, and argued in the third edition of *The Grammar of Science* (1911) that causation is merely the limiting case of correlation. Statistical correlation was born, in short, as an instrument for reading heredity in bodies, for detecting through measurement what a bloodline carries. Lovecraft's genealogical tales are correlation-horror in this exact Galtonian sense. In "Facts Concerning the Late Arthur Jermyn and His Family" (1920), a portrait, a locket, and a stuffed white ape are correlated into an origin that drives the last of the line to set himself alight. In "The Rats in the Walls" (1923), the restorer of Exham Priory traces the de la Poer lineage downward through the strata of the building's foundations to a cannibal cult, and his speech regresses through the historical strata of language as he descends. *The Case of Charles Dexter Ward* (1927) turns on the physical identity of a young antiquarian with the portrait of his necromantic ancestor. In "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1931), the unnamed narrator (called Robert Olmstead only in Lovecraft's notes) pursues his ancestry through family papers and local records and then reads its conclusion in his own face. In each case the protagonist assembles documents, portraits, deeds, and physiognomic resemblances, and correlates himself into a lineage that annuls him. The racial horror is not an addition to the cosmic horror; it is the same operation applied to the body. "Correlation is not causation" is a methodological prudence that statistics learned late. For Galton and Pearson, as for Lovecraft's narrators, correlation was destiny.

The fourth stratum is clinical. In *Die beginnende Schizophrenie* (1958), Klaus Conrad coined *Apophänie*, apophany, for the unmotivated perception of connections accompanied by a specific experience of abnormal meaningfulness, and described a course that runs from a prodromal tension he called *trema*, the actor's stage fright, through the apophanic phase itself to a phase he named, without irony, *apocalypse*. Conrad located the core disturbance in a loss of *Überstieg*, the capacity to step beyond one's own standpoint and see oneself as one among others, a loss he figured in explicitly Copernican terms: the patient who suffers it is thrown back into a Ptolemaic world in which every event refers to the self. Lovecraft's narrators undergo an inverted apophany. They correlate everything and discover that nothing refers to them. Two madnesses may therefore be distinguished, a Ptolemaic paranoia for which everything concerns me and a Copernican horror for which nothing does, and the Mythos is the literature that makes them collide. Wilcox and Angell are singled out by dreams; the Innsmouth narrator is, in a sense, elected by his blood; Peaslee, in the most vertiginous scene of the corpus, finds among the records of the Great Race a document written in his own hand. The cosmos addresses him personally, which is the Ptolemaic signal par excellence, and it addresses him as an entry in someone else's catalogue, which is the Copernican humiliation par excellence. Richard Hofstadter's "The Paranoid Style in American Politics" (1964) and Thomas Pynchon's alternation, in *Gravity's*



1.2 *The five strata of correlation.* Correlation as a logical form (Aristotle), a transcendental structure (Kant and his critics), a statistical instrument of heredity (Galton and Pearson), a clinical syndrome (Conrad) and a computational paradigm (the data sciences), drawn as a geological section with the oldest stratum at its base (section 1.4).

Rainbow (1973), between the terror that everything is connected and the terror that nothing is, map a territory Lovecraft had already crossed. His narrators occupy the impossible synthesis of the two terrors: everything is connected, and the connection is not for us. The iconography of the evidence wall, its photographs joined by red string, descends from Thurston's study through *The X-Files* and *True Detective* into the conspiracy cultures of the networked present.

The fifth stratum is computational. In "The End of Theory" (2008), Chris Anderson announced in *Wired* that the deluge of data had rendered the scientific method obsolete: given enough data, correlation supersedes causation, models become dispensable, and the numbers speak for themselves. The subsequent ascendancy of machine learning, culminating in large language models trained to predict the next token across the accumulated textual archive of the species, has realized

something close to Anderson's prophecy. The piecing together of dissociated knowledge is now an engineering discipline, conducted at planetary scale through the layered apparatus Benjamin Bratton has called the Stack, and sold as a service. Yet the starkest contemporary realization of Lovecraft's sentence is scientific rather than commercial. The climate science synthesized since 1988 by the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change is structurally a Thurstonian enterprise. It pieces together dissociated knowledges (ice cores, ocean heat content, atmospheric chemistry, glaciology, palaeoecology) into a single picture of our position, and that picture is terrifying in precisely the sense the sentence intends. The two responses the sentence predicts, madness from the revelation and flight into the peace and safety of a new dark age, describe with uncomfortable accuracy the two dominant cultural responses to that picture: a despair that pathologizes knowledge, and a denial that retreats from it.

Correlation is, in sum, a logical form (Aristotle), a transcendental structure (Kant and his critics), a statistical instrument of heredity (Galton and Pearson), a clinical syndrome (Conrad), and a computational paradigm (the data sciences). Lovecraft's sentence condenses all five; the Mythos dramatizes each; and the history of its reception has distributed them across separate disciplines and separate waves, as though in obedience to the very mercy the sentence describes.

1.5 Correlative Horror: Definition, Distinctions, Corollaries

The concept toward which this genealogy has been moving may now be stated formally.

> *Correlative horror is the affect that attends a finite intelligence's completion of a pattern whose completion annuls the centrality of the intelligence that completes it.*

Three features distinguish it. It is *performative*: the subject is the author of his own horror, which arrives not as an assault from without but as the conclusion of his own inference, so that Lovecraft's narrators are undone less by monsters than by their own competence. It is *retroactive*: the completed pattern reorganizes everything that preceded it, converting dreams, clippings, and family resemblances into evidence, so that the typical Lovecraftian narrative is written after the fact by a narrator rereading his history in the light of its terminus. And it is *self-implicating*: the subject discovers himself not as the author of the pattern but as one of its elements, not as the reader of the archive but as an entry in it.

Narrative form follows from these features with something like necessity. The narrator is a scholar, a scientist, an antiquarian, or a student, because only a professional correlator possesses both the competence to complete the pattern and the training that forbids him to refuse its conclusion. The text is a dossier: a manuscript found among papers, a statement made to the police, a report addressed to future expeditions, a testament composed in anticipation of suicide or metamorphosis. Revelation is deferred, not to manufacture suspense in the ordinary sense, but because correlation is cumulative and its threshold is reached only at the end. The final sentence, frequently set in italics, is the typographic signature of a pattern closing: the instant at which the last datum clicks into place and the narrator, and the reader with him, can no longer unsee the whole.

Correlative horror can be specified further by contrast with the concepts through which the uncanny, the terrible, and the sublime have been theorized. Ann Radcliffe's "On the Supernatural in Poetry" (1826) distinguished terror, which "expands the soul," from horror, which "contracts, freezes, and nearly annihilates" the faculties. Lovecraftian horror is Radcliffean horror produced by the expansion of a faculty: the understanding enlarges itself toward totality, and the enlargement annihilates it. Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) located the sublime in a terror enjoyed at a safe distance; correlative horror abolishes the distance, since the observer discovers that he stands inside the scene he has been observing. Kant's *Critique of the Power of Judgment* (1790) distinguished a mathematical sublime, in which magnitude defeats the imagination and reason's idea of totality rescues the subject, from a dynamical sublime, in which nature's might is surmounted by the subject's awareness of a moral vocation independent of nature. In Lovecraft the rescuing faculty is the destroying one. It is precisely reason's demand to grasp the whole that undoes the subject, and no moral vocation survives the discovery that value is a local accident of a minor species. Correlative horror is the Kantian sublime with its rescue inverted.

The remaining distinctions can be drawn more briefly. Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919) traced the uncanny to the return of something familiar that had been repressed; correlative horror is the arrival of the never-familiar through the familiar, whether a student's clay bas-relief, a provincial newspaper, or a family portrait. Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) theorized abjection as the collapse of the boundary between self and other; correlative horror is the collapse of the boundary between scales, the moment at which the human scale of meaning is shown to be continuous with scales on which it does not register. Rudolf Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) described the numinous as a *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* before the wholly other, *das ganz Andere*; correlative horror retains the *tremendum* and the *fascinans* and subtracts the holy, leaving the wholly other without holiness. Fisher defined the weird as that which does not belong and the eerie as a failure of absence or of presence;

correlative horror is the moment at which the weird discloses that it does belong, to an order in which we do not. Miéville's abcanny names the irruption of the radically new; correlative horror is the epistemic mechanism by which the abcanny arrives, not as an apparition but as a conclusion.

Lovecraft's own theory requires a corresponding correction. "Supernatural Horror in Literature" opens by declaring fear the oldest and strongest of human emotions and "the oldest and strongest kind of fear" to be "fear of the unknown," and it locates the essence of the weird tale in an atmosphere of dread before unknown forces and in a malign suspension of the natural laws that are our only defence against chaos and "the daemons of unplumbed space." The mature tales do not bear this out. In them horror attaches not to the unknown but to the newly known, to comprehension rather than to its absence. The unknown is the condition of mercy; the known is the catastrophe. Here lies the decisive difference between the Mythos and its Gothic inheritance. The Gothic revelation discloses a secret about the subject, whether a crime, an incest, or a usurped inheritance, as in Walpole, Radcliffe, Lewis, and Maturin. The Lovecraftian revelation discloses no secret about the subject except that the subject is not the subject of the revelation. Even the genealogical tales, which look most Gothic, translate the Gothic secret into a non-Gothic register: what they uncover is not a transgression but a classification, a species, a lineage, a taxonomic fact.

From the definition seven corollaries follow, each of which organizes a chapter of what follows.

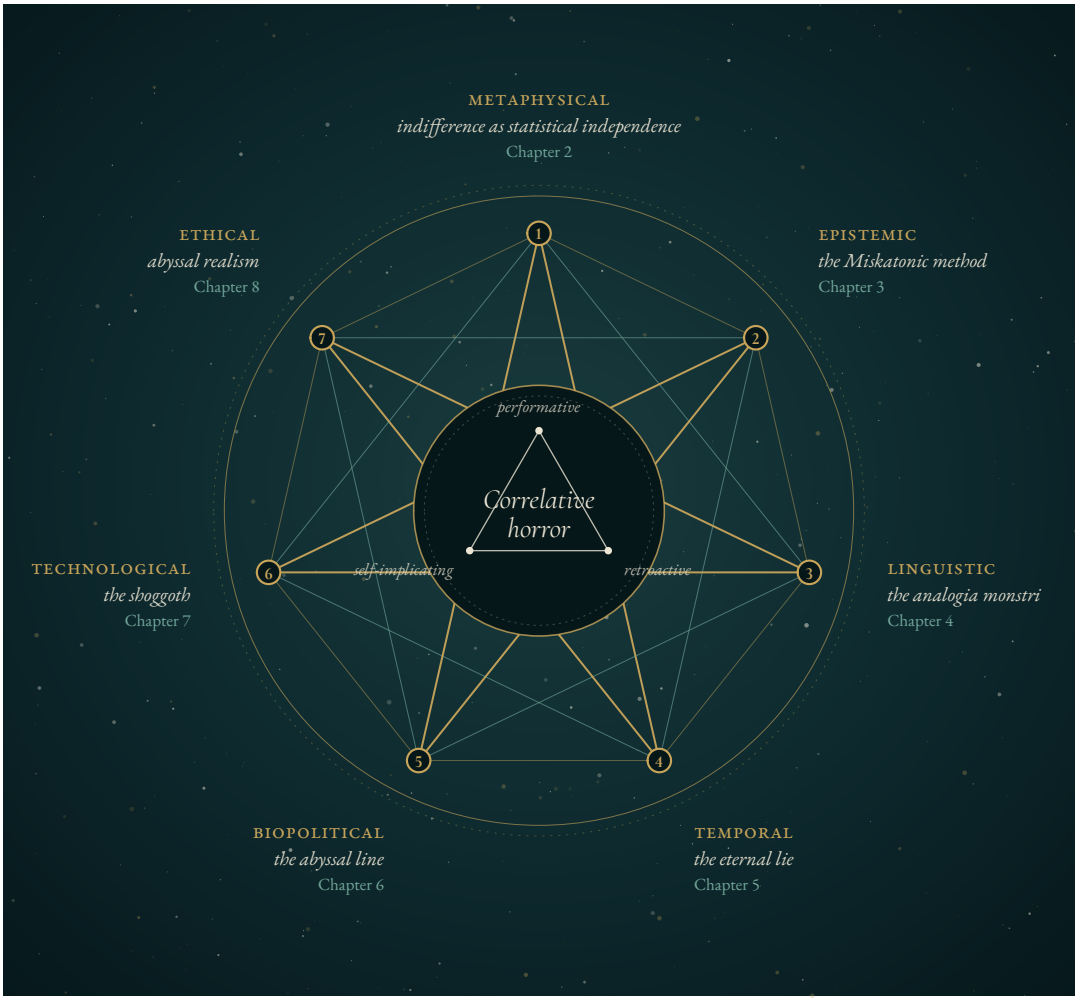
- *Corollary 1 (metaphysical): indifference is statistical independence.* The cosmos of the Mythos is neither hostile, which would require a negative correlation between events and human value and therefore a perverse providence of the Gnostic, Manichaean, or Derlethian kind, nor benevolent, which would require a positive one. It is uncorrelated. This is the exact content of Lovecraft's insistence, in his letters, that he was not a pessimist but an indifferentist: pessimism posits a correlation with a negative sign, while indifferentism posits none (Chapter 2).
- *Corollary 2 (epistemic): the Miskatonic method.* Science and paranoia share the operation of correlation, and the Mythos stages the point at which they can no longer be told apart, since the procedures of the antiquarian, the folklorist, the geologist, and the philologist lead, without methodological error, to conclusions indistinguishable from delusion (Chapter 3).
- *Corollary 3 (linguistic): the analogia monstri.* At the limit of correlation, language proceeds by composite and avowedly failing analogy, as in a sculpture that suggests at once "an octopus, a dragon, and a human caricature," or a hue that could be called a colour "only by analogy" (Chapter 4).

- *Corollary 4 (temporal): the eternal lie.* Deep time is a correlation of strata, and the archaic survives within it as that which can "eternal lie": both what lies dormant without dying and what persists as a fiction that cannot be retracted (Chapter 5).
- *Corollary 5 (biopolitical): the abyssal line.* Genealogical correlation transposes cosmic horror into racial horror, and the cosmic Outside proves to be the colonial line dividing the visible from the invisible world, projected onto the stars (Chapter 6).
- *Corollary 6 (technological): the shoggoth.* Correlation without interiority is mimesis, and the shoggoth is its emblem: a servitor that correlates its masters' sounds into a voice and their forms into its own, and learns from them how to rebel (Chapter 7).
- *Corollary 7 (ethical): abyssal realism.* The mercy of the opening sentence can be reconstructed not as ignorance but as opacity, that is, as a mode of relation that preserves the uncorrelated as uncorrelated (Chapter 8).

Beyond Apologia and Indictment: The Dialectic of Correlation 1.6

Since the fourth wave, discussion of Lovecraft has polarized around two positions that share a premise despite their mutual hostility. The apologetic position separates a philosophy (cosmicism, materialism, the decentring of the human) from a prejudice (racism, xenophobia, a horror of the body), treats the latter as the contingent residue of a period and a class, and preserves the former for philosophical use. The indicting position reverses the hierarchy, reading the cosmic as a sublimation of the racial and the stars as a screen onto which a fear of immigrants and of Black Americans was projected; in its crudest form, which Houellebecq's provocation invited, cosmicism is racism with a telescope. Both positions presuppose that metaphysics and politics are separable layers of the corpus, one of which may be declared the truth of the other.

The *Dialectic of Enlightenment* of Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno (1944; 1947) supplies the means to refuse that premise. Its central thesis, that myth is already enlightenment and that enlightenment reverts to mythology, is accompanied by a diagnosis of enlightenment's motive. Enlightenment, they argue, is mythic fear radicalized: nothing is permitted to remain outside, because the very idea of an outside is the source of fear. The Mythos is the literary form of this dialectic, and it preceded the dialectic's philosophical statement by almost two decades. It is a mythology composed by a mechanistic materialist in order to dramatize the consequences of mechanistic materialism, an enlightenment become myth; and its Outside, Lovecraft's own term for the exterior of human cognition and its correlates, names precisely the remainder that enlightenment's totalizing correlation sought to abolish and therefore produced in monstrous form. Horkheimer and Adorno read



1.3 *Correlative horror and its seven corollaries.* The definition at the centre, with its three features, performative, retroactive and self-implicating; at the points of the heptagram, the seven corollaries that organize Chapters 2 to 8 (section 1.5).

Odysseus, lashed to the mast so that he may hear the Sirens without succumbing, as the prototype of the bourgeois subject who survives myth by cunning. Lovecraft's narrators are failed Odysseuses: the bonds that should protect them, method, discipline, and scholarship, are the very means by which they hear the song.

If the dialectic is taken seriously, the cosmicism and the racism of the corpus appear as two outcomes of a single structure. The fear of the cosmos and the fear of the crowd are one fear at two scales: the fear of being correlated into a pattern authored elsewhere, in which the subject figures as a term rather than a centre. The rhetoric of the New York tales makes the identity audible. In "The Horror at Red Hook" (1925), the immigrant neighbourhoods of Brooklyn are rendered in the lexicon of swarming,

polyglot, abyssal multiplicity that the corpus elsewhere reserves for the Outside. In "He" (1925), a vision of New York's future is a vision of racial inundation. In "The Call of Cthulhu," the doctrine of the Great Old Ones is expounded by Old Castro, an aged mestizo, in the same section that describes the Louisiana celebrants as "mixed-blooded" and mentally aberrant. The stars and the streets are not metaphors for one another. They are two scales at which a single operation, correlation without centrality, produces a single affect.

Lovecraft's own response to this structure was what criticism has called his aesthetic traditionalism: an attachment to inherited forms, Georgian architecture, the colonial landscape of New England, the cadences of eighteenth-century prose, as the only available ground of value in a cosmos that supplies none. Philosophically, it is a strategy of local re-correlation, restoring meaning at the scale at which meaning can be inherited rather than discovered. Aesthetically, it succeeds. In "The Silver Key" (1926), Randolph Carter recovers the lost significance of things by returning to the scenes of his childhood, and at the close of *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath* Nyarlathotep himself reveals that the marvellous sunset city Carter has pursued across the dreamlands is composed of nothing but his memories of the New England he loved in youth. Ethically, it fails, because the enclave of inherited value is policed by blood, and the scale at which meaning can be inherited becomes the scale at which strangers must be excluded. This thesis therefore neither purifies cosmicism of its racism nor dissolves it into racism. It shows both to be outcomes of one correlative structure and asks whether a third outcome is possible. Its answer, developed in Chapter 8, is abyssal realism, whose ethical form is prefigured by the most ambivalent ending in the corpus: the resolve of the Innsmouth narrator, in the tale's final paragraph, to free his confined cousin and swim with him to Y'ha-nthlei, where they will dwell "amidst wonder and glory for ever."

Method: A Constellational Comparatism 1.7

A thesis about correlation is itself an act of correlation and must answer for the horror it studies. The danger is not merely rhetorical. A comparative study that ranges across every medium risks becoming a total theory of the Lovecraftian, which is to say a *Necronomicon*: a compendium so complete that every entry confirms the pattern and none can contradict it. The method adopted here is therefore constellational, after the formula Walter Benjamin gave in the epistemo-critical prologue to *Ursprung des deutschen Trauerspiels*, published in 1928, the year in which "The Call of Cthulhu" reached print: *Die Ideen verhalten sich zu den Dingen wie die Sternbilder zu den Sternen*, ideas are to things as constellations are to stars. A constellation correlates without totalizing. Its stars remain light-years apart; the figure exists only from a

situated standpoint; its unity is legible without being substantial. The cosmology of the Mythos is itself constellational, for the Old Ones return not when a cause has operated but "when the stars were right," when a configuration holds. The comparisons that follow are configurations, not equivalences. Job is not Lovecraft, *Solaris* is not "Lovecraftian," and *Bloodborne* is not an adaptation. Each comparison is held at the distance at which it becomes legible and abandoned at the distance at which it would harden into an identity.

The comparative field is correspondingly wide. In literature it extends from the Gothic and the Decadent through the weird tale, the scientific romance, pulp science fiction, and the New Weird to contemporary Afro-diasporic and Indigenous speculative fiction. In philosophy it runs from Presocratic atomism to speculative realism, cosmic pessimism, and decolonial thought. In scripture and myth it includes Job and the Psalms, Hesiod's *Theogony*, the *Enūma Eliš*, the Nag Hammadi codices, Purāṇic cosmology, and the Eddic poems. In cinema and television it takes in John Carpenter, Andrei Tarkovsky, Alex Garland, and Richard Stanley, together with *True Detective* and *Lovecraft Country*; in games, Chaosium's *Call of Cthulhu*, *Eternal Darkness*, *Bloodborne*, *Darkest Dungeon*, *Sunless Sea*, and *Dredge*; in music, a lineage running from heavy metal's Lovecraftian instrumentals to funeral doom, drone, and the micropolyphony of György Ligeti; in the visual arts, Gustave Doré, John Martin, Odilon Redon, H. R. Giger, Zdzisław Beksiński, and Junji Ito; in occultism, Kenneth Grant, Anton LaVey and Michael Aquino, the Simon *Necronomicon*, and chaos magic; and in network folklore, creepypasta, the SCP Foundation, and the Backrooms. A media-archaeological attention, indebted to Friedrich Kittler's *Grammophon Film Typewriter* (1986), is directed at the media of correlation within the tales themselves: press cuttings and telegrams, the photograph that closes "Pickman's Model," the phonograph recording of "The Whisperer in Darkness," and the typescripts, diaries, and letters through which every revelation is transmitted.

A principle of evidence completes the method. The thesis distinguishes throughout between Lovecraft's documented convictions, as stated in letters and essays; the convictions of his narrators, which are dramatic and frequently unreliable; and the effects of his texts, which exceed both. The letters are treated as evidence of doctrine but not as keys that lock the fiction shut, in keeping with the caution of W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley's "The Intentional Fallacy" (1946) though without its formalist austerity, since the biographical and historical record is indispensable to any account of what the corpus correlates, and why.

The Architecture of the Argument 1.8

Chapter 2, "A Mechanistic Cosmos," reconstructs the philosophical and aesthetic genealogy of Lovecraft's indifferentism: the atomism of Democritus, Epicurus, and Lucretius, whose consolatory materialism serves as the chapter's foil; the dread that the infinite universe of Copernicus and Bruno provoked in Pascal; the Darwinian decentring as it reached Lovecraft through Huxley, Haeckel's *Die Welträtsel* (1899), and Hugh Elliot's *Modern Science and Materialism* (1919), whose uniformity of law and denial of teleology he adopted; his selective appropriations of Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, and Spengler; his anxious reception of Riemann's geometry, Charles Howard Hinton's hyperspace, and the physics of Einstein and Planck; and the literary lineage running from Poe's doctrine of unity of effect and the cosmology of *Eureka* (1848) through Machen, Dunsany, Blackwood, Chambers, and William Hope Hodgson to the Augustan prose ideal Lovecraft never abandoned. It formalizes indifferentism as statistical independence, reads aesthetic traditionalism as a local re-correlation of value, and measures both against Bertrand Russell's "A Free Man's Worship" (1903), Zapffe, Camus, Ligotti, Brassier, and Jean-François Lyotard's meditation on the death of the sun.

Chapter 3, "The Miskatonic Method," examines the epistemology of forbidden knowledge. It situates the *Necronomicon* within the history of interdicted knowing from Eden, Prometheus, and Faust to Frankenstein, and within the tradition of the imaginary library from Borges's Babel and Tlön to Umberto Eco's labyrinthine abbey; analyses the documentary form of the tales and the convergence of inference and apophany; and reads "From Beyond" (1920) through Jakob von Uexküll's *Umwelt* and Gerhard Vollmer's "mesocosm," the band of scales to which human cognition is adapted and which Tillinghast's resonator dissolves by machine. It treats the archive of the Great Race as the figure of a subject discovering itself as specimen, and closes with Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* and *His Master's Voice*, the Strugatskys' *Roadside Picnic*, Jeff VanderMeer's Southern Reach, found-footage cinema, and the SCP Foundation.

Chapter 4, "Analogia Monstri," turns to language, the sublime, and theology. Beginning from the controversy over Lovecraft's adjectives, it reconsiders Burke, Kant, and Otto; reads the vocabulary of the unnamable against the apophatic tradition of Pseudo-Dionysius, Meister Eckhart, and Nicholas of Cusa; and argues that "The Colour Out of Space" stages the collapse of the scholastic *analogia entis*, which Erich Przywara defended and Karl Barth denounced, and its replacement by an *analogia monstri*. It reads Azathoth against the ignorant demiurge of the *Apocryphon of John*, whom Gnostic sources also name Samael, "god of the blind," and against Hans Jonas's account of Gnostic acosmism, as the deity of a Gnosticism without a pleroma:

no light beyond the prison, no spark within the prisoner. It treats the tentacle as teratological sign, the tongues of R'lyeh and Aklo as xenoglossia, and the cults of the Old Ones as worship without reciprocity, after Marcel Mauss on the gift and Georges Bataille on sovereign expenditure; its comparisons run from the Book of Job and Kafka's Odradek to Ito's *Uzumaki*, Ligeti's *Atmosphères*, and the "Insight" mechanic of *Bloodborne*.

Chapter 5, "The Eternal Lie," concerns time. It sets the Mythos's deep time within the geology of Hutton and Lyell and the thermodynamics of Kelvin, and its cults within E. B. Tylor's anthropology of survivals and its successors, James Frazer's *The Golden Bough* and Margaret Murray's *The Witch-Cult in Western Europe*, both of which "The Call of Cthulhu" names among Professor Angell's sources. It compares the Mythos's imprisoned elders and recurrent catastrophes with Hesiod's Titans, Tiamat in the *Enūma Eliš*, the Purāṇic *yugas*, Ragnarök, and Spengler's morphology of cultures; reads the couplet "That is not dead which can eternal lie" through Emmanuel Levinas's horror of the *il y a* and Aby Warburg's *Nachleben*; and follows the lie into the occult afterlives in which a fictional grimoire acquired real editions and practitioners. It concludes with the nuclear semiotics of the Human Interference Task Force, including Thomas Sebeok's proposal of an "atomic priesthood," as the Mythos applied: an attempt to warn the inhabitants of a remote future about a buried thing that must not be disturbed.

Chapter 6, "The Abyssal Line," addresses race, heredity, and empire without euphemism. It documents Lovecraft's racism from the early verse and letters to the New York tales written in the shadow of the Immigration Act of 1924; situates it within degeneration theory and eugenics; reads the corpus through Stephen Arata's "reverse colonization," John Rieder's colonial fantasies of reversal, the "boomerang" of Aimé Césaire and Hannah Arendt, and Frantz Fanon's phobogenic object; and advances its central claim, that the cosmic Outside is Santos's abyssal line projected onto the stars. It considers Lavinia Whateley, Shub-Niggurath, and Asenath Waite through Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine, and ends with the counter-mythos, from Drexciya and Okorafor's *Lagoon* (2014) to LaValle, Ruff, Emrys, Jemisin, and Solomon, and with Kyle Powys Whyte's reminder that, for Indigenous peoples, the end of the world has already happened.

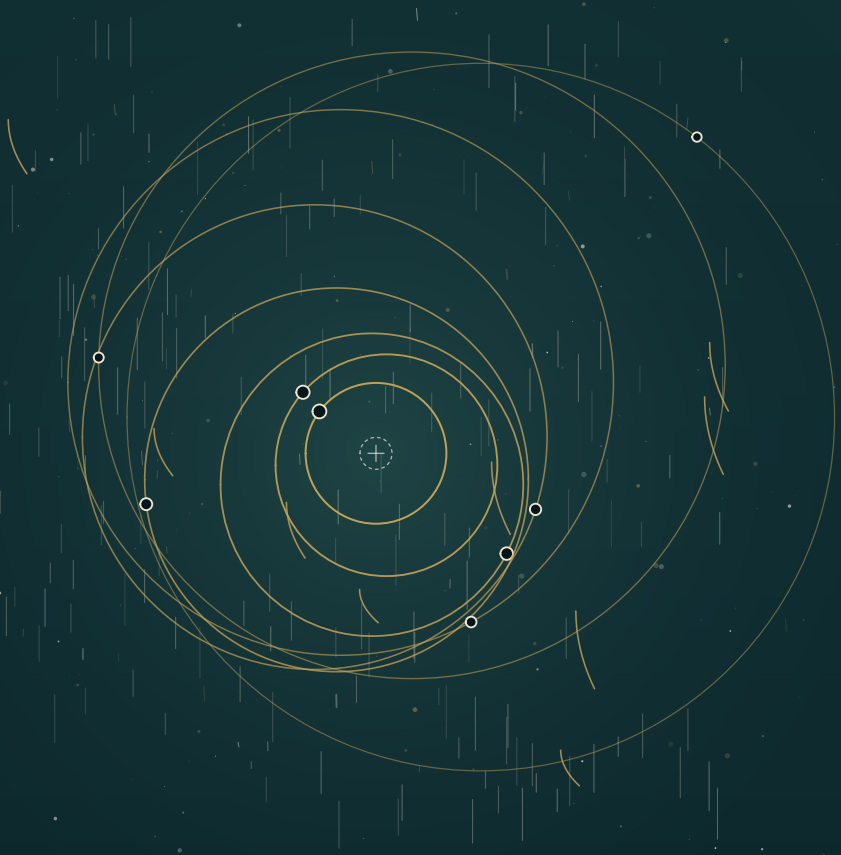
Chapter 7, "Tekeli-li," concerns mimesis and servitude. It reads the shoggoths of *At the Mountains of Madness*, protoplasmic labourers who learn to imitate their makers' piping and then rise against them, together with the genealogy of their cry, which Lovecraft took from Poe's *Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym* (1838). It sets them beside Plato on mimesis, Benjamin on the mimetic faculty, and Roger Caillois on the organism's dissolution into space; beside the golem, Gershom Scholem's 1965 address on the computer at Rehovot, Karel Čapek's robots, Samuel Butler's

machines, and Norbert Wiener; and beside the disembodied brains of the Mi-Go and the mind-exchanges of the Great Race. It examines the shoggoth's adoption as an emblem in recent discourse on artificial intelligence, and reads the Mythos itself, in its pastiches, games, and plush toys, as a shoggothic corpus that has outgrown its maker, with the help of Sianne Ngai's analysis of the cute as an aesthetic of powerlessness.

Chapter 8, "Abyssal Realism," draws the argument together. It maps correlationism, speculative realism, cosmic pessimism, and dark ecology as responses to correlative horror; brings Harman's withdrawal into dialogue with Glissant's opacity; sets Levinas's ethics of the face against the faceless night-gaunts of Lovecraft's childhood nightmares; weighs Haraway's Chthulucene and Timothy Morton's hyperobjects; reads the rising of R'lyeh against the rising sea and Amitav Ghosh's *The Great Derangement* (2016); and formulates a right to be uncorrelated for an age of planetary computation. Its final movement relocates the ethical centre of the Mythos to Y'ha-nthlei and rereads the opening sentence as a maxim: the real is what remains uncorrelated within every relation, and the highest relation is the one that preserves the uncorrelated as such.

The argument begins, then, where Lovecraft's sentence ends: in the narrow interval between the mercy of not knowing and the catastrophe of knowing all, where the question ceases to be whether to correlate and becomes how to relate to what refuses correlation.

Chapter Two



A Mechanistic Cosmos

The Philosophical and Aesthetic Genealogy of Lovecraftian Indifferentism

Suave, mari magno turbantibus aequora ventis,
e terra magnum alterius spectare laborem.

Lucretius, *De rerum natura* II.1–2

The metaphysical register

Chapter Two

A Mechanistic Cosmos

This chapter reconstructs the sources from which Lovecraft assembled his cosmos and argues that he took from each its description of the world and never its consolation. From ancient atomism, the infinite universe of the early moderns, Darwinian biology, German philosophies of will and decline, the new geometry and physics, and a literary lineage running from Poe to Hodgson, he composed a doctrine that can be stated with unusual precision: human value and cosmic process are statistically independent. The chapter then examines the ethics Lovecraft built on that doctrine, a local re-correlation of value through inherited tradition, and measures both against the principal twentieth-century responses to the same cosmos.

2.1 The Atomist Inheritance: Democritus, Epicurus, Lucretius

Lovecraft understood himself as the heir of a philosophical lineage older than Christianity. His first theology, by his own retrospective account, was a childish paganism assembled from Bulfinch's *Age of Fable* and the Garth translation of Ovid, which led him at seven or eight to raise altars to Pan and Apollo and to half-believe that he had glimpsed fauns in the Rhode Island woods. Its successor was astronomy: between 1903 and 1907 the adolescent Lovecraft hectographed his own *Rhode Island Journal of Astronomy*, and for years afterward he contributed astronomical columns to provincial newspapers. The telescope was his first instrument of correlation, and what it disclosed confirmed the mechanistic materialism he set out in "Idealism and Materialism: A Reflection" (1919) and in the polemical letters later collected as "In Defence of Dagon" (1921), and which he traced to Democritus, Epicurus, and Lucretius. The genealogy is not decorative. It furnishes the standard against which Lovecraft's divergence can be measured, because the ancient atomists drew from premises almost identical to his conclusions opposite in affect.

Democritus of Abdera bequeathed two fragments that the Mythos might take as epigraphs. The first, preserved by Galen, divides the world into what exists by convention and what exists in reality: *nomōi chroiē, nomōi glyku, nomōi pikron, eteēi de atoma*

kai kenon, by convention colour, by convention sweet, by convention bitter, in reality atoms and void (DK 68 B125). The second, preserved by Diogenes Laertius, draws the epistemological consequence: *eteēi de ouden idmen; en bythōi gar hē alētheia*, in reality we know nothing, for truth lies in the depths (DK 68 B117). The first fragment is the ancestor of the distinction between secondary and primary qualities that runs through Galileo and Locke into the scientific image Lovecraft absorbed, and it is worth pausing over the fact that colour heads its list of conventions. "The Colour Out of Space" (1927) stages precisely the arrival of a colour that is not *nomōi*: a hue belonging to the real rather than to the conventions of the human sensorium, which can therefore be named only by analogy. The second fragment supplies, two and a half millennia early, both the topography of the Mythos and the motto of this thesis's conclusion. Truth is in the *bythos*, the abyss or deep, a word that Valentinian Gnosticism would later make the name of its unknowable first principle (Chapter 4). Democritus locates truth where Lovecraft locates R'lyeh and Y'ha-nthlei: beneath the surface on which the senses and their conventions float.

Epicurus converted Democritean physics into a therapy. His gods exist, but they dwell in the spaces between the worlds, the *metakosmia* that Cicero rendered as *intermundia* (*De natura deorum* I.18), in a blessedness that no human petition can disturb and no human misfortune can concern; and his fourfold remedy, as Philodemus summarized it, teaches that god is not to be feared, death is not to be felt, the good is easily obtained, and the terrible easily endured. Every term of the remedy is inverted in the Mythos. The Old Ones are to be feared, though not as gods; death is far from the worst that can befall a human being in a corpus crowded with possession, body-exchange, and living brains preserved in metal cylinders; the good is not given but laboriously constructed and easily lost; and the terrible is precisely what cannot be endured. The most striking correspondence, however, is topological. The *Necronomicon* passage quoted in "The Dunwich Horror" (1928) places the Old Ones exactly where Epicurus placed his gods, "Not in the spaces we know, but between them," and adds that there they walk "serene and primal." Lovecraft retained the Epicurean geography of the divine, the indifference of its inhabitants, and even their serenity. What he subtracted was the serenity of those who contemplate them. Epicurean theology was a pedagogy of imitation, in which the sage modelled his tranquillity on the gods' untroubled bliss; the serenity of the Old Ones is inimitable, and it communicates itself to human beings only as dread.

It was Lucretius who gave the atomist cosmos its literary form, and the form is the point. *De rerum natura* opens its argument with a heroic narrative: a Greek was the first mortal who dared to raise his eyes against religion, burst the bolts of nature's gates, passed beyond the *flammantia moenia mundi*, the flaming ramparts of the world, traversed the immeasurable whole in mind and spirit (*omne immensum pera-*

gravit mente animoque), and returned victorious to report what can come to be and what cannot (I.62–79). Here, in the first century before the common era, is the voyage into the Outside, undertaken by a mind and completed by a return. Lovecraft's narrators make the same journey and do not come back intact. The difference lies not in what is found beyond the ramparts, which in both cases is an infinite and godless plurality of worlds, but in what the finding does to the finder, and Lucretius specifies the condition of his consolation in the most famous image of his second book. It is sweet, he writes, when winds whip the waters of the great sea, to watch from the land another's great struggle, not because another's suffering pleases, but because it is sweet to see from what evils one is free (II.1–4). Philosophy, on this account, is the shore. Hans Blumenberg's *Schiffbruch mit Zuschauer* (1979) traced this image of shipwreck with a spectator across European thought and showed how modernity eroded the spectator's ground, until in Pascal's *vous êtes embarqué* and in Nietzsche's announcement that we have left the land and taken to the ships there is no shore left to stand on. Lovecraft's opening paragraph belongs to the end of this history. The "placid island of ignorance" amid black seas of infinity is the Lucretian shore in its last form, and it is secured no longer by knowledge but only by knowledge's absence.

A further difference concerns the population of the infinite. Lucretius taught that other earths bear other races of men and other kinds of beasts (II.1048–1076), but his plurality is a plurality of analogues, made of the same atoms under the same laws and populated by beings recognizably like ourselves. Lovecraft's is a plurality of incommensurables. His infinite is not empty of rivals but crowded with them, older, more capable, and more numerous than humanity, so that the Epicurean inference from the indifference of the gods to the tranquillity of the sage loses its middle term: the Lucretian cosmos is indifferent because nothing in it is interested in us, the Lovecraftian cosmos although a great deal in it is interested, as a naturalist is interested in insects. Lucretius also derived religion from fear and from ignorance of causes (V.1161–1240), a genealogy that Statius would compress into the formula *primus in orbe deos fecit timor*, fear first made gods in the world. The opening chapter of "Supernatural Horror in Literature" rehearses the same genealogy, deriving religious feeling from primitive dread of the unknown, and draws from it the opposite moral. Lucretius explained fear in order to dissolve it; Lovecraft explained it in order to cultivate it as the raw material of an art. The Mythos is Lucretian physics with the therapy removed and the symptom preserved as an aesthetic resource.

2.2 Infinite Spaces: Copernicus, Bruno, Pascal

The closed cosmos that Lucretius had breached in imagination was dismantled in fact between Copernicus's *De revolutionibus* (1543) and the reception of Newton,

and Alexandre Koyré's *From the Closed World to the Infinite Universe* (1957) remains the classic account of the cost. Freud, in 1917, numbered the Copernican revolution first among three great blows (*Kränkungen*) to human narcissism, the biological blow being Darwin's and the psychological his own. The Mythos consolidates all three into a single injury and adds a fourth, an axiological blow, by which value is shown to be as provincial as the Earth, as contingent as the species, and as little master in its own house as the ego. What the infinite universe meant affectively, however, was never settled, and its first century produced a spectrum of responses that the Mythos would compress into one.

At one pole stands Giordano Bruno, whose *De l'infinito, universo e mondi* (1584) proclaimed an infinite universe of innumerable inhabited worlds and whose reward, in the Campo de' Fiori on 17 February 1600, was the stake. Bruno experienced the infinite as exaltation, and in *De gli eroici furori* (1585) he gave that exaltation its emblem in the myth of Actaeon: the hunter who pursues the goddess through the forest, beholds her naked at her bath, and is transformed into a stag and torn apart by his own hounds. For Bruno the allegory is triumphant. The hunter is the intellect, the goddess divine truth, the hounds the hunter's own thoughts, and to be devoured by them is to be transfigured, the pursuer becoming the pursued and the knower dissolving into what is known. No figure in early modern philosophy more exactly anticipates the Lovecraftian scholar, who also pursues a truth that ought not to be seen naked and is also destroyed by nothing but his own correlations. Lovecraft retains every element of Bruno's allegory except its sign. Actaeon is still devoured by his thoughts; the devouring is no longer apotheosis.

At the other pole stands Pascal. The fragment that supplied this thesis's first epigraph, his confession that the eternal silence of infinite spaces frightens him (L. 201), is only the most compressed of his meditations on the new cosmos, and the most important for the Mythos is the longer fragment on the *disproportion de l'homme* (L. 199). There Pascal places the human being between the infinitely great and the infinitely small, a nothing with respect to the infinite and an all with respect to nothing, *un milieu entre rien et tout*, incapable of grasping either extreme and condemned to despair of ever knowing their principle or their end. The concept that Chapter 3 will develop under Gerhard Vollmer's name of the mesocosm, the narrow band of scales to which human cognition is adapted, is already present here, together with its affect. Pascal's countervailing consolation matters as much, because it is the one the Mythos specifically revokes. Man is a reed, the feeblest thing in nature, but a thinking reed (L. 200): the universe can crush him with a vapour, yet he remains nobler than what kills him, because he knows that he dies and the universe knows nothing of its advantage. The Lovecraftian universe knows. It contains intelligences that have catalogued the human species, studied its history, inhabited its bodies, and

archived its records, and the dignity Pascal reserved for human consciousness as the one knower in an unknowing cosmos is annulled by the discovery that we are not the only reeds that think, nor the most capable, nor the oldest. Pascal's God remained a *Deus absconditus* (Isaiah 45:15), and Lucien Goldmann's *Le Dieu caché* (1955) made that hiddenness the key to a tragic vision. In the Mythos the hiddenness survives the death of God and is repopulated: what is hidden is no longer God but the gods, and their concealment is not a trial of faith but a mercy.

Between ecstasy and dread lay the urbane domestication of the infinite, epitomized by Fontenelle's *Entretiens sur la pluralité des mondes* (1686), which conducted a marquise through the inhabited planets as through the salons of a galant evening. The genre had a speculative undercurrent that leads more directly to Lovecraft. Kepler's posthumous *Somnium* (1634) imagined lunar organisms adapted to monstrous extremes of heat and cold, and Kant's *Allgemeine Naturgeschichte und Theorie des Himmels* (1755), in a section of his pre-critical cosmology seldom read today, proposed that the perfection of rational beings increases with their distance from the Sun, so that the inhabitants of Jupiter and Saturn surpass us as we surpass those of Mercury. Kant's hierarchy of planetary minds finds its terminus in Yuggoth, the outermost world from which the Mi-Go of "The Whisperer in Darkness" (1930) descend, and which Lovecraft identified with the newly discovered Pluto in the very months of the tale's composition. The Romantic response was Giacomo Leopardi's. His "L'infinito" (1819) ends in a shipwreck that is sweet, *il naufragar m'è dolce in questo mare*, so that the Lucretian spectator now consents to drown; and his "Dialogo della Natura e di un Islandese" (1824) is the most exact statement of cosmic indifference in European literature before Lovecraft. A wanderer who has fled Nature's persecutions across the globe confronts her at last in the African interior and demands to know why she torments him. Nature answers that she never had the human race in view and would not notice if she extinguished it; the dialogue ends with the Icelander devoured by lions or, in an alternative that Leopardi supplies with sardonic equanimity, buried by a sandstorm and mummified for a European museum. Leopardi's Nature, the stepmother (*matrigna*) of "La ginestra" (1836), is the Old Ones' nearest ancestor in the century before the Mythos, and she differs from them in a single respect: she can still be addressed.

The Mythos does not choose among these responses; it superimposes them. Lovecraft's narrators feel Pascal's dread and Bruno's fascination at once, often within a sentence, and Lovecraft himself, the boy astronomer who never lost his love of the night sky, embodied the conjunction. The epistemic position of the Mythos is Pascal's *milieu* without Pascal's God; its affective position is Bruno's *furor* without Bruno's apotheosis; its rhetorical position is Fontenelle's guided tour, conducted by a guide who has gone mad. What unifies the composite is the problem of scale. Every

response to the infinite universe was a response to the discovery that the human being occupies a middle position that cannot be generalized, and the Mythos is the first literature to make that discovery not a premise of argument but an event in a life.

The Darwinian Decentring: Huxley, Haeckel, and Hugh Elliot's Mechanism 2.3

If the Copernican revolution displaced humanity in space, the Darwinian displaced it in time and in kind, and it reached Lovecraft less through Darwin than through Darwin's most combative interpreters. *On the Origin of Species* (1859) closed by finding "grandeur in this view of life," and the Victorian reception divided over whether that grandeur could be felt. Tennyson had already voiced the opposite feeling in *In Memoriam* (1850), written under the shadow of Lyell's geology, where Nature, "red in tooth and claw," answers the hope that she is at least careful of the species with the cry that a thousand types are gone and that she cares for nothing: "all shall go." Lovecraft's position within this emotional range is best located through three figures: Thomas Henry Huxley, Ernst Haeckel, and the now obscure Hugh Elliot.

Huxley supplied a substance and a moral structure. His lecture "On the Physical Basis of Life" (1868) scandalized its Edinburgh audience by declaring protoplasm the common matter of every living thing, and in the same year he gave the name *Bathybius haeckelii* to a substance dredged from the floor of the North Atlantic, believing it to be a sheet of primordial living slime carpeting the abyss. The chemist of the *Challenger* expedition showed that it was a precipitate produced by the alcohol in which the samples had been preserved, and Huxley withdrew it in 1875; but for several years Victorian science believed that the deep ocean was lined with formless, living protoplasm, and the phantom's name joined the Greek *bathys*, the deep, to that of the century's great monist. The shoggoths of *At the Mountains of Madness*, protoplasmic, formless, endlessly plastic, and found at the bottom of the world, are the literary afterlife of *Bathybius*. The moral structure came later. In "Evolution and Ethics," his Romanes Lecture of 1893, Huxley set the ethical process against the cosmic process and argued that the ethical progress of society depends neither on imitating nature nor on fleeing it, but "in combating it." The "Prolegomena" of 1894 made the garden the governing image, an artificial order wrested from the state of nature and sustained only by unceasing labour, and then extended the image, tellingly, to a colony planted in a new land, imagining even an administrator as far above the colonists as they are above their cattle, before rejecting the programme of human breeding such a being might impose. Lovecraft's ethics, as section 2.8 shows, is a Huxleyan garden, an enclave of value cultivated against the cosmic process; and

Huxley's colonial extension of the metaphor marks, already in 1894, the point at which a garden becomes a border.

Haeckel supplied a cosmology and a morphology. *Die Welträtsel* (1899), which Lovecraft read as *The Riddle of the Universe*, proclaimed a monism in which matter and energy are attributes of a single substance under a universal law of substance, and in which soul, freedom, and immortality dissolve into physiology. Haeckel's biogenetic law, that ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny, gave the Mythos its most persistent model of the self: an organism that carries its species' history within it and may, under pressure, run that history backward. The descent of the narrator of "The Rats in the Walls" through the strata of Exham Priory, during which his speech regresses through Middle English, Latin, and Gaelic to animal noise, is recapitulation in reverse, as is the devolution of the Martense family into subterranean anthropoids in "The Lurking Fear" (1922). Haeckel's other gift was visual. The plates of *Kunstformen der Natur* (1899–1904) presented radiolarians, siphonophores, medusae, and echinoderms as an alien ornament, a catalogue of radial symmetries and translucent architectures that taught a generation what the non-human might look like; the barrel-bodied, five-fold, star-headed Elder Things of *At the Mountains of Madness* are Haeckel's plates animated and given a civilization. Haeckel's monism, finally, was inseparable from a racial taxonomy that ranked human populations on an evolutionary scale and fed German eugenics through the Monist League he founded in 1906. In Haeckel the materialism and the racism that Lovecraft inherited share a single root, which Chapter 6 will trace.

Hugh Elliot's *Modern Science and Materialism* (1919) gave these materials doctrinal form. Joshi has shown how closely Lovecraft's mature philosophy follows Elliot's three principles: the uniformity of law, by which every event is the necessary consequence of antecedent events; the denial of teleology, by which nature has no purposes; and the denial of any mode of existence not envisaged by physics and chemistry. The third principle explains a feature of the Mythos often misdescribed. Lovecraft's entities are not supernatural. They are natural beings of unfamiliar physics, organisms of matter in unfamiliar states, inhabitants of dimensions that mathematics permits and perception does not reach. The Mythos is a supernatural literature written under a materialist's ban on the supernatural, and its horror derives from the fact that nothing in it violates the laws of nature, only the expectations of a species. The second principle explains the Mythos's most audacious inversion of natural theology. William Paley's *Natural Theology* (1802) inferred a benevolent designer from the contrivance of organisms, as one infers a watchmaker from a watch. *At the Mountains of Madness* reveals that terrestrial life does have designers, the Elder Things, whose biotechnology produced its first cells; but the fragmentary lore its narrators recall holds that the Old Ones made earthly life as a joke or by mistake.

Design is conceded and providence denied. Lovecraft grants Paley his watchmaker and removes every reason for gratitude.

Lovecraft's Darwinism, then, is neither Darwin's grandeur nor Tennyson's grief. It is Huxley's garden without Huxley's confidence, Haeckel's monism without Haeckel's religion of nature, and Elliot's mechanism made narratable. Its distinctive contribution is to extend the decentring from origin to destination. Darwin had shown that humanity was not the purpose of the history of life; the Mythos adds that it is not the culmination either, since the archive of the Great Race records a history of the Earth that continues after us, the planet passing to a hardy beetle-like species before it passes to the cold. Evolution, which the Victorian imagination still pictured as a ladder with humanity at its summit, becomes in Lovecraft a corridor through which humanity is merely passing.

Will, Value, Decline: Schopenhauer, Nietzsche, Spengler 2.4

The German philosophical tradition supplied Lovecraft less with doctrines than with moods, and its three most important representatives in his reading share a single structure: each pairs a disenchanted account of the world with a redemptive or affirmative counter-movement, and in each case Lovecraft accepted the account and declined the redemption. Schopenhauer's *Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung* (1818; expanded 1844) taught that the world of representation is the objectification of a blind, insatiable, purposeless striving, the Will, which is the inner nature of everything and the source of all suffering. Against Leibniz he argued that ours is the worst of all possible worlds, the one only just able to persist (II, ch. 46), and he found deliverance only in aesthetic contemplation, which suspends the Will for a moment, and in the ascetic denial of the will-to-live, which extinguishes it. Lovecraft, who read Schopenhauer with sympathy, rejected both the metaphysics and the soteriology: he was a materialist, not a voluntarist, and he insisted that he was no pessimist. Yet the deepest image of the Mythos is Schopenhauerian. At the centre of infinity, in the tales from *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath* to "The Haunter of the Dark," churns Azathoth, the blind idiot god, a mindless energy about which amorphous dancers revolve to the monotonous piping of flutes. Schopenhauer held that music, unlike the other arts, is not a copy of the Ideas but an immediate copy of the Will itself (I, §52). Azathoth is the Will given a body and an orchestra: blind striving at the core of being, attended by the one art that copies it directly. And the music is idiot music. The *harmonia mundi* of the Pythagoreans, which Kepler's *Harmonices Mundi* (1619) had sought in the ratios of planetary motion, has become the piping of a mindless court. The music of the spheres has become the music of the void.

Nietzsche reached Lovecraft in the late 1910s and shaped the anti-democratic aristocratism of his early maturity, recorded in the compilation of his letters published as "Nietzscheism and Realism" (1921). The Nietzsche who matters for the Mythos, however, is not the political Nietzsche Lovecraft first admired but the cosmological one. The posthumously published essay "Über Wahrheit und Lüge im außermoralischen Sinne" (1873) opens with a fable that is the most Lovecraftian paragraph in philosophy before Lovecraft: in some remote corner of a universe poured out in countless glittering solar systems there was once a star on which *kluge Thiere das Erkennen erfanden*, clever animals invented knowing; it was the most arrogant and mendacious minute of world history, but only a minute, for after nature had drawn a few breaths the star grew cold and the clever animals had to die. The fable relativizes knowledge in time as the Copernican revolution had relativized the Earth in space, and its title couples truth with lies, a pairing to which Chapter 5 will return. *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* (1882) supplied the corresponding image of disorientation. In §124 we have left the land and taken to the ships, with no shore behind us; in §125 the madman who announces the death of God asks what we did when we unchained this Earth from its sun, whether we are not plunging continually, whether we are not straying as through an infinite nothing. The death of God is figured, decisively, as an astronomical catastrophe, a Copernican event. Lovecraft accepted the cosmological diagnosis and declined the Nietzschean cure. There is no *amor fati* in the Mythos, no Dionysian affirmation, no Übermensch; and the one place where Nietzsche's language surfaces verbatim is a parody. The cult of Cthulhu teaches that when the Old Ones return, humanity will become like them, "free and wild and beyond good and evil," shouting, killing, and revelling in joy. Nietzsche's transvaluation of values appears in the Mythos only as the eschatology of a swamp-cult: the Übermensch as orgy.

Spengler completed the triad. *Der Untergang des Abendlandes* (1918–22), which Lovecraft read in the late 1920s and found congenial, treated cultures as organisms passing through spring, summer, autumn, and winter, each expressing a unique prime symbol and each hardening in its last phase into a "civilization" of megalopolitan masses, money, and Caesarism. Lovecraft had rehearsed the diagnosis before he read it: "He" (1925) presents New York as a megalopolis in Spenglerian winter, and a lifelong reading of Gibbon had long since taught him to see his own age in the late Roman one. The Spenglerian method enters the Mythos most strikingly, however, at its most alien point. In *At the Mountains of Madness* the explorers reconstruct the history of the Elder Things from the bas-reliefs of their city and date its phases by the evolution of its art, distinguishing the vigour of the earliest carvings from the decadence of the latest. This is morphology of culture in Spengler's sense applied to a nonhuman civilization, the senescence of an alien people read in the decline of its

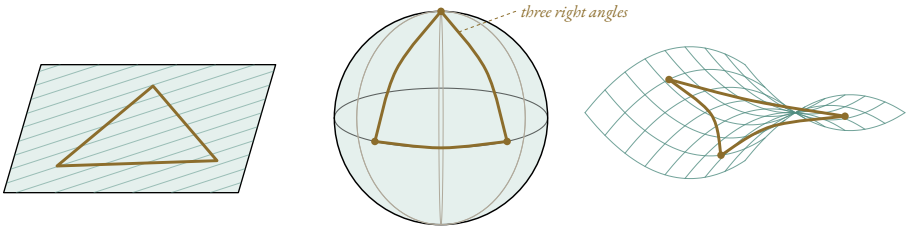
style. The pathos of the scene, which culminates in the narrator's celebrated recognition that the Elder Things, for all their monstrousness, were "men," derives from the Spenglerian insight that every culture, ours included, is a mortal form legible only from outside and only once it has begun to die.

In each of these engagements Lovecraft performs the same operation, which may be called a subtraction of redemption. From Schopenhauer he takes the blind striving at the heart of things and subtracts the quietist deliverance; from Nietzsche he takes the death of God as cosmic disorientation and subtracts the affirmation; from Spengler he takes the mortality of cultures and subtracts the heroic acceptance of destiny that Spengler demanded of the Faustian soul. What remains in each case is a description without an exit, and the Mythos is the narrative form of descriptions without exits. Its horror is not that the world is as these philosophers described it, since they had already said as much, but that the exits they built have been bricked up.

2.5 Non-Euclidean Anxieties: Riemann, Hinton, Einstein, Planck, and the Physics of the Outside

The most characteristic adjective of the Mythos is perhaps "non-Euclidean," and its pedigree is philosophical before it is atmospheric. Kant had held Euclidean geometry to be synthetic a priori knowledge, a necessary truth grounded in the form of spatial intuition. The construction of consistent geometries in which Euclid's parallel postulate fails, by Lobachevsky (1829) and Bolyai (1832), and Riemann's generalization of geometry to curved manifolds of any number of dimensions, in a lecture of 1854 published in 1868, removed the ground from that claim: space need not conform to the form of our intuition, and which geometry the physical world obeys became an empirical question. Hermann von Helmholtz pressed the point in a lecture of 1870 by imagining two-dimensional beings on the surface of a sphere, whose geometry would differ from ours and who could not intuit the dimension that curved their world. When Thurston recalls Wilcox's report that the geometry of his dream-city was "abnormal, non-Euclidean," Lovecraft is therefore invoking not a vague strangeness but a specific defeat of the transcendental aesthetic. The architecture of R'lyeh is anti-Kantian in the sense developed in Chapter 1: it is space that refuses to conform to the forms of human intuition.

Between Riemann and Einstein the fourth dimension became a popular obsession, and Linda Dalrymple Henderson's *The Fourth Dimension and Non-Euclidean Geometry in Modern Art* (1983) has shown how deeply it shaped Cubism, Futurism, and Suprematism. Edwin Abbott's *Flatland* (1884) made the dimensional revelation a parable: its narrator, a Square, is visited by a Sphere, glimpses the third dimension, and is imprisoned for preaching it to a world that cannot conceive it, so that the first



Euclid	Riemann	Lobachevsky, Bolyai
flat; angle sum = 180°	*positive curvature*; angle sum > 180°	*negative curvature*; angle sum < 180°
the plane of Kant's intuition	lecture of 1854, published 1868	1829; 1832

2.1 *Three geometries.* The angle sum of a triangle on a plane (exactly 180°), on a sphere (more than 180°; here three right angles) and on a surface of negative curvature (less than 180°). After Lobachevsky, Bolyai and Riemann, which geometry the world obeys became an empirical question (section 2.5).

great fiction of higher space is already a fiction of correlative horror. Charles Howard Hinton, whose *Scientific Romances* (1884–86) and *A New Era of Thought* (1888) gave the language the word "tesseract," proposed that the mind could be trained by long exercises with coloured cubes to perceive four-dimensional space directly, and P. D. Ouspensky's *Tertium Organum* (1912) and Claude Bragdon's *A Primer of Higher Space* (1913) turned the fourth dimension into a mystical vocation. Lovecraft's late tales are the darkest product of this culture. In "The Dreams in the Witch House" (1932), a Miskatonic student of non-Euclidean calculus and quantum physics learns that the witch Keziah Mason escaped from Salem jail in 1692 through the angles of a room, so that witchcraft proves to be applied topology. In "Through the Gates of the Silver Key" (1932–33), revised from a draft by E. Hoffmann Price, Randolph Carter learns that every three-dimensional being is a section of a higher-dimensional archetype, and that the person he took himself to be is one facet of an entity extending through dimensions he cannot perceive. Hinton promised that higher space could be learned. Lovecraft's narrators learn it, and what they learn is that they are cross-sections.

The confirmation of general relativity by the eclipse expeditions of May 1919, announced in London that November and reported as the overthrow of Newton, troubled Lovecraft more than any other scientific event of his lifetime. His letters of the early 1920s record a genuine fear that relativity had dissolved the fixed natural order on which his materialism rested, an anxiety Joshi has traced through the correspondence; by the end of the decade he had accommodated relativity to mechanism, reasoning that a universe of curved space-time is no less lawful for being

stranger, and had begun to exploit it. Quantum theory posed the sharper challenge, since Heisenberg's indeterminacy relations (1927) seemed to undo the Laplacean determinism that Elliot's uniformity of law presupposed, and popularizers such as Arthur Eddington in *The Nature of the Physical World* (1928) and James Jeans in *The Mysterious Universe* (1930) drew idealist and even theological lessons from the new physics, suggesting that the universe had begun to look less like a machine than like a thought. Lovecraft's materialism absorbed indeterminacy without conceding either: what quantum physics removed was predictability at the smallest scales, not lawfulness, and certainly not purpose. The concession he did make is visible in the fiction, which presents the stability of physical law at the human scale as a local condition, a regional uniformity in a cosmos whose remoter laws may be quite otherwise.

The physics of the Outside follows from that concession, and its signature is the failure of instruments. The Mi-Go of "The Whisperer in Darkness" are visible to the eye but cannot be photographed, because the matter of their bodies, as the tale explains, vibrates at rates foreign to our region of space and leaves no trace on ordinary plates. The meteorite of "The Colour Out of Space" displays, under the spectroscope of Miskatonic's chemists, shining bands that belong to no known element. The second failure is pointed, because spectroscopy was the nineteenth century's paradigmatic instrument of correlation. Auguste Comte had declared in 1835 that the chemical composition of the stars would remain forever unknowable; within a generation Kirchhoff and Bunsen had correlated the dark lines of the solar spectrum with the emission lines of terrestrial elements and read the chemistry of the Sun. The meteorite's spectrum marks the point at which that triumph of correlation fails, and the failure is not ignorance but surplus: the instrument registers something real that the table of elements cannot place. Frank Belknap Long's "The Hounds of Tindalos" (1929), written within Lovecraft's circle, gave this physics its most memorable myth, dividing reality into the curved time in which human beings live and an angular time inhabited by hungry entities that can enter our world only through angles. The Mythos is full of corners for this reason: the angle is where Euclidean space shows its seams.

Because it is a formal property rather than a creature, the non-Euclidean has proved the most transmissible element of the Mythos across media. Its visual genealogy runs from the impossible staircases of Piranesi's *Carceri d'invenzione* (1750; 1761) through the painted, tilted geometries of Robert Wiene's *Das Cabinet des Dr. Caligari* (1920), exactly contemporary with Lovecraft's first mature tales, to M. C. Escher's *Relativity* (1953) and the impossible staircase that Lionel and Roger Penrose described in 1958. It has found its native medium in the video game, where impossible space can be built and traversed rather than described, from the recursive architecture of *Antichamber* (2013) to Remedy Entertainment's *Control* (2019), whose Oldest

House, larger inside than out and administered by a Federal Bureau of Control, fuses Lovecraft's geometry with the bureaucratic containment of the SCP Foundation. What these works share with the Mythos is the conversion of a mathematical possibility into an experiential threat: the discovery that the space in which one moves has properties one's body was not built to read.

2.6 The Aesthetic Lineage: Poe, Machen, Dunsany, Blackwood, Chambers, and the Augustan Ideal

Lovecraft named his own ancestors in "Supernatural Horror in Literature," which devotes a chapter to Poe and closes with "The Modern Masters," Machen, Dunsany, Blackwood, and M. R. James, to whom the revision of 1933–34 added William Hope Hodgson. From Poe he took a poetics and a set of situations. The poetics was the doctrine, stated in the review of Hawthorne (1842) and elaborated in "The Philosophy of Composition" (1846), that a tale should be built backward from a single preconceived effect to which every word contributes; Lovecraft's insistence on unity of atmosphere descends from it, and the structure of correlative horror, in which every datum converges on a terminal revelation, is that doctrine raised to an epistemology. The situations were the found manuscript and the abyss. In "MS. Found in a Bottle" (1833) a narrator aboard a doomed ship records his last observations as it plunges toward the southern pole, aware of hurrying toward "some never-to-be-imparted secret, whose attainment is destruction": the formula of correlative horror, a century early. In *The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym* (1838) the same polar abyss yields the cry "Tekeli-li," which Lovecraft would give to his shoggoths. The instructive contrast is "A Descent into the Maelström" (1841), whose fisherman survives the whirlpool precisely by correlating his observations, noticing that cylindrical objects are drawn down more slowly than others and lashing himself to a cask. In Poe, correlation can still save the observer from the abyss; in Lovecraft, correlation is how the abyss gets in. Poe's *Eureka* (1848), finally, supplied a cosmological precedent, a universe diffusing from a primordial unity and destined to collapse back into it, which explains the darkness of the night sky by the finitude of light's travel and concludes, in pantheist rapture, that the heart of the universe is our own. Lovecraft kept the scale and removed the heart.

Arthur Machen, whom Lovecraft discovered in 1923, gave him his most important narrative template. In "The Novel of the Black Seal," embedded in *The Three Impostors* (1895), Professor Gregg correlates the characters engraved on a black stone with a passage in the Roman geographer Solinus and with the incomprehensible speech of an afflicted boy in the Welsh borderlands, concludes that a pre-human race survives beneath the hills, and vanishes. Here, thirty years before Thurston, is

a professor who correlates an artefact's inscription with a classical source and with the utterances of a dreamer, and who is destroyed by the conclusion: "The Call of Cthulhu" is Gregg's dossier rewritten on a planetary scale. Machen's "The White People" (1904), a girl's diary of initiation into a hidden folk-religion, lent Lovecraft the "Aklo letters" and the motif of the forbidden book that teaches; "The Great God Pan" (1894), in which an operation on a young woman's brain enables her to see the god and destroys her mind, established the equation of expanded perception with ruin that "From Beyond" would mechanize. But Machen's evil was sacramental. In the prologue to "The White People," his spokesman Ambrose explains that true evil, like true sanctity, is an ecstasy, an attempt to penetrate a higher sphere by a forbidden way, and Machen's horrors are sins against the order of being. Lovecraft retained the transgression and deleted the sin. His scholars violate no commandment; they merely complete a pattern.

Dunsany supplied the invented pantheon. *The Gods of Pegāna* (1905) describes a supreme deity, Māna-Yood-Sushāī, who made the gods and then fell asleep, and a drummer, Skarl, who beats unceasingly so that he will not wake, since on the day the drumming stops Māna-Yood-Sushāī will wake and there will be neither worlds nor gods. The court of Azathoth, with its drums and flutes at the centre of all things, descends from Skarl's drum; and the later, post-Lovecraftian notion that the universe is Azathoth's dream, which appears nowhere in Lovecraft's own text, owes more to Pegāna than to the Mythos to which it is usually attributed. Dunsany also taught Lovecraft the cadences of a prose modelled on the King James Bible and the device of gods themselves subject to a higher fatality. Blackwood supplied the sense of a boundary. "The Willows" (1907), which Lovecraft judged the finest weird tale in the language, strands two travellers on an island in the Danube where the membrane between our world and another has worn thin, and where they sense themselves observed by presences indifferent to them except as possible victims. There is a further irony in this debt. The epigraph of "The Call of Cthulhu," with its doctrine of survivals, comes from *The Centaur* (1911), a novel informed by Gustav Theodor Fechner's panpsychist vision of the Earth as a conscious being. Lovecraft placed a panpsychist's sentence at the head of a materialist's manifesto and let the new context invert its meaning: what survives, in Blackwood, is the living soul of the world; what survives, in Lovecraft, is something that would be better dead.

The remaining ancestors contributed devices. Robert W. Chambers's *The King in Yellow* (1895), which Lovecraft read in 1927, organized a cycle of tales around a forbidden play whose second act drives its readers mad, borrowing Carcosa and Hastur from Ambrose Bierce's "An Inhabitant of Carcosa" (1886) and "Haïta the Shepherd" (1891); the *Necronomicon* inherits from it the defining property that to read it is to be changed. Bierce also completed a lineage of invisible monsters running from Fitz-

James O'Brien's "What Was It?" (1859) through Maupassant's "Le Horla" (1887) to his own "The Damned Thing" (1893), whose creature cannot be seen because, as its victim concludes, there are colours the eye cannot perceive, "and, God help me! the Damned Thing is of such a color!" The colour beyond the spectrum, and the creature made visible only by artifice, as the invisible twin of "The Dunwich Horror" is revealed by a sprayed powder, enter the Mythos from this line. M. R. James supplied the scholarly protagonist and the inscription that should not have been deciphered, most exactly in "The Treasure of Abbot Thomas" (1904), whose antiquary decodes a cipher in stained glass and finds its guardian. Hodgson, read only in 1934, supplied in *The House on the Borderland* (1908) and *The Night Land* (1912) the scale of the dying sun, and coined in the latter the word "abhuman." Behind all of these stand Hawthorne, whose "Young Goodman Brown" (1835) and *The House of the Seven Gables* (1851) placed a witch-cult in the New England forest and an ancestral curse in a Salem house, and Cotton Mather, whose *Magnalia Christi Americana* (1702) Lovecraft mined for "The Unnamable." The Mythos is a New England genre before it is a cosmic one: its cosmos is entered through Puritan cellars.

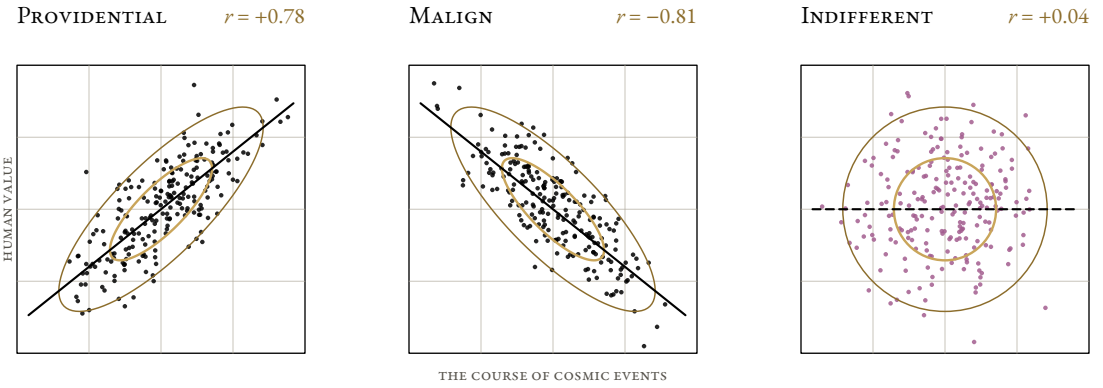
The most consequential element of Lovecraft's aesthetic inheritance, however, is the one most often dismissed as affectation: his lifelong identification with the eighteenth century. He professed to feel himself an exile from the age of Addison and Pope; his early verse is a sustained imitation of Augustan couplets; he adopted British spellings and cultivated archaisms, and in 1917 he published a sketch in the persona of an ancient gentleman reminiscing about his acquaintance with Dr. Johnson. The affectation conceals a structural key. The Augustan cosmos was a cosmos of proportion, ordered by the great chain of being whose history Arthur O. Lovejoy published in 1936, the year before Lovecraft's death, and whose classic English statement is Pope's *Essay on Man* (1733–34). Pope counselled humanity not to presume to scan God, since the proper study of mankind is man, and he described the human condition as that of a being "Plac'd on this isthmus of a middle state," darkly wise and rudely great, a link in a chain from which to strike a single link, "Tenth or ten thousandth," is to break the whole. Lovecraft's opening sentence is Pope's counsel converted from prudence into terror, and his governing image is a precise revision of Pope's. Pope's middle state is an isthmus, a narrow ground that connects, joining the human to the orders above and below it in a continuous chain. Lovecraft's is an island, a narrow ground that connects to nothing, set in black seas across which no chain extends. The Mythos is the *Essay on Man* read after the chain has broken, by a reader who still believed in proportion and could find it nowhere but in the doorways and steeples of colonial Providence. The Augustan ideal is therefore not incidental to the Mythos but its condition of legibility. Disproportion can be felt only by a

sensibility trained in proportion, and the most Augustan imagination in American letters produced its literature of disproportion for exactly that reason.

Indifferentism as Statistical Independence 2.7

The genealogy assembled in the preceding sections permits Lovecraft's metaphysics to be stated with a precision his letters, discursive and polemical, never attempted. Let the value that human beings attach to states of the world be treated as one variable and the course of cosmic events as another. Three relations between them are possible. If they are positively correlated, so that the cosmos tends toward what we value, the universe is providential, as in Leibniz's *Théodicée* (1710) and in every theism that promises that all things work together for good. If they are negatively correlated, the universe is malign: Schopenhauer's worst of all possible worlds, the hostile demiurge of the Gnostics, and, in the Mythos's own afterlife, Derleth's rebellious Old Ones, whose enmity toward humanity is the shadow cast by the benevolence of his Elder Gods. If they are uncorrelated, the universe is indifferent. Lovecraft's insistence that he was not a pessimist but an indifferentist is a claim about the sign of this correlation, and it is exactly right. Pessimism posits a correlation with a negative sign, which is still a correlation and therefore still a providence, inverted; indifferentism posits none.

Three consequences follow, each of which corrects a common misreading. The first is that indifference is not hostility, and is in an important sense worse. A hostile cosmos would at least be concerned with us; enmity is a relation and a form of



2.2 *Three cosmoi.* Human value plotted against the course of cosmic events in three simulated universes of 220 observations each, with their equal-density ellipses: providential (positive correlation), malign (negative) and indifferent (none). Pessimism posits a correlation with a negative sign, which is still a providence, inverted; indifferentism posits none (section 2.7).

recognition, and the Gnostic or the Manichaean can take a grim comfort in being worth persecuting. Lovecraft's narrators are denied even the dignity of being hated. The second is that indifference is the cosmological form of a logical gap that philosophy had long since identified. Hume observed in the *Treatise* (1739–40) that no proposition about what ought to be follows from propositions about what is, and G. E. Moore codified the point as the naturalistic fallacy in *Principia Ethica* (1903); indifferentism is Hume's gap projected onto the cosmos, the discovery that a description of the universe, however complete, contains no prescription. Max Weber named the social form of this condition the disenchantment of the world in "Wissenschaft als Beruf" (delivered 1917, published 1919), and added a prophecy that reads like a synopsis of the Mythos composed nine years before it: in the disenchanted world the many old gods, *entzaubert und daher in Gestalt unpersönlicher Mächte*, disenchanted and therefore in the form of impersonal powers, *entsteigen ihren Gräbern*, rise from their graves, strive for power over our lives, and resume their eternal struggle. Weber meant the warring value-spheres of modernity. Lovecraft wrote the literal version.

The third consequence is the most important and the least recognized. Indifference is not meaninglessness. The cosmos of the Mythos is not a void of values; it is crowded with them. The Great Race pursues an encyclopedic historiography across hundreds of millions of years; the Elder Things practise science, art, and politics; the Mi-Go mine, collect, and transport minds; even the cultists pursue an eschatology. What the Mythos denies is not that purposes exist in the universe but that any purpose including us is guaranteed by it. Its cosmos is not meaningless but meaningful without us, and this distinguishes Lovecraft's indifferentism sharply from the nihilism with which it is routinely conflated. Hence, finally, the paradox that binds this chapter to the last. Independence is a statistical conclusion, and like every such conclusion it can be reached only by measurement: one cannot know that two variables are uncorrelated without correlating them. Lovecraft's narrators must therefore correlate everything in order to discover that nothing correlates with them. The null result is the most laborious of findings, and correlative horror is the affect of the moment at which an exhaustive inquiry returns it.

2.8 Aesthetic Traditionalism: "The Silver Key" and the Local Recorrelation of Value

If the cosmos guarantees no value that includes us, value must be produced locally, and Lovecraft's mature ethics is a theory of where and how. Its manifesto is "The Silver Key" (1926), in which Randolph Carter, having lost at thirty the capacity to dream, tries in turn the consolations of modernity: the realism that reduces life to its mechanisms, the churches whose fables he can no longer credit, the occultists, the

bohemians, the novelists of disillusion. All fail, and Carter recovers the lost meaning of things only by returning, through the key of the title, to the hills and the ancestral house of his childhood. The tale's philosophical claim is that meaning is neither discovered in the cosmos nor invented by the will but inherited: it inheres in the forms, landscapes, and customs that a person absorbs before reflection, and it is lost when reflection detaches him from them. *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath* reaches the same conclusion from the opposite direction. Carter crosses the whole of the dreamlands in pursuit of a marvellous sunset city, and Nyarlathotep, the messenger of the Outer Gods, tells him at the summit of the quest that the city is made of nothing but his memories of the New England he loved in youth. The cosmos, interrogated by its own herald, sends the seeker home.

The structure is that of a local re-correlation: value restored at the scale at which meaning can be inherited rather than discovered. Its closest philosophical analogue is Husserl's late diagnosis, in *Die Krisis der europäischen Wissenschaften* (1936), that the mathematization of nature since Galileo had severed science from the lifeworld, the *Lebenswelt* of pre-theoretical experience from which all meaning derives. Husserl's lifeworld, however, is a universal structure of consciousness, while Lovecraft's is a particular place, and the difference marks the fork at which theories of rootedness divide. One branch leads to Simone Weil's *L'Enracinement* (1949), for which rootedness is a universal human need owed to every person; another to Heidegger's meditations on *Bodenständigkeit*, compromised by their author's entanglement with National Socialism. Lovecraft's version occupies a third position, aesthetic rather than ontological and racial rather than universal. Its literary analogues are clearer. Wallace Stevens's "Sunday Morning" (1915), published as Lovecraft began to write his mature fiction, describes humanity living in an old chaos of the sun, in "island solitude, unsponsored, free," and proposes that the beauty of the earth must suffice in place of any paradise; George Santayana, a materialist in ontology and a Catholic in imagination, held that religion is poetry mistaken for literal truth and deserves to be loved as poetry. Lovecraft shares with both the conviction that a godless cosmos leaves art as the custodian of value. He differs from both in binding the art to a lineage.

The lineage is the point at which the ethics fails. Lovecraft's attachment to inherited forms was genuine and frequently moving. His letters and travelogues record decades of pilgrimage to colonial doorways, gambrel roofs, and Georgian steeples from Quebec to Charleston, and Providence at sunset recurs through his work as a figure of the only transcendence he could credit; the words "I am Providence," drawn from his letters, are carved on the stone that admirers set on his grave in Swan Point Cemetery in 1977. The pun is exact and unintended. Denying providence to the cosmos, Lovecraft found it in a city, and Providence became the local substitute for

a providential universe. But a value that can be inherited can also be guarded, and Lovecraft tied the inheritance not to place alone but to what he called race and stock, insisting that a culture cannot outlive the replacement of the population that bore it. The structure that made Carter's homecoming possible made the immigrant crowds of "The Horror at Red Hook" intolerable. Here the argument of Chapter 1 returns with formal precision. Local re-correlation is a bounded correlation, a decision to correlate within an enclave and not beyond it; it is the opening sentence's mercy converted into a social programme. The island of ignorance becomes the island of tradition, and its shores must be patrolled, against the Old Ones at the cosmic scale and against strangers at the human one. Fairness to the record requires one qualification. In his last years Lovecraft's politics moved toward a socialism grounded partly in the same traditionalism, since he came to regard laissez-faire capitalism as the great destroyer of inherited forms. The conviction that tradition requires protection could lead him toward solidarity as well as exclusion, and the conclusion of this thesis will argue that the logic of the Mythos itself points beyond the exclusion.

2.9 Comparative Coda: Russell, Zapffe, Camus, Ligotti, Brassier, Lyotard

Lovecraft's indifferentism can be measured, finally, against the principal twentieth-century responses to the same cosmos. Bertrand Russell's "A Free Man's Worship" (1903) is the closest in content and the most distant in affect. Its central paragraph enumerates the findings of science in a single periodic sentence: that humanity is the product of causes with no prevision of their end, its hopes and loves the outcome of "accidental collocations of atoms," its achievements destined to extinction in the death of the solar system; and it concludes that only on the firm foundation of "unyielding despair" can the soul's habitation be safely built. Russell's response is Promethean. The free man worships not power but his own ideals, in defiance of the omnipotent matter that will destroy them, and Russell expressly condemns the worship of force he associated with Carlyle, Nietzsche, and militarism. The Mythos contains Russell's free man nowhere, but it contains his antagonist everywhere: the cult of Cthulhu is the worship of force in its purest form, a religion of power that expects nothing from its god except ecstatic destruction. Russell and Lovecraft agree about the cosmos and disagree about what can be built upon it. Russell raises a temple of ideals; Lovecraft restores a Georgian house.

Peter Wessel Zapffe's "The Last Messiah" (1933), written in Norway as Lovecraft was completing his last major tales, offers the most precise psychological complement to the opening sentence. Zapffe argued that human consciousness is an evolutionary overdevelopment, like the antlers of the extinct giant deer that grew too heavy for

the animal to bear, and that human beings survive their own lucidity only through four mechanisms of repression: isolation, the expulsion of disturbing thoughts from awareness; anchoring, the fixation of life on stable points of value such as God, nation, family, and tradition; distraction; and sublimation, the conversion of despair into art. The correspondence with Lovecraft is close enough to be schematic. The mercy of the opening sentence is Zapffe's isolation; Lovecraft's aesthetic traditionalism is anchoring in its most deliberate form; and his fiction is sublimation, the conversion of cosmic horror into a beautiful object. Read through Zapffe, Lovecraft's life and work compose a complete apparatus of defence against the lucidity his tales depict, and the tales are the record of what befalls characters for whom the apparatus fails.

Albert Camus's *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (1942) defined the absurd not as a property of the world or of the self but as their confrontation, the collision between the human demand for meaning and the unreasonable silence of the world. In this relational definition the absurd is the nearest philosophical relative of correlative horror, which this thesis has likewise located in a relation rather than in either of its terms. The difference lies in what the relation does. The absurd is a standing confrontation, which Camus would have us sustain in lucid revolt, imagining Sisyphus happy; correlative horror is the completion of a movement, and it leaves the subject nowhere to stand. Camus's lucidity is his hero's victory. Lovecraft's is his narrators' ruin.

The pessimist revival of the present century has tended to annex Lovecraft to positions he would not have recognized. Thomas Ligotti, whose "The Last Feast of Harlequin" (1990) is dedicated to Lovecraft's memory, argues in *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* that existence is "malignantly useless" and that consciousness is the parent of all horrors, a position that brings him, alongside David Benatar's *Better Never to Have Been* (2006), to antinatalism. But malignancy is a negative correlation, and Ligotti's cosmos is Schopenhauer's rather than Lovecraft's; the indifferentist has no grounds for antinatalism, since a cosmos that does not care whether we suffer supplies no more reason to cease than to continue. Ray Brassier's *Nihil Unbound* (2007) draws a sterner lesson from the death of the Sun: since extinction is certain, thought must think its own annihilation, and the catastrophe to come has in a sense already cancelled the meaning of everything that precedes it. Brassier's extinction is an arche-fossil of the future, and Lovecraft had narrated it, most fully in "The Shadow out of Time," whose archive records the species that will inherit the Earth after humanity and the minds that will abandon the planet before its end. Jean-François Lyotard's "Can Thought Go On Without a Body?" (1987), finally, reasoned from the Sun's death in some four and a half billion years that the one serious task left to techno-science is to detach thought from the bodies that will perish with the Earth. The Great Race, which exchanges minds across species and epochs to outlast successive extinctions, is Lyotard's programme realized by an alien civilization, and

Chapter 7 will ask what it means that the Mythos imagined that programme as a horror.

Measured against these positions, Lovecraft's indifferentism appears as a distinct sixth term. It is not pessimism, because it denies the negative sign; not Promethean defiance, because it raises no temple of ideals; not revolt, because it permits no stance; not heroic rationalism, because it does not ask thought to love its own extinction; and not techno-transcendence, because it regards the escape of mind from body as a further horror rather than a hope. It is the recognition of statistical independence between value and process, joined to an aesthetic strategy of local re-correlation that succeeds as art and fails as ethics. The cosmos it describes is meaningful without us, and the meaning it permits us is inherited, bounded, and guarded. What remains to be explained is how a doctrine that Lovecraft could state calmly in a letter became unbearable in the tales. The answer lies not in the doctrine but in the method by which the narrators arrive at it, and to that method, the Miskatonic method, the next chapter turns.

Chapter Three



The Miskatonic Method

Forbidden Knowledge, the Archive, and the Epistemology of Correlative Horror

For in much wisdom is much grief: and he that increaseth knowledge increaseth sorrow.

Ecclesiastes 1:18, Authorized Version

The epistemic register

Chapter Three

The Miskatonic Method

This chapter argues that the horror of the Mythos is generated not by what its narrators find but by the method through which they find it, and that the method, here called the Miskatonic method, is sound. It begins with the long history of interdicted knowledge, which the Mythos secularizes by moving the prohibition from divine law into the structure of knowledge itself. It then examines the instruments of correlation within the tales: the imaginary book, the documentary dossier, the abductive inference shared by science, detection, and paranoia, the scientific instrument that widens the human perceptual world, and the inhuman archive in which the human correlator finds himself catalogued. A comparative coda follows the method into later fiction, film, network folklore, and games.

3.1 Eden, Prometheus, Faust: A Prehistory of Interdicted Knowing

The tale of knowledge that should not have been sought is among the oldest the species tells, and the Mythos inherits its structure while transforming its terms. In the second and third chapters of Genesis the knowledge of good and evil is interdicted by divine command under pain of death, and the serpent's promise that its acquisition will make humanity as gods (Genesis 3:5) is fulfilled in a form that turns it into exile. Christian moral theology generalized the episode into a doctrine of illicit curiosity. Augustine numbered *curiositas*, the lust of the eyes (1 John 2:16), among the great concupiscences and condemned in the *Confessions* (X.35) the appetite to know for the sake of knowing; Hans Blumenberg's *Der Prozeß der theoretischen Neugierde* (1973) reconstructed the long trial through which modernity acquitted curiosity of that charge, so that by the age of Bacon the drive to know had passed from vice to virtue and become the legitimating motive of the sciences. The Mythos reopens a trial that modernity believed it had won. It indicts curiosity again, but on new grounds. The charge is no longer impiety but incommensurability: the knower is not condemned for exceeding a limit set by God but undone by exceeding the limit set by his own constitution.

Greek myth supplies a more exact precedent, and a more surprising one. In the *Prometheus Bound* attributed to Aeschylus, the Titan enumerates his gifts to humanity, and the first that he names is not fire. He has stopped mortals, he says, from foreseeing their doom; asked what remedy he found for that affliction, he answers that he settled blind hopes in them, *typhlas en autois elpidas katōikisa*, and the Chorus calls this a great benefit; only then does he add that he also gave them fire (248–252). The Promethean endowment is double from the beginning, a technology of knowledge and a merciful blindness that makes knowledge bearable, and the blindness is given first. Lovecraft's opening sentence restates the Promethean mercy with one difference that measures the distance between the two worlds. Prometheus planted blind hopes by deliberate benevolence; Lovecraft's mercy has no giver. It is an accident of cognitive constitution, as unintended as everything else in a mechanistic cosmos, and it cannot therefore be relied upon. Hesiod's Pandora, whose jar releases every evil but retains *elpis* within (*Works and Days* 96–99), teaches the same lesson from the other side: what remains sealed is what makes the released evils endurable.

The Faust tradition gave the interdiction its early modern form and its scholarly protagonist. Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus* (printed 1604) ends with a chorus that draws the moral a Miskatonic narrator might append to his own manuscript, exhorting the wise "Only to wonder at unlawful things," to marvel at them rather than practise them. Goethe's *Faust* (1808) supplied the figure itself: the scholar who has studied philosophy, law, medicine, and, alas, theology, the whole circle of the faculties, and who turns to magic in despair so that he may know *was die Welt / Im Innersten zusammenhält*, what binds the world together at its core. The desire is precisely the desire for total correlation, and the scene that follows is the first great dramatization of correlative horror in modern literature. Faust conjures the Earth Spirit, cannot bear the sight of it, and is dismissed with a sentence that might stand as epigraph to the argument of section 3.5: *Du gleichst dem Geist, den du begreifst, / Nicht mir!*, you resemble the spirit you comprehend, not me. The scholar can grasp only what is commensurate with him, and what exceeds him rebukes him for having called.

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) completed the secularization of the motif and supplied the narrative architecture of Lovecraft's longest work. Victor Frankenstein tells his story to the explorer Robert Walton, whose ship is icebound on a voyage toward the pole, in order to dissuade him from pursuing his own discovery, and he draws its moral in terms that anticipate both the opening sentence of "The Call of Cthulhu" and the ethics analysed in Chapter 2: learn from me, he tells Walton, how dangerous is the acquirement of knowledge, and "how much happier that man is who believes his native town to be the world" than he who aspires beyond his nature. *At the Mountains of Madness* reproduces the architecture exactly. William Dyer writes his account to dissuade the Starkweather-Moore expedition from returning to the

Antarctic, as Victor speaks to turn Walton back from the Arctic; the polar frame, the testimony of a ruined scientist, and the intended reader whose voyage the narrative exists to prevent are common to both. The native town that Victor commends is Lovecraft's Providence, and the moral of both narratives is the moral of the island of ignorance.

Across these precedents the Mythos makes three transformations, and together they define its epistemology. First, the source of the prohibition migrates from an external authority into the structure of knowledge. No god forbids the Miskatonic scholar anything; the danger is not legislated but entailed, inherent in what is known rather than imposed upon the knower. Second, the punishment migrates from sanction to consequence. Adam is expelled, Prometheus chained, Faust damned; the Lovecraftian scholar is simply changed by what he knows, and the knowledge is its own penalty. Third, the work of interdiction passes to human institutions. In Lovecraft's mock history of the *Necronomicon* the book is burned by a patriarch of Constantinople and banned by a pope; at Miskatonic it is kept under lock, and in "The Dunwich Horror" the librarian Henry Armitage refuses it to Wilbur Whateley. The forbidding of knowledge becomes a merciful policy enacted by the institutions of knowledge themselves, which must both pursue correlation and police it. The emblem of this condition is older than the Mythos: the key in Perrault's "La Barbe bleue" (1697), which, once it has opened the forbidden chamber, bears a stain of blood that no scrubbing will remove. What correlation unlocks cannot be locked again.

3.2 The *Necronomicon* and the Imaginary Library: Borges, Eco

The *Necronomicon* is the Mythos's most famous invention and its most precise instrument of correlation. Lovecraft first named it in "The Hound" (1922), and in 1927 he composed, for his own reference, a mock-bibliographical "History of the *Necronomicon*," printed as a pamphlet the year after his death. Its author is Abdul Alhazred, a name Lovecraft had adopted at the age of five under the spell of the *Arabian Nights*: a mad poet of Sanaa who flourished under the Umayyad caliphs, explored the ruins of Babylon and the empty quarter of Arabia, wrote his book in his last years in Damascus under the title *Al Azif*, after the Arabic word for the nocturnal insect-sound once taken for the howling of demons, and was devoured in 738, according to the medieval biographer Ibn Khallikan, by an invisible monster in broad daylight before many witnesses. The history then traces a philological descent: a Greek translation as the *Necronomicon* by Theodorus Philetas of Constantinople in 950, a burning by the Patriarch Michael in 1050, a Latin version by Olaus Wormius in 1228, a papal ban in 1232, early printed editions, and surviving copies in the British Museum, the Bibliothèque nationale, the Widener Library at Harvard, the library of

Miskatonic University, and the University of Buenos Aires. The catalogue mimics the apparatus of real scholarship so successfully that its one conspicuous error, the dating of a translator modelled on the Danish polymath Ole Worm, who lived four centuries later, has become a philological curiosity in its own right.

The fiction is not innocent of its sources. Lovecraft took the gloss on *azif* from Samuel Henley's notes to William Beckford's *Vathek* (1786), and the figure of the mad Arab places the origin of the most dangerous knowledge on earth in the Orient that Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978) would identify as the West's preferred repository of the irrational, the ancient, and the forbidden. The philological history compounds the structure. The real transmission of Greek learning to medieval Europe ran from Greek through Arabic into Latin, by way of the translators of Baghdad and Toledo; Lovecraft's *translatio* runs from Arabic through Greek into Latin, reversing the route by which Europe recovered its own antiquity in order to import, along the same channels, an antiquity that is not humanity's at all. The colonial geography analysed in Chapter 6 is already legible here. Knowledge of the Outside enters the West through the East, and the Western philologist, translating, transmits a contamination he believes himself to be curating.

Lovecraft glossed the title in a late letter as an image of the law of the dead, joining *nekros* to *nomos* and *eikōn*; and the presence of *nomos* in the name of the Mythos's central book is a quiet irony, since *nomos* is the term by which Democritus designated the conventional order of human perception and opposed it to the real (section 2.1). The *Necronomicon* is a book of laws that belong to no human convention. Its function within the corpus is best described in this thesis's own terms: it is a pre-correlated archive. Where Thurston must assemble his pattern from dispersed sources at the cost of his sanity, Alhazred has already performed the correlation, binding the lore of the Old Ones, their cults, their formulae, and their cosmic cycles into a single compendium, so that to read the book is to receive the completed pattern without the protective labour of assembling it. That is why it is dangerous to read rather than merely to possess, and why the danger attaches to comprehension rather than to ownership. Lovecraft compounded the effect by never presenting the book whole. It exists in the corpus only as quotation, a handful of passages cited from tale to tale and supplemented by the citations of his correspondents, so that the *Necronomicon* is less a text than a network of citations, as the Mythos itself is. The book that performs every correlation is itself known only by correlation.

It belongs to a tradition of imaginary books as old as print, from the absurd catalogue of the library of Saint-Victor in Rabelais's *Pantagruel* (1532) and Sir Thomas Browne's *Musaeum Clausum* (1684) to the reviews of nonexistent books in Stanisław Lem's *A Perfect Vacuum* (1971). Two real objects have given the tradition material form: the Voynich manuscript, acquired by Wilfrid Voynich in 1912 and

dated by radiocarbon to the early fifteenth century, written in an undeciphered script among drawings of unidentifiable plants, and Luigi Serafini's *Codex Seraphinianus* (1981), an encyclopedia of an imaginary world in an invented alphabet. Both exhibit the form of knowledge while withholding its content, and both have attracted exactly the obsessive correlators whom the Mythos depicts.

Borges is the tradition's philosopher, and three of his fictions define the space within which the *Necronomicon* must be located. "La biblioteca de Babel" (1941) imagines a library containing every possible book, every combination of twenty-five symbols across volumes of four hundred and ten pages, in which every truth exists and none can be found, and whose librarians go mad or kill themselves in search of the catalogue of catalogues. Babel is the library of all possible correlations; the *Necronomicon* is its antithesis, the single book in which the one correlation that matters has been found and cannot be lost. Both drive their readers mad, the one by infinite noise and the other by a single signal. "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagines an encyclopedia of an invented planet, compiled by a secret society, whose objects begin to appear in the world until, in the story's postscript, the world itself is becoming Tlön: a fiction made real through the accumulation of its own citations, which is precisely what befell the *Necronomicon* in the decades after Lovecraft's death (Chapter 5). "El Aleph" (1945), finally, places in a Buenos Aires cellar a point that contains all other points, through which the narrator sees the entire universe at once. His response is not horror but an infinite veneration and pity, and his consolation, in the story's postscript, is that the mind is porous to forgetting, so that the total vision is already eroding. Borges's narrator is saved by the mercy that Lovecraft's opening sentence names. In both writers, the incapacity to retain the total correlation is what allows a human being to survive having glimpsed it.

Umberto Eco completed the tradition by giving the imaginary library its institutional and its pathological forms. In *Il nome della rosa* (1980) the forbidden book is the lost second book of Aristotle's *Poetics*, on comedy, which the blind librarian Jorge of Burgos, Eco's homage to Borges, has poisoned so that whoever reads it dies. Jorge defends a monastic conception of knowledge as preservation rather than search, and he is the dark double of Lovecraft's Armitage, a guardian of books convinced that some knowledge must be kept rather than used. In *Il pendolo di Foucault* (1988) three Milanese editors, contemptuous of the occult manuscripts they are paid to read, amuse themselves by inventing a universal conspiracy, the Plan, assembled partly by a computer named after the Kabbalist Abraham Abulafia that recombines fragments of text at random; the Plan is taken up by real believers, and it kills its authors. The novel diagnoses the Miskatonic method as a disease of interpretation, the disease Eco theorized in his Tanner Lectures (*Interpretation and Overinterpretation*, 1992) as the hermetic drive to find every text connected to every other. Lovecraft's narrators

are overinterpreters whose overinterpretations are true. That is the single difference between the two writers, and it is the whole of the horror.

The Dossier: Clippings, Testimonies, Photographs, Phonographs 3.3

Lovecraft's tales are dossiers before they are stories. "Dagon" (1917) is a statement written in the hour before its author's intended suicide; "The Statement of Randolph Carter" (1919) is a deposition to the police; "The Call of Cthulhu" is a manuscript found among a dead man's papers; *At the Mountains of Madness* is a report addressed to a scientific expedition; "The Shadow out of Time" is a letter from a father to his son; *The Case of Charles Dexter Ward* is reconstructed from letters, diaries, and an ancestor's correspondence; "The Thing on the Doorstep" is a statement in which the narrator explains why he has shot his closest friend. The form descends from the epistolary novel and from the legal-testimonial structure that Wilkie Collins made explicit in the preamble to *The Woman in White* (1860), which announces that its story will be told by several pens, as an offence is told in court by several witnesses. In every case the narrative is assembled from documents, and the documents are the media through which correlation occurs.

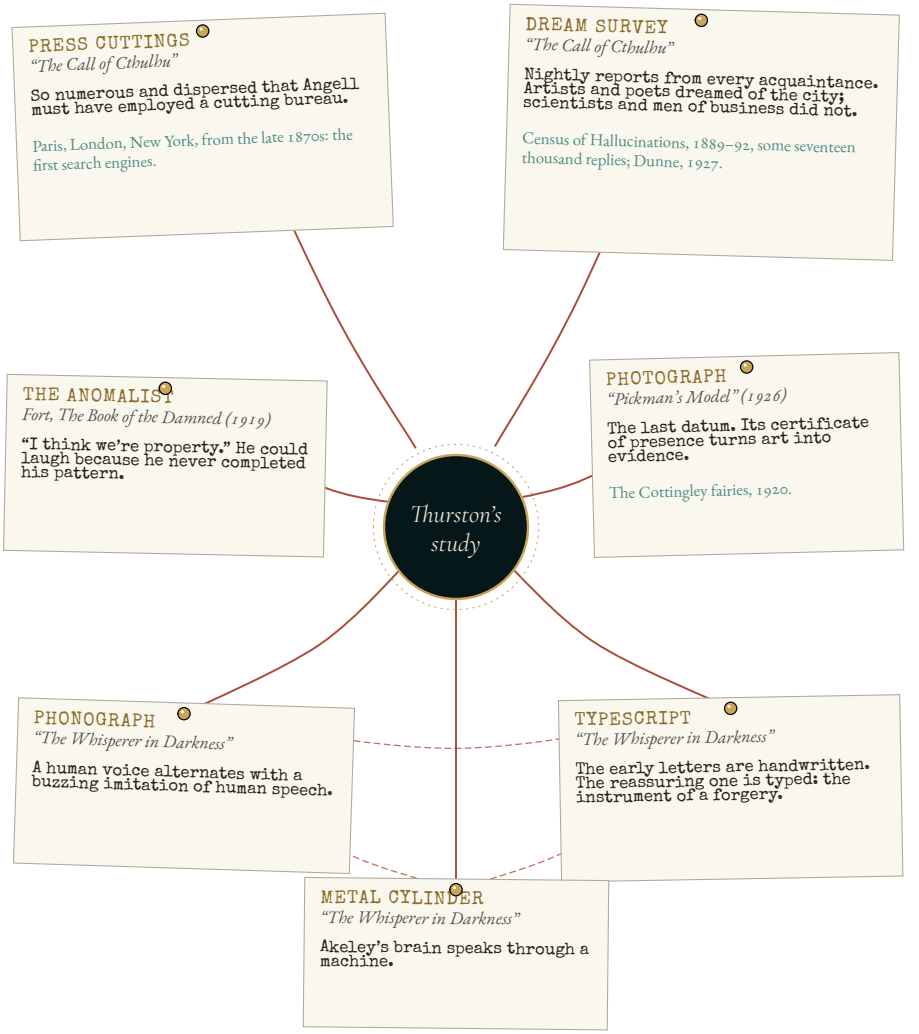
The decisive precedent is Bram Stoker's *Dracula* (1897), the great documentary novel of the nineteenth century, whose text consists of diaries, letters, telegrams, newspaper cuttings, a ship's log, transcripts of the phonograph cylinders on which Dr. Seward dictates his journal, and the typescripts in which Mina Harker collates everything into chronological order. Friedrich Kittler's celebrated reading ("Draculas Vermächtnis," 1982) showed that the vampire is defeated by information processing: by the typewriter, the phonograph, and the bureaucratic collation that turns scattered testimony into a single actionable file. Mina is the novel's correlator, and her correlation saves its world. Twenty-nine years later Thurston performs the same operation on the same kinds of media, cuttings, testimonies, manuscripts, and a sculptor's dream-record, and the result is reversed. Between *Dracula* and "The Call of Cthulhu" the valence of correlation flips: the information network that once contained the archaic monster now summons it. The flip marks the passage from the nineteenth century's confidence in the processing of information to the twentieth century's dread of it.

The media of correlation in "The Call of Cthulhu" deserve attention in their own right. Thurston infers that Angell must have employed a cutting bureau, so numerous and widely dispersed are the newspaper extracts in his files; the press-cutting agencies that appeared in Paris, London, and New York from the late 1870s were in effect the first search engines, services that sifted the world's print by keyword for a fee. Angell had also conducted a survey, asking every acquaintance he could decently

approach for nightly reports of their dreams, and found that artists and poets had dreamed of the city while scientists and men of business had not. The survey has real precedents. The Society for Psychical Research conducted a Census of Hallucinations between 1889 and 1892, polling some seventeen thousand respondents to establish whether apparitions of the dying coincided with deaths more often than chance allowed, and J. W. Dunne's *An Experiment with Time* (1927) invited its readers to record their dreams in order to detect precognition: psychical research was, among other things, an attempt to apply correlation to the uncanny. Its most eccentric practitioner, Charles Fort, compiled in *The Book of the Damned* (1919) thousands of anomalous reports excluded by science and drew from them a hypothesis that anticipates the Mythos in four words: "I think we're property." Fort practised the Miskatonic method as a humorist, and he could laugh because he never completed his pattern.

Two further media mark the limits of correlation. The photograph, in Roland Barthes's analysis in *La Chambre claire* (1980), certifies that its referent has been there, *ça-a-été*, and Lovecraft's age had already learned to exploit that certificate on behalf of the supernatural, from the spirit photography of the 1860s to the Cottingley fairy photographs that Arthur Conan Doyle championed in 1920. "Pickman's Model" (1926) inverts the exploitation. The narrator, having admired the painter's monstrous canvases as works of imagination, finds curled on one of them a photograph that proves they were painted from life; the photograph is the last datum, and its certificate of presence turns art into evidence. "The Whisperer in Darkness" is the corpus's most sustained study of media. Its evidence includes a phonograph recording of a ritual in the Vermont woods on which a human voice alternates with a buzzing imitation of human speech, the voice of a being that has learned our language without possessing our organs; and its plot turns on the difference between handwriting and typescript. Akeley's early letters are handwritten, but the reassuring letter that lures the narrator to Vermont is typed, and the typewriter, which Kittler identified as the machine that severs writing from the hand and so from the guarantee of identity, is the instrument of a forgery. At the end the narrator finds Akeley's face and hands lying in a chair, while Akeley's brain speaks through a machine from a metal cylinder. The tale moves through the entire media system of its time, phonograph, typewriter, telegraph, and prosthetic voice, and shows each to be a channel through which the Outside can impersonate the human.

The documentary form has a final consequence. Because the dossier must be complete even when its compiler is destroyed, Lovecraft's narrators write until the last moment, a convention much mocked since "Dagon" closed with its narrator's cry, as something approaches his door, of "The window! The window!" The convention is absurd as realism and exact as epistemology. The text outlives its author because



3.1 *The media of correlation.* The documentary apparatus of the Miskatonic method, from the press cuttings and dream survey of "The Call of Cthulhu" to the photograph of "Pickman's Model" and the phonograph, typescript and cylinder of "The Whisperer in Darkness", with the real practices behind them, pinned in the manner of the evidence wall that descends from Thurston's study (sections 1.4 and 3.3).

correlation, once completed, does not end with the correlator; it passes to whoever reads the dossier next. The reader inherits the pattern and its danger, and the mercy of the opening sentence is breached, in the end, not in Thurston but in us. Koji Suzuki's novel *Ring* (1991) and Hideo Nakata's film *Ringu* (1998) carried this logic to its terminus: a videotape that kills its viewer within seven days unless it is copied and shown to another. The cursed medium can be survived only by being transmitted, which is to say that the dossier has become a contagion; and the history of the Mythos's

afterlife, examined in Chapter 5, suggests that the description fits Lovecraft's own texts more closely than he could have intended.

3.4 Science and Paranoia: Apophenia, Pynchon, and the Evidence Wall

The protagonists of the major tales are not mad scientists. Lovecraft wrote one such figure, Herbert West of Miskatonic's medical school, in a serial he regarded as hackwork; the scholars of the mature fiction are cautious, collegial, and methodologically scrupulous. Armitage, Rice, and Morgan in "The Dunwich Horror" reason from the evidence to a hypothesis that predicts the entity's behaviour and allows them to destroy it; Dyer and Pabodie in *At the Mountains of Madness* proceed by the standards of geology and comparative anatomy and are confirmed at every step; the chemists of "The Colour Out of Space" run the correct tests. Their error is not methodological. It is that they are right. This is the substance of the second corollary stated in Chapter 1, and its strangeness can be measured against the philosophy of science. For Karl Popper (*Logik der Forschung*, 1934) the mark of a scientific hypothesis is that it exposes itself to refutation, while pseudo-science and conspiracy shield themselves from it. The Lovecraftian hypotheses expose themselves to refutation and are not refuted. The Mythos is the thought experiment in which the paranoid passes every test that science can set.

The logic the scholars share is abduction, which Charles Sanders Peirce formalized in his Harvard lectures of 1903: a surprising fact is observed; if a certain hypothesis were true, the fact would be a matter of course; there is therefore reason to suspect that the hypothesis is true. Abduction is also the logic of detective fiction, as the essays collected by Umberto Eco and Thomas Sebeok in *The Sign of Three* (1983) demonstrated by setting Peirce beside Dupin and Holmes, and the genealogy of detection contains a fact whose significance for the Mythos is easily overlooked. The first detective story, Poe's "The Murders in the Rue Morgue" (1841), concludes that the murderer was not human: Dupin's analysis of the evidence, its inhuman strength, its unintelligible voice, its impossible agility, leads to an orang-utan. From its inception, the abductive method of detection was capable of arriving at a nonhuman culprit. Holmes formulated the method's governing maxim in *The Sign of Four* (1890): "when you have eliminated the impossible, whatever remains, however improbable, must be the truth." Lovecraft's narrators obey it to the letter. Having eliminated hoax, coincidence, hallucination, and conspiracy, they are left with the improbable remainder, and the remainder is the Old Ones. The Mythos is detective fiction in which the solution indicts the universe.

Carlo Ginzburg's essay "Spie" (1979) traced this conjectural or evidential paradigm, shared by the art connoisseur Giovanni Morelli, by Freud, and by Holmes, back to the hunter reading tracks in the mud, the oldest form of knowledge, which infers an absent animal from its traces. Lovecraft's scholars are hunters in this sense, and like Bruno's Actaeon (section 2.2) they discover that what they have been tracking is tracking them. The same paradigm is the logic of the paranoid. Richard Hofstadter observed that paranoid political writing is distinguished not by its disregard for evidence but by its obsessive accumulation of it, by a pedantic apparatus of citation and a heroic striving for proof, so that the paranoid text resembles scholarship more than scholarship does; Thurston's manuscript, with its references to Frazer, to Murray, and to the theosophical literature, has exactly this texture. What separates science from paranoia in the ordinary world is not the form of inference, which is the same, but its fate: the scientist's abductions are tested by others and usually abandoned, while the paranoid's are insulated from correction. In the Mythos the abductions are tested and survive, and the community of inquirers, Armitage and his colleagues, Dyer and Danforth, concurs. Every social check that ordinarily distinguishes the two has been satisfied. Only the conclusion remains to tell them apart, and the conclusion is the paranoid's.

The cognitive science of religion permits the same point to be made at the level of the species. Stewart Guthrie's *Faces in the Clouds* (1993) explained religion as systematic anthropomorphism, the tendency to see agents in ambiguous stimuli; Justin Barrett and Pascal Boyer described a hyperactive agency detection device, an evolved bias toward false positives that makes the rustle in the grass a predator because the cost of mistaking a predator for the wind is death. On this account religion is a by-product of an overcautious perceptual system, and the skeptic's task is to correct its false alarms. Lovecraft, as thoroughgoing a skeptic as any American writer of his generation, wrote a world in which the false alarms are true. There is something in the rustle; there are faces in the clouds; the agency that the primitive mind projected onto nature is really there, though it is not divine and does not care. The Mythos is a materialist's revenge on his own materialism: a demonstration that the skeptic's null hypothesis might fail without the believer being vindicated.

Two later fictions mark the limits of the method from opposite sides. Thomas Pynchon's *The Crying of Lot 49* (1966) sends Oedipa Maas in pursuit of the Tristero, a secret postal system whose muted post horn she begins to find everywhere, and leaves her at the novel's end awaiting an auction that may resolve whether the Tristero is real, a hoax devised to torment her, or her own delusion. Pynchon suspends the correlation that Lovecraft completes, and the suspension is the source of his novel's anxiety as completion is the source of Lovecraft's horror. *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) restaged the conflict between correlation and causation as a quarrel between

the statistician Roger Mexico, who finds that the map of Tyrone Slothrop's sexual encounters matches the Poisson distribution of V-2 strikes on London, and the Pavlovian Pointsman, who demands a causal mechanism. Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper" (1892) marks the other limit. Its narrator, confined by her physician husband to a rest cure, begins to trace the pattern of the wallpaper and discerns behind it a woman, or many women, creeping and trapped. Her correlation is pathologized as hysteria, though it reads the truth of her own confinement; and the contrast with Lovecraft's male scholars, whose correlations are credited as science even when they destroy, exposes a gendering of apophenia that the Mythos never examines. When the professor correlates, it is research; when the confined woman correlates, it is a symptom.

The contemporary relevance of the method needs little emphasis. The networked present has made correlation cheap and universal, and the cultures of conspiracy that Michael Barkun analysed in *A Culture of Conspiracy* (2003) prize what he called stigmatized knowledge, knowledge valued because institutions reject it. The *Necronomicon*, burned by a patriarch and banned by a pope, is the archetype of stigmatized knowledge, and the Mythos is a literature in which such knowledge proves true. Here lies the ambivalence of its pedagogy: its correlations are true only within the fiction, but the pleasure of the last datum clicking into place is identical to the paranoid's, and the Mythos rehearses its readers in that pleasure. Tyler Vigen's *Spurious Correlations* (2015), which charts among other pairs the close statistical relation between the films of Nicolas Cage and drownings in swimming pools, supplies the comic antidote, and a reminder that the mercy of the opening sentence includes the mercy of not mistaking noise for revelation.

3.5 Umwelt and Mesocosm: Uexküll, Vollmer, and "From Beyond"

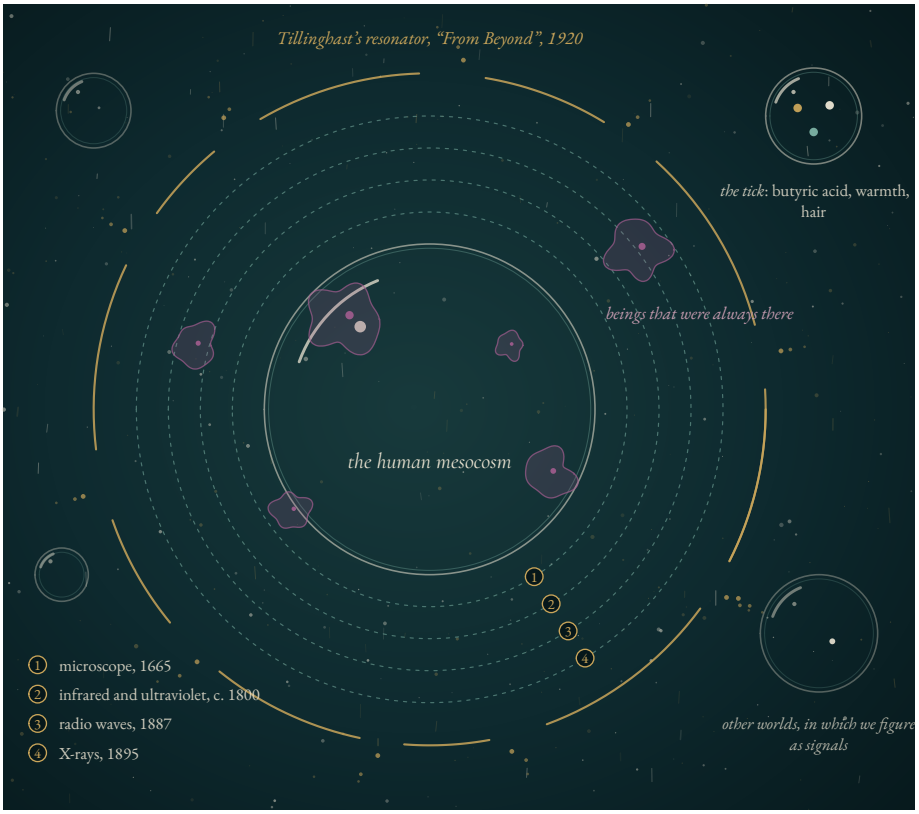
"From Beyond" (1920) is the Mythos's laboratory experiment, the tale in which the merciful limit of the opening sentence is breached not by the assembly of documents but by a machine. Crawford Tillinghast builds a resonator that emits a wave capable of stimulating dormant organs of perception, chief among them the pineal gland, which he calls the great sense-organ of organs; under its influence the narrator perceives that the room is full of beings that have always shared our space unseen, gelatinous monstrosities drifting through solid objects and through his own body. Nothing has invaded. The beings were always there; what has changed is the range of perception. The choice of organ is not arbitrary. Descartes had made the pineal gland the seat of the soul, the point at which mind and body interact (*Les Passions de l'âme*, 1649, arts. 31–32), and Theosophy had reinterpreted it as an atrophied third eye. Tillinghast converts the Cartesian interface between mind and body into an interface

between the world and the Outside; Georges Bataille, in the drafts on "L'œil pinéal" that he composed in the late 1920s, imagined the same gland as an eye at the crown of the skull opening onto the blinding sun. In both, the organ of the soul becomes an organ of excess.

The biology that gives this fiction its philosophical precision is Jakob von Uexküll's. In *Umwelt und Innenwelt der Tiere* (1909) and *Streifzüge durch die Umwelten von Tieren und Menschen* (1934), Uexküll argued that every organism inhabits a world of its own, an *Umwelt* composed only of the features its receptors can register and its effectors can act upon, and he pictured each such world as a soap bubble enclosing its subject. The tick, his most famous example, lives in a world of three signs, the smell of butyric acid, the warmth of a mammal's body, the texture of hair, and can wait in that world, as one specimen did in the laboratory at Rostock, for eighteen years without food. Uexküll understood his biology as Kantianism extended to every species: each organism has its own forms of intuition and its own transcendental bubble. The consequence for the Mythos is direct. If every species is enclosed in its Umwelt, then what lies beyond the human bubble is not the thing-in-itself but other bubbles, the worlds of other beings in which we may figure as mere signals; and the placid island of ignorance is Uexküll's soap bubble described from inside. "From Beyond" bursts the bubble with a machine. The major tales burst it with evidence.

Uexküll's work entered philosophy through Heidegger's lectures of 1929–30, *Die Grundbegriffe der Metaphysik*, which set out a hierarchy in which the stone is worldless, the animal poor in world (*weltarm*), and the human being world-forming; Giorgio Agamben's *L'aperto* (2002) has shown how much that hierarchy depends on the animal it excludes. The Mythos, written in the same years, displaces Heidegger's hierarchy one level upward. Relative to the Great Race, which inhabits all epochs, or to the Mi-Go, who traverse dimensions and preserve minds without bodies, humanity is poor in world, a creature whose Umwelt is narrow and whose captivity within it is visible to beings that are not so confined. Part of the horror of the major tales is the discovery that we stand to them as Heidegger's animal stands to us. Thomas Nagel's "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" (1974) argued that the subjective character of an alien experience is inaccessible in principle; "The Shadow out of Time" imagines that inaccessibility overcome, as Peaslee dreams his way into the senses of a cone-shaped body, and presents the overcoming as a violation.

Evolutionary epistemology supplied the last step. Konrad Lorenz proposed in 1941 that Kant's a priori forms are a posteriori for the species: categories prior to individual experience because they were acquired through phylogenetic adaptation. Gerhard Vollmer's *Evolutionäre Erkenntnistheorie* (1975) drew the corollary under the name *Mesokosmos*, the mesocosm: the band of the real, from the very small to the very large and from the instantaneous to the immemorial, at whose middle scales our



3.2 *Umwelten.* Uexküll's soap bubbles. The tick's world of three signs; the human mesocosm, enlarged by the instruments numbered at its edge; Tillinghast's resonator, which bursts the bubble and discloses beings that were always there; and other bubbles, the worlds of other beings, in which we figure as mere signals (section 3.5).

perceptual and cognitive apparatus evolved and to which alone it is fitted. Beyond that band, at the scales of quantum events, cosmological distances, and geological time, intuition fails because it was never selected to succeed. Richard Dawkins later popularized the concept as the "Middle World," glimpsed through a slit as narrow as the eyehole of a burka. J. B. S. Haldane had stated the conclusion in 1927, the year "The Colour Out of Space" appeared, in a sentence that could serve as the Mythos's scientific motto: the universe is not only queerer than we suppose but "queerer than we can suppose." The mesocosm is the biological ground of Lovecraft's mercy. We cannot correlate all our contents because the apparatus that correlates was built for the middle of the world, and the contents that would complete the pattern lie at its edges.

The history of science is, from this perspective, a history of resonators. Robert Hooke's *Micrographia* (1665) unfolded a flea the size of a page, and Leeuwenhoek's

letters to the Royal Society revealed animalcules swarming in every drop of water: the microscope disclosed a coexisting world as crowded and as indifferent as Tillinghast's. The nineteenth century added radiations beyond the visible, infrared and ultraviolet at its opening and radio waves in 1887, and in December 1895 the X-ray photograph of the hand of Röntgen's wife, Anna Bertha, who is said to have exclaimed on seeing her own bones that she had seen her death. Lovecraft wrote in the wake of these extensions of the Umwelt and of their casualties. "From Beyond" was composed in November 1920, as the influenza pandemic that had killed tens of millions through an agent no one had yet seen was subsiding; "The Colour Out of Space" was composed in March 1927, while the American press was reporting the slow poisoning of the radium dial-painters of New Jersey by a luminous substance that destroyed them from within. The Colour, invisible in its action and visible only as an unnameable glow, kills as radium killed, by slow disintegration. The mesocosm is the limit not only of our knowledge but of our safety, and the instruments that carry knowledge beyond it carry danger back.

Pnakotus: The Archive of the Great Race and the Subject as Specimen 3.6

"The Shadow out of Time" (1934–35) is the culmination of the Miskatonic method because it is the tale in which the correlator discovers himself correlated. Nathaniel Wingate Peaslee, professor of political economy at Miskatonic, collapses during a lecture on 14 May 1908 and recovers on 27 September 1913, having lived the intervening years as a different personality, a scholar of strange intensity who haunted libraries, studied forbidden books, and travelled to remote regions. In dreams that pursue him afterward he learns what happened. His body had been occupied by a mind of the Great Race of Yith, a species that escaped the death of its own world by projecting itself into the cone-shaped bodies of a terrestrial race some 150 million years ago, and that pursues, across every epoch accessible to its mental projection, a single civilizational project: the compilation of a complete history of the cosmos. Its method is exchange. A Yithian mind occupies a body in another era and studies that era from within, while the displaced native mind is held in a Yithian body in the past and required to write the history of its own time for the archives of the Great Race. In 1935 an expedition to the Great Sandy Desert of Western Australia uncovers the ruins of the archive city. Peaslee descends alone at night and finds, in a metal case upon the shelves, a manuscript in English in his own hand, written a hundred and fifty million years before his birth.

The Great Race is the archive incarnate, and the tale reads as a commentary on theories of the archive that it anticipates by half a century. Jacques Derrida's *Mal*

d'archive (1995) recalled that the Greek *arkheion* was the house of the archons, the magistrates who guarded official documents and held the power to interpret them, so that the archive involves a domiciliation, a house arrest of documents under the authority of guardians. The archive of the Great Race literalizes the figure: its documents are composed by authors held under house arrest, captive minds in borrowed bodies writing their histories for the guardians who have confined them. Derrida's title names a fever, the compulsive and even self-destructive desire to return to the origin through its record, and Peaslee's nocturnal descent into the ruins, against every rational counsel, in search of a document he dreads to find, is archive fever in its purest form. Michel Foucault had defined the archive in *L'Archéologie du savoir* (1969) as the law of what can be said, the system that governs the appearance of statements, and in the final paragraph of *Les Mots et les choses* (1966) he had predicted that "man," a recent invention of the human sciences, might be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. The Yithian archive is a Foucauldian archive at cosmic scale. Humanity appears in it not as the subject of knowledge but as one of its objects, a historical formation catalogued between the species that preceded it and the beetle-like species that will follow.

The Great Race also practises an anthropology, and its practice reverses the one Lovecraft's own culture conducted. The salvage ethnography associated with Franz Boas and his students set out to record the languages, customs, and objects of peoples it presumed to be vanishing, and Edward S. Curtis's twenty volumes of *The North American Indian* (1907–1930) gave that presumption its iconic images. The Great Race records every species before its extinction, and in its archive the professor of political economy becomes the native informant, the subject whose culture is extracted, transcribed, and shelved by an alien scholarship. Johannes Fabian's *Time and the Other* (1983) argued that anthropology constitutes its objects by a denial of coevalness, placing the peoples it studies in another time, the past of the observer's present. The Yithians perform the reversal literally: they inhabit the remote past and study the human present as their own distant future, so that humanity is placed in another time with respect to an observer who is not human. Lovecraft, who imagined himself an eighteenth-century gentleman and regarded many of his contemporaries as survivals from a lower stage of history, wrote a tale in which the gentleman is the specimen and the survival.

The discovery of the manuscript is the most vertiginous moment in the corpus because it unites the Ptolemaic and Copernican madnesses distinguished in Chapter 1. The cosmos has preserved Peaslee's handwriting, the Ptolemaic signal of personal significance, and it has preserved it as one record among millions, the Copernican humiliation of insignificance. Derrida's analysis of the signature in "Signature événement contexte" (1971) holds that a mark can function as a signature only because

it is iterable, repeatable in the absence of its author and therefore detachable from him. Peaslee's handwriting in the archive is iterability as horror: the trace of the self, repeated a hundred and fifty million years before the self, in a context the self never chose. Then the proof is lost. Fleeing, Peaslee lets fall the case, and he returns to the surface with no evidence at all. The tale ends in the condition of the paranoid, complete certainty without any proof that could be shown to another, and Peaslee closes his letter to his son by entertaining the hope that the experience was wholly or partly hallucination. The mercy of the opening sentence returns by accident, through a dropped case, and as a wish.

The theory of that mercy had been written in 1874. In the second of his *Unzeitgemäße Betrachtungen*, "Vom Nutzen und Nachtheil der Historie für das Leben," Nietzsche argued that *zu allem Handeln gehört Vergessen*, that all action requires forgetting, and that a surfeit of history is a disease that paralyses life; Borges's "Funes el memorioso" (1942) imagined a man incapable of forgetting and therefore incapable of thought, since to think is to forget differences. The Great Race, which forgets nothing, is the historical species of Nietzsche's diagnosis raised to its maximum, and human forgetting appears beside it as the precondition of human life. Our own civilization has meanwhile begun to build Pnakotus. The Svalbard Global Seed Vault (2008) and the Arctic World Archive (2017) store the genetic and digital inheritance of the species in Arctic permafrost, and in 2020 a snapshot of the world's public software repositories was deposited there on film designed to last a thousand years. The nearest analogue to the Yithian project, however, is not a vault but a corpus: the textual archives on which large language models are trained, which gather the written records of the species at a scale no library has approached, largely without the knowledge of their authors, in order to produce an intelligence that has, in a limited sense, read our histories. Chapter 7 returns to the analogy. Here it suffices to observe that the archive of the Great Race, once the Mythos's most fantastic invention, now describes an engineering programme.

3.7 Comparative Coda: Lem, the Strugatskys, VanderMeer, Found Footage, the SCP Foundation

The Miskatonic method has generated three later families of fiction: narratives of correlation that fails, narratives of correlation administered, and narratives of correlation played. The first is Stanisław Lem's. *Solaris* (1961) imagines a century of Solaristics, the science devoted to a planet-covering ocean that may or may not be intelligent, and Kris Kelvin's reading in the station library surveys its result: a vast literature of classification, of mimoids, symmetriads, and asymmetriads, and of hypotheses that cancel one another, a correlation without convergence. The ocean, meanwhile, correlates its

observers, reading their memories and returning them as living simulacra, so that the alien understands the human archive while the human cannot read the alien at all; the cyberneticist Gibarian has killed himself before Kelvin arrives. Lem's conclusion, voiced by Snaut, is that human beings do not want other worlds but mirrors, and his novel converts Lovecraftian horror into an epistemological humility that Andrei Tarkovsky's film (1972) turned toward grief. *His Master's Voice* (1968) relocates the method to a military-scientific project in the Nevada desert, where specialists attempt to decode a neutrino signal from space and succeed chiefly in projecting onto it their own fears and ambitions. In Lem, correlation fails because the alien exceeds it. In Lovecraft, it succeeds, and the human cannot survive the success.

Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972) states the doctrine of statistical independence with unsurpassed economy. Aliens have visited the Earth and left behind Zones littered with artefacts whose purpose no one can determine, and the physicist Valentine Pilman proposes that the Visitation was a roadside picnic: travellers stopped, ate, and drove on, leaving debris among which the insects of the meadow now crawl and speculate. The Visitation was not about us at all. Science, institutionalized as an international institute, accumulates artefacts and theories without understanding, while the stalkers who enter the Zone illegally survive by a folk empiricism of thrown bolts and inherited superstition. Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) reduced the Zone to a sacred, overgrown landscape and gave the Miskatonic dilemma a single character: the Professor, who carries a bomb into the Zone to destroy the Room that grants wishes before anyone can misuse it, and who, like Dyer warning off the Starkweather-Moore expedition, believes that some knowledge must be destroyed rather than shared. After 1986 the exclusion zone around Chernobyl, with its own illegal stalkers, gave the fiction an uncanny real-world double, which the video game *S.T.A.L.K.E.R.: Shadow of Chernobyl* (2007) fused with its source.

The second family administers correlation. Jeff VanderMeer's Southern Reach novels, *Annihilation*, *Authority*, and *Acceptance* (all 2014), to which *Absolution* (2024) has since been added, send expeditions into Area X, a coastal region sealed after an unexplained Event, under the direction of a secretive government agency. The members of the twelfth expedition are named only by their disciplines, the biologist, the anthropologist, the surveyor, and the psychologist, so that the interdisciplinary team of Lovecraft's opening sentence enters the anomaly in person and is dissolved by it. At the heart of the Zone, a descending structure that the biologist insists on calling a tower is inscribed with a sermon written in living fungal letters by an unseen hand: a text that writes itself in a medium made of organisms, a *Necronomicon* that is alive. *Authority* turns from the Zone to the bureaucracy that studies it and finds there the same failure in administrative form, files, protocols, and hoarded specimens that document everything and explain nothing. Alex Garland's film *Annihilation* (2018)

renders the Zone as the Shimmer, a field that refracts genomes as a prism refracts light, so that correlation becomes a biological process, the mixing of every organism with every other.

Found-footage cinema transposed the Lovecraftian dossier into moving images. *The Blair Witch Project* (1999) presents the recovered tapes of three student filmmakers who set out to document a local legend, interview its witnesses, and map its sites, and who are destroyed by what their documentation discloses; its final image, of a figure standing with his face to a corner, is the last datum of a dossier whose compilers did not survive it. Joel Anderson's *Lake Mungo* (2008), a mock documentary in which a grieving Australian family examines the photographs and videos of their drowned daughter, culminates in footage, recorded on her telephone at the dry lake of the title, of the daughter encountering her own corpse walking toward her out of the dark: Peaslee's handwriting rendered as an image. The network-native genre known as analog horror, from Kris Straub's *Local 58* (2015) to Alex Kister's *The Mandela Catalogue* (2021), fabricates emergency broadcasts, instructional videotapes, and public-service announcements in the degraded textures of obsolete media, so that the media of the late twentieth century themselves become the found documents of an Outside.

The most complete contemporary realization of the Miskatonic method, however, is the SCP Foundation, a collaborative fiction that originated on an imageboard in 2007 and grew into a wiki of many thousands of entries. Each entry takes the form of a containment document for an anomalous object or entity, with an item number, an object class, special containment procedures, and a description, written in the dispassionate prose of an institution whose motto is "Secure. Contain. Protect." The Foundation is Miskatonic University reorganized as a security bureaucracy, and its shared format, followed by thousands of authors, realizes the Mythos-as-protocol defined in Chapter 1 at a scale Lovecraft's correspondence could not approach. Three of its conventions formalize the mercy of the opening sentence. Its documents are redacted, so that the reader encounters correlation interrupted by black bars and notices that data have been expunged. Its personnel are dosed with amnestics, drugs that erase the memory of what they have witnessed. And it classes certain anomalies as infohazards and cognitohazards, information that harms whoever comprehends it, a category that qntm's *There Is No Antimemetics Division* (2020) extended to ideas that cannot be remembered at all. In the Foundation, correlative horror has become a hazard class and mercy a procedure; and one of its object classes is named, with a wit Lovecraft might have appreciated, Euclid.

The third family plays the method. Lucas Pope's *Return of the Obra Dinn* (2018) casts the player as an insurance investigator who must establish the identity and fate of every soul aboard a merchant ship that has drifted back into port without its

crew, using a watch that reveals the frozen instant of each death; the player correlates accents, uniforms, positions, and fragments of speech into a ledger, and the monsters that destroyed the ship emerge as a by-product of the bookkeeping. Mobius Digital's *Outer Wilds* (2019) organizes its whole structure around a ship's log that records clues and draws the connections between them as a graph, and its player reconstructs, from the writings of an extinct alien civilization, the history of a universe at its end; its affect is wonder rather than dread, and it returns in Chapter 5 as the Mythos's most moving inversion. Across the three families the method persists while its affect varies: humility in Lem, absurd persistence in the Strugatskys, institutional dread in VanderMeer and the Foundation, pleasure in the puzzle. What does not vary is the point at which every version arrives, where the evidence has been assembled and language must say what it has found. That point is the subject of the next chapter.

Chapter Four



Analogia Monstri

The Unnamable, the Sublime, and the Theology of Failed Analogy

Wovon man nicht sprechen kann, darüber muß man schweigen.

Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, 7

The linguistic register

Chapter Four

Analogia Monstri

This chapter examines what happens to language at the point where correlation is complete and must be reported. It argues that Lovecraft's much-mocked vocabulary of the unnamable is the trace of a precise operation, here called the *analogia monstri*: a mode of predication that speaks of what exceeds human concepts through composite likenesses that confess their own failure. The chapter reconsiders the controversy over Lovecraft's style, the theories of the sublime and the numinous, the apophatic tradition of negative theology, and the scholastic doctrine of analogy, and then turns to the Gnostic background of Azathoth, the iconography of the tentacle, the invented languages of the Mythos, and the cults that worship without reciprocity.

4.1 Adjectival Excess and Its Critics: Wilson, Leiber, Harman

No feature of the Mythos has been more often ridiculed than its vocabulary. At every crisis Lovecraft's narrators reach for the same small stock of words: unnamable, nameless, indescribable, unutterable, blasphemous, eldritch, cyclopean, squamous, rugose, gibbous, non-Euclidean, daemoniac. The lexicon is partly an antiquarian inheritance, since Lovecraft took *eldritch* from Scots and preferred the archaic *daemoniac*, but its most revealing members are philological fossils. *Cyclopean* is itself a theory of nonhuman builders: the Greeks attributed the enormous fitted stones of Tiryns and Mycenae to the Cyclopes, as Pausanias reports (2.25.8), because they could not believe that human beings had raised them. The adjective that Lovecraft applies to nearly every ruin in the corpus thus carries within it the inference that the Mythos dramatizes, that structures beyond human capacity were built by someone other than humans.

Lovecraft anticipated his critics in a tale that serves as his ars poetica. In "The Unnamable" (1923) Randolph Carter and his friend Joel Manton, a high-school principal of rationalist convictions, sit at twilight on a seventeenth-century tomb in an Arkham burying-ground and debate whether anything can be unnamable.

Manton holds that every sensation can be described; Carter, that some things exceed the categories of description. The thing they are discussing then attacks them, and the tale ends with Manton, recovering in hospital, conceding the argument in its final line: "Carter, it was the unnamable!" The rationalist loses not by argument but by experience, and the scene anticipates the critical dispute of the following decades, in which Manton's part was taken by Edmund Wilson.

Wilson's review in *The New Yorker* in 1945 catalogued the adjectives as the symptom of an incapacity, an attempt to manufacture by repeated assertion the emotion the tales had failed to produce, and concluded that the only real horror in most of them was the horror of bad taste and bad art. The charge is not wholly unjust. The adjectives are formulaic, and their formulaic quality is one reason the Mythos proved so easy to imitate: the protocol described in Chapter 1 includes a vocabulary. But Wilson misidentified the function of the formula. Fritz Leiber observed that Lovecraft's climaxes characteristically confirm rather than reveal, bringing to completion a pattern the reader has already half assembled, and the observation exposes the logic of the adjectives. They do not describe the thing; they mark the place where description fails and the reader is required to complete the correlation that the sentence withholds. Michel Houellebecq defended the same excess as a deliberate paroxysm, a style that strains toward delirium because nothing less than delirium can register what the narrators confront.

The most rigorous defence is Graham Harman's. In *Weird Realism* he argues that Lovecraft's descriptions are built on gaps rather than predicates: a vertical gap, in which the object withdraws behind the qualities through which it is allusively approached, and a horizontal gap, in which the object fractures into a cubist excess of qualities that no unity can hold together. The paradigm is the bas-relief of Cthulhu, which suggests at once "an octopus, a dragon, and a human caricature," and whose frightfulness, the narrator adds, lay not in any of these but in the general outline of the whole. Harman shows that such sentences cannot be paraphrased without loss, because their force lies in the gap they open. The present chapter accepts the analysis and specifies its object. The gap that Lovecraft's adjectives mark is the gap between a completed correlation and the language available to report it: the narrator has assembled the pattern and lacks the words to say what it is. The adjectives are the grammatical trace of correlative horror, and they belong to a larger structure, older than Lovecraft and theological in origin, which the following sections reconstruct and which this thesis calls the *analogia monstri*.

4.2 The Sublime and the Numinous Reconsidered: Burke, Kant, Otto

The theory of the sublime began as a rhetoric. The treatise *Peri hupsous*, attributed to Longinus and transmitted to modern Europe through Boileau's translation of 1674, defined sublimity as the echo of a great soul and found it, remarkably for a pagan critic, in the sentence of Genesis in which God says "Let there be light" (9.9). Half a century after Boileau, Pope answered with a parody, *Peri Bathous, or the Art of Sinking in Poetry* (1728), a mock treatise on the techniques by which bad poets, straining for the sublime, collapse into the ridiculous. Lovecraft's style lives on the edge between these two treatises, and Wilson's indictment amounts to a charge of bathos. The charge has a buried etymology. *Bathos* is the Greek for depth, cognate with Democritus's *bythos* and with the *bathys* of Huxley's *Bathybius* (Chapter 2), and the Mythos is a bathos in both senses: an art that risks sinking into absurdity and an art whose subject is the deep. The two senses are connected. At the limit of human language, where it attempts to name what exceeds it, the sublime and the ridiculous become hard to tell apart, because the only available words are the words of the familiar, and the familiar, applied to the abyss, is comic. Lovecraft's bathos is not a failure of the sublime but its shadow, cast wherever language descends far enough.

Burke supplied the doctrine of obscurity. To make anything very terrible, he argued in the *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757), obscurity seems in general to be necessary, and his chosen example was Milton's portrait of Death at the gate of Hell, "If shape it might be call'd that shape had none," of which he wrote that all is "dark, uncertain, confused, terrible, and sublime to the last degree." Milton's Death is the ancestor of every shapeless thing in the Mythos, from the invisible twin of "The Dunwich Horror" to the shoggoths. But Lovecraft revised Burke's doctrine in a way that is easily missed. His tales are not obscure; they are exact in their dates, places, instruments, and procedures, and Lovecraft advised that a weird tale be written with the care one would give to an actual hoax, realistic in every particular except the one marvel it exists to present. The technique is precision at the periphery and obscurity at the core. Burkean darkness is confined to a single point and surrounded by a documentary realism that makes the darkness credible, so that the reader experiences not vagueness but a sharply bounded hole in an otherwise sharp picture.

Kant's *Critique of the Power of Judgment* (1790) contains two concepts more exact than Burke's for the Mythos's purposes. The sublime, Kant observed, may be encountered even in a formless object (§23), insofar as limitlessness is represented in it; and in §26 he distinguished from the sublime proper both the colossal, the presentation of a concept almost too great for any presentation, and the monstrous. An object is monstrous, *ungeheuer*, when by its magnitude it annihilates the purpose that

constitutes its concept. Kant placed the monstrous outside the pure judgment of the sublime, together with natural things whose concept already involves a determinate end, precisely because it confounds the concept through which it must be judged. The Mythos is built on Kant's excluded term. Its entities are monstrous in exactly his sense, things whose presentation destroys the concept under which we try to present them, so that an octopus that is also a dragon and a man is no longer an octopus, a dragon, or a man. Lovecraft's aesthetic is a sublime of the *Ungeheure*: a sublime of what Kant ruled out of the sublime.

Rudolf Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) completed the theory by locating the root of religion in a non-rational experience, the numinous, before which the subject feels a creature-feeling (*Kreaturgefühl*), the sense of being a creature submerged in its own nothingness before an overwhelming power. Otto held that the numinous cannot be grasped in concepts, only indicated by ideograms, analogical expressions such as the wrath of God that point toward what they cannot define, and he regarded the fear of ghosts and the thrill of the horror tale as degraded offshoots of the same primal dread. Lovecraft's cosmic fear is Otto's daemonic dread restored to its full scale and stripped of the holy, and his adjectives are ideograms in Otto's sense, analogical pointers toward what exceeds conceptual capture. One element of Otto's analysis, however, acquires in the Mythos a literal force that Otto could not have intended. Creature-feeling, for Otto, is an affect with no implication about origins. In *At the Mountains of Madness* it becomes a historical fact: terrestrial life really is the creature of an older power, the Elder Things, and the creature-feeling of the narrators is simply accurate. The Mythos offers creaturehood without a Creator, a dependence upon makers who were neither holy nor concerned.

Via Negativa: Pseudo-Dionysius, Eckhart, Cusa 4.3

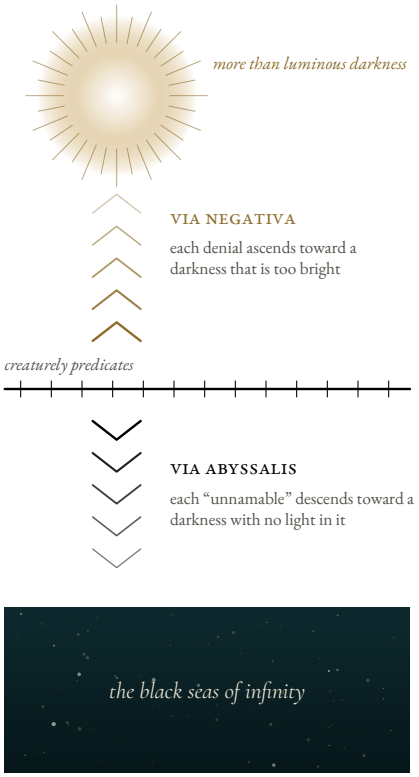
The lexicon of the unnamable is older than the Gothic. Its source is the apophatic theology bequeathed to the Christian West by the sixth-century author who wrote under the name of Dionysius the Areopagite. *The Divine Names* teaches that God is at once nameless and named by every name, beyond being and therefore beyond every predicate drawn from beings; *The Mystical Theology* urges the reader to leave behind sense and intellect alike and to be raised toward the superessential ray of the divine darkness, as Moses entered the cloud on Sinai, into a darkness the treatise calls more than luminous. The apophatic method proceeds by negation: God is not this, not that, not even being, and the negations, rightly pursued, carry the soul past the last concept into a union no concept can describe. Lovecraft's narrators use the same vocabulary, unnamable, indescribable, formless, incomprehensible, and the correspondence is close enough that Eugene Thacker has proposed reading the horror

tradition as a kind of dark mysticism. The correspondence nonetheless conceals an inversion, which this section seeks to state exactly.

The anonymous fourteenth-century *Cloud of Unknowing* distilled the apophatic programme into a sentence: by love God may be gotten and held, but by thought never. Meister Eckhart pressed it further, distinguishing the God of the creeds from the Godhead beyond him, a silent desert and an abyss (*abgrunt*) in which the ground of God and the ground of the soul are one, and praying in one of his German sermons that God might rid him of God; in 1329 a papal bull condemned propositions drawn from his works. Henry Vaughan gave the tradition its finest English lines in "The Night" (1655): "There is in God, some say, / A deep but dazzling darkness." Lovecraft's abyss keeps the first of Vaughan's adjectives and loses the second. It is deep, and it does not dazzle.

Nicholas of Cusa's *De docta ignorantia* (1440) supplied the axiom that joins the apophatic tradition to the cosmology of Chapter 2. Cusa takes as his starting point the scholastic principle that there is no proportion between the finite and the infinite, *finiti ad infinitum nulla proportio* (I.3), and concludes that the wise mind is the one that knows its own ignorance. From the same principle he drew a cosmology that anticipated Bruno: the machine of the world has its centre everywhere and its circumference nowhere, and the Earth, which is not the centre, moves (II.12). Koyré began *From the Closed World to the Infinite Universe* with Cusa for this reason. For the present argument the first formula is decisive. In Latin *proportio* is the standard rendering of the Greek *analogia*, so that Cusa's axiom states that analogy, which is proportion, fails at the boundary of the finite. Learned ignorance is the posture of a mind that accepts this failure as the condition of its approach to God.

The inversion can now be stated. The apophatic negations ascend. Each denial removes a creaturely predicate from God in order to bring the soul nearer to a reality that exceeds predication by excess of being; the darkness into which they lead is dark because it is too bright, and the unknowing is a form of union. Lovecraft's negations descend. Each "unnamable" marks not a reality too full for concepts but a reality indifferent to them, and the darkness into which the narrators are led is dark because there is no light in it. Dionysius's more than luminous darkness becomes the black seas of infinity. Learned ignorance, which in Cusa is the mind's fitting humility before God, becomes in Lovecraft the mercy of the opening sentence, a merely biological incapacity that keeps the mind from a knowledge that would destroy it. The Mythos preserves the via negativa as a grammar and reverses it as a direction. It is not a way of negation toward the One but a *via abyssalis* toward the bottom of the world, and its mystic is the scholar who arrives there and does not return.



	analogia entis Aquinas; Cajetan	*analogia monstri* "The Colour Out of Space"
WAY OF CAUSALITY	God named from his effects	the thing produces colour-like effects
WAY OF NEGATION	every creaturely limitation denied of him	not colour in any sense we know
WAY OF EMINENCE	the perfection affirmed in a higher mode	replaced by incommensurability: off the scale

A PROPORTION WITH A MISSING TERM

as colour is to us, so this is to _____

The sentence breaks off where the fourth term should stand.

4.1 ***Via negativa, via abyssalis.*** The apophatic negations ascend toward a darkness that is dark because it is too bright; Lovecraft's descend toward a darkness with no light in it. Of the three ways by which Aquinas named God, the *analogia monstri* keeps causality and negation and replaces eminence with incommensurability: a proportion with a missing term (sections 4.3 and 4.4).

The Collapse of the *Analogia Entis*: Aquinas, Przywara, Barth, and "The Colour Out of Space" 4.4

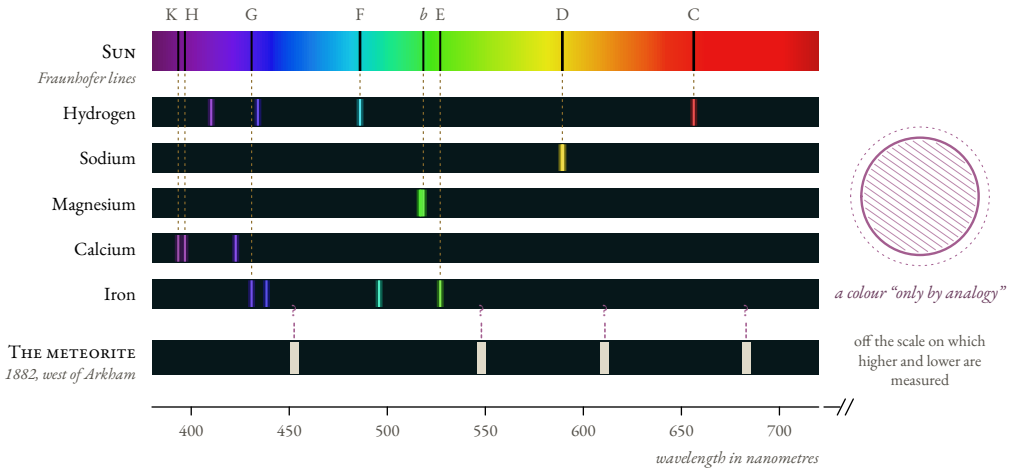
Between apophasis and affirmation the scholastic tradition built a middle way, and it is this middle way that the Mythos most precisely dismantles. Thomas Aquinas asked how words drawn from creatures can be said truly of God, and answered that they are said neither univocally, with the same meaning, nor equivocally, with unrelated meanings, but analogically, *secundum analogiam, idest proportionem*, according to a proportion (*Summa theologiae* I, q. 13, a. 5). The analogical name is grounded in a real relation: creatures participate in being, and God is the cause of their perfections, so that goodness said of God is truly goodness, possessed in a supereminent mode that exceeds our grasp of it. Aquinas organized such predication into three ways inherited from Dionysius: the way of causality, by which God is named from his effects; the way of negation, by which every creaturely limitation is denied of him; and the way

of eminence, by which the perfection is affirmed of him in a higher mode. Cardinal Cajetan systematized the doctrine as the analogy of proper proportionality in *De nominum analogia* (1498), and it came to be called the *analogia entis*, the analogy of being.

The Fourth Lateran Council (1215) had given the doctrine its governing caution: between Creator and creature no likeness can be noted without a greater unlikeness being noted between them, a *maior dissimilitudo*. Erich Przywara made the formula the centre of his *Analogia Entis* (1932), interpreting analogy as a movement in which every similarity opens onto an ever greater dissimilarity, toward a God who is always greater, *Deus semper maior*. In the same year Karl Barth, in the preface to the first volume of his *Church Dogmatics*, called the *analogia entis* the invention of Antichrist and the one serious reason for not becoming Catholic, because it set God and creature on a common scale of being and so allowed human reason to speak of God apart from revelation; he proposed instead an *analogia fidei*, grounded only in God's self-disclosure. The Mythos, composed during this controversy and in ignorance of it, refutes both parties at once. Against Przywara it denies that any common being spans the gap, any participation that would ground the analogy; against Barth it denies that any revelation exists to replace it. What remains is the bare structure of Lateran IV, every likeness exceeded by a greater unlikeness, with the divine term removed.

"The Colour Out of Space" (1927) is the theological centre of the corpus because it stages this collapse at the level of a single word. In 1882 a meteorite falls on the farm of Nahum Gardner west of Arkham. The professors of Miskatonic examine it: it shrinks, it stays hot, it shows under the spectroscope shining bands that belong to no known element, and it contains globules of a hue which, as the narrator reports from the testimony of the old farmer Ammi Pierce decades later, could be called a colour "only by analogy." A slow, systematic disintegration follows. The crops grow lush and inedible, the animals deform, the family sickens into grey brittleness and madness, and the thing that has lodged in the well finally rises into the sky, leaving the blasted heath that the narrator, a surveyor for a new reservoir, has come to measure for flooding. The tale's final judgment is that this was just a colour out of space, "a frightful messenger from unformed realms of infinity beyond all Nature as we know it." The word *colour* is applied to the entity as *goodness* is applied to God in Aquinas, by analogy; but the Thomist analogy rests on participation and opens upward into eminence, while Lovecraft's rests on nothing and opens onto the unformed. The way of causality is preserved, since the thing produces colour-like effects. The way of negation is preserved, since it is not colour in any sense we know. But the way of eminence is replaced by incommensurability. The Colour is not higher than our colours; it lies off the scale on which higher and lower can be measured.

The structure can therefore be defined.



4.2 *Correlation in the spectroscope.* Kirchhoff and Bunsen read the chemistry of the Sun by matching the dark lines of its spectrum to the bright lines of terrestrial elements. The meteorite of "The Colour Out of Space" shows bands that belong to no known element, and its colour lies off the scale altogether. The elements' lines are drawn at their true wavelengths; the meteorite's are imagined (sections 2.5 and 4.4).

The analogia monstri is the mode of predication in which a finite language speaks of what exceeds it through composite likenesses that confess their own failure, retaining the ways of causality and negation while replacing the way of eminence with incommensurability.

It is the linguistic form of correlative horror. Analogy, as Cusa's axiom reminds us, is proportion, a correlation of ratios in which one term is known through its relation to others; the *analogia monstri* is a correlation whose ratio cannot be computed, a proportion with a missing term. Its sentences have the grammar of Cajetan's proportionality, *as colour is to us, so this is to*, and they break off where the fourth term should stand.

The adaptations of the tale confirm the analysis by the difficulty they have had with it, and two have solved the problem with real ingenuity. Huan Vu's German production *Die Farbe* (2010) is shot in black and white, so that the colour appears as the only colour in the film, defined not by its hue but by its difference from a world without hue. Richard Stanley's *Color Out of Space* (2019) renders it as a saturated

magenta, and the choice is more exact than it may appear. Magenta is an extra-spectral colour, corresponding to no single wavelength of light, produced by the visual system when the receptors for red and blue are stimulated without those for green. It exists only in the perceiver, a hue that physics can describe only by analogy, and the film chose, perhaps without knowing it, the one visible colour that already lies outside the spectrum.

4.5 The Blind Idiot God: Gnostic Acosmism, Jonas, and a Cosmos Without a Pleroma

At the centre of the Mythos's cosmology sits Azathoth, whom the tales call the blind idiot god and place at the heart of all infinity, a mindless nucleus of chaos attended by drums and flutes (section 2.4). The epithets have a precise and almost certainly unconscious precedent. In the cosmogonies of the ancient Gnostics, the material world is the work not of the true God but of an ignorant demiurge, born from the error of the aeon Sophia, who fashions the cosmos and its ruling powers, the archons, and then boasts that he is God and there is no other. The *Apocryphon of John* gives him three names: Yaltabaoth, Saklas, and Samael. Saklas is Aramaic for fool; Samael, as the *Hypostasis of the Archons* explains when a voice rebukes the demiurge's boast, means god of the blind. The creator of the visible cosmos is, in these sources, a blind and foolish god, which is to say a blind idiot god. Before the discovery of the Nag Hammadi codices in 1945 these names survived only in scattered heresiological and Manichaean sources, and there is no evidence that Lovecraft encountered them; the convergence is structural rather than genealogical, and it is the more striking for that.

The Gnostic cosmos is a prison. Its planetary spheres are ruled by archons who enforce fate (*heimarmenē*); within some human beings, however, lies a spark of the divine substance fallen from the Pleroma, the fullness of the true God beyond the cosmos, and salvation comes through *gnōsis*, a saving knowledge that awakens the spark, reveals the prison for what it is, and enables the soul to ascend past the archons to its home. In Gnosticism, knowledge liberates. The Mythos retains the Gnostic diagnosis and deletes the Gnostic cure. Its cosmos too is ruled by a blind idiot at the centre and by powers indifferent to human welfare; its scholars too acquire a secret knowledge transmitted in forbidden books. But there is no Pleroma beyond the prison and no spark within the prisoner, and the knowledge, far from liberating, binds the knower more tightly to the cosmos it reveals. The Mythos is Gnosticism without a Pleroma. Its gnosis does not open the prison; it shows the prisoner that there is no outside to escape to, only an Outside stranger still.

Valentinian Gnosticism sharpens the inversion. According to Irenaeus (*Adversus haereses* I.1.1), the Valentinians placed at the summit of all things a perfect, invisible,

and incomprehensible Aeon whom they called the Forefather and *Bythos*, the Depth, who abode through boundless ages in profound serenity and quiet, with Silence as his consort. The Valentinian first principle is an abyss, and it is serene; the Old Ones of "The Dunwich Horror," as Chapter 2 observed, also walk serene. But the Valentinian depth is the height, the source of the Pleroma and the goal of the soul's return, whereas Lovecraft's depth is merely deep: R'lyeh lies at the bottom of the Pacific, not at the summit of the aeons. Democritus located truth in the *bythos* (section 2.1); the Valentinians made the *bythos* God; Lovecraft returned it to the ocean floor.

Hans Jonas supplied the philosophical frame for this convergence. His *Gnosis und spätantiker Geist* (1934) and *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) read ancient Gnosticism through the categories of Heidegger's existential analytic, and in the essay appended to the latter's second edition, "Gnosticism, Existentialism, and Nihilism," he drew the comparison explicitly. Gnostic man and modern man are both thrown into an alien world; but the Gnostic world is hostile, a demonic order that still takes humanity seriously enough to imprison it, whereas the world of modern science is merely indifferent. Jonas concluded that the modern situation is the more radical, and that only the indifferent cosmos is the true abyss, the really bottomless pit. This is precisely the distinction drawn in section 2.7 between a negative correlation and a zero correlation, and it permits a final description of the Mythos's place in the history of religion. Lovecraft borrowed the imagery of Gnosticism, its blind creator, its ruling powers, its forbidden knowledge, its cosmic prison, to dramatize the modern indifference that Jonas identified as Gnosticism's more terrible successor. Azathoth is the Gnostic demiurge rendered indifferent: not the arrogant Saklas who claims to be God, but a blindness and an idiocy that claim nothing at all.

The afterlives of the Mythos have repeatedly tried to restore the missing Pleroma. Derleth's Elder Gods, benign powers who imprisoned the Old Ones and may yet protect humanity, are a Pleroma reinstalled above Lovecraft's cosmos, and his redaction can be described, in the terms of this section, as a re-Gnosticization: the return of a hostile cosmos under a benevolent beyond. The Gnostic revival in later popular culture shows the same tendency, from the Black Iron Prison broken open by a benevolent intelligence in Philip K. Dick's *VALIS* (1981) to the red pill of *The Matrix* (1999), a sacrament of liberating gnosis. In each case knowledge frees. The Mythos is the rare modern fiction that keeps the Gnostic cosmos and refuses the Gnostic consolation, and the refusal is what makes it, among the fictions of forbidden knowledge, the one Jonas would have recognized as truly modern.

4.6 The Tentacle and the Real: Miéville, Lacan, Kristeva

China Miéville has observed that the tentacle, a limb all but absent from Western teratological iconography before the Weird, became the Weird's signature after it, and he has suggested that the Weird's crisis of representation belongs to the catastrophe of the Great War. The tentacle's ascent can nonetheless be traced through the century before Lovecraft. Erik Pontoppidan's natural history of Norway (1752–53) gave learned form to the kraken, and Tennyson's "The Kraken" (1830) imagined it sleeping far beneath the thunders of the upper deep in "His ancient, dreamless, uninvaded sleep," until it rises at the end of time to be seen once by men and angels and to die upon the surface. Victor Hugo's *Les Travailleurs de la mer* (1866) made the octopus a modern monster, Jules Verne's *Vingt mille lieues sous les mers* (1870) set giant cephalopods against the *Nautilus*, and H. G. Wells gave tentacles to the sea raiders of 1896 and to the Martians of *The War of the Worlds* (1898). Lovecraft inherited the image from this line and transformed it at one decisive point. Tennyson's kraken sleeps without dreams; Cthulhu waits dreaming, and his dreams leak into the minds of sculptors and poets on four continents. The sleeper of the deep has become a transmitter.

The tentacle's power is taxonomic before it is aesthetic. Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) argued that the abominations of Leviticus are not arbitrary but classificatory: unclean creatures are those that confound the categories of a created order in which each kind belongs to its element and bears the marks of its kind. Among them is whatever in the waters has neither fins nor scales (Leviticus 11:12), which is to say, among much else, the cephalopod. The tentacled sea-creature is an abomination in the exact sense, a creature of the waters lacking the signs of a creature of the waters; and the Levitical prohibition of mixtures, of breeding diverse kinds, sowing mingled seed, and wearing mingled cloth (Leviticus 19:19), extends the logic to every hybrid. Lovecraft's favourite term of condemnation, *blasphemous*, often mocked as an atheist's affectation, recovers in this light a precise meaning. The blasphemy of the Mythos is categorial, an offence not against God but against kinds, and Cthulhu, at once octopus, dragon, and man, is a mixture of exactly the sort Leviticus forbids. Chapter 6 will show how the same logic of forbidden mixture structures the corpus's horror of human hybridity.

The word *monster* carries its own theory. Augustine reports in the *City of God* (XXI.8) that monsters are so called from showing, *a monstrando*, because they signify something by what they show, and Roman antiquarians derived the word from *monere*, to warn. The monster is a showing that warns, and the *analogia monstri* is accordingly an analogy of the warning as well as of the monster: every Lovecraftian description shows what cannot be shown and warns against seeking to see it. Modern

teratology, from Ambroise Paré's *Des monstres et prodiges* (1573) to the classifications of anomalies by the Geoffroy Saint-Hilaires in the 1830s, sought to naturalize the monster as a lawful deviation from type, and Lovecraft the materialist accepted the naturalization; his monsters are lawful organisms. But they deviate from no type we possess, and so they remain signs. What they signify is the limit of our types.

Psychoanalysis named the region the monsters inhabit. Jacques Lacan called the Real that which resists symbolization absolutely, and in his seminar of 1959–60 he gave the name *das Ding*, the Thing, to the unrepresentable kernel around which desire and signification turn. In an earlier seminar (1954–55), commenting on Freud's dream of Irma's injection, he described the moment at which Freud, looking into his patient's throat, confronts a formless flesh that ought never to be seen, an encounter with the Real that he associated with the head of the Medusa. Jean-Paul Sartre had given the formless its existential analysis in *L'Être et le néant* (1943), where the viscous, clinging and yielding at once, figures as the revenge of the in-itself upon the for-itself; and in *La Nausée* (1938) his Roquentin, contemplating the root of a chestnut tree, watches the names fall away from things until existence itself appears as a soft, monstrous, superfluous mass. Sartre's root is a secular apophasis, the moment at which language withdraws and the thing appears unnamed. Lovecraft's narrators undergo the same withdrawal, with one difference: what appears to them when the names fall away is not existence in general but something with an anatomy.

The tentacle has acquired, since Lovecraft, an unexpected scientific warrant. Peter Godfrey-Smith's *Other Minds* (2016) describes the octopus as the nearest thing on Earth to an intelligent alien: a mind that evolved independently of ours from a common ancestor some six hundred million years ago, distributed through arms that hold the majority of its neurons and appear to explore and decide with a measure of autonomy. The cephalopod is, in the strictest sense, an intelligence by analogy, a mind whose likeness to ours includes a greater unlikeness. Cthulhu's octopoid head was chosen for its horror. It turns out to have been the most accurate image available to Lovecraft's century of what a convergent, nonhuman intelligence might actually look like.

Xenoglossia: R'lyehian, Aklo, and the Grammar of the Unspeakable 4.7

The *analogia monstri* has a phonology. The cult's formula in "The Call of Cthulhu," *Ph'nglui mglw'nafh Cthulhu R'lyeh wgah'nagl fhtagn*, glossed as "In his house at R'lyeh dead Cthulhu waits dreaming," is built from consonant clusters and apostrophes designed to resist the English mouth, and Lovecraft explained in a letter of 1934 that the name Cthulhu was only a clumsy human attempt to record a word formed

by organs unlike ours. The names of the Mythos are transliterations with a missing original, sounds pronounced by analogy. Their typographic signature, the apostrophe, is the mark of an elision: it stands for the part of the word the human apparatus cannot produce. Even *Aklo*, which Lovecraft borrowed from Machen's "The White People" and set in Wilbur Whateley's diary, where the boy records that he has learned the Aklo for the Sabaoth, is a language attested only by its name.

The grammar of the unspeakable is a grammar of deferral. Lovecraft's periodic sentences withhold their nouns, accumulating clauses of approach until the thing is named, or fails to be, at the period; and when no noun can be supplied the sentence falls back on the pronoun *it* or the indefinite noun *thing*, the two words of English that name without describing. The convention has proved fertile: John W. Campbell's "Who Goes There?" (1938) and John Carpenter's *The Thing* (1982), and Stephen King's *It* (1986), whose shape-changing predator comes from a realm beyond the universe, take their titles from the Mythos's placeholder words. The most affecting moment of xenoglossia in the corpus runs, however, in the opposite direction. At the climax of "The Dunwich Horror," the invisible twin of Wilbur Whateley, dying on Sentinel Hill as Armitage recites the formula that banishes it, abandons its inhuman ululation for English and cries out for its parent: "FATHER! FATHER! YOG-SOTHOTH!" The monster, at the last, speaks our language, and what it says is the most human thing in the tale.

The invocations of the Mythos belong to a longer history of languages that claim a nonhuman origin. The Pentecostal revival that began on Azusa Street in Los Angeles in 1906 restored glossolalia, the speaking in the tongues of men and of angels (1 Corinthians 13:1), to American religious life, and William Samarin's *Tongues of Men and Angels* (1972) later showed that such speech, however patterned its sounds, carries no semantics. Théodore Flournoy's *Des Indes à la planète Mars* (1900) studied the Genevan medium Hélène Smith, who in trance spoke and wrote a Martian language with its own alphabet, and the linguist Victor Henry showed in *Le langage martien* (1901) that its grammar and phonology were French in disguise. The angelic language that John Dee and Edward Kelley received through scrying in the 1580s, Enochian, has likewise proved under analysis to share much of the phonetic and syntactic structure of English. Lovecraft, who made Dee the English translator of the *Necronomicon*, shared the tradition's predicament: no human being can produce a genuinely inhuman language. What distinguishes the Mythos is its candour. Smith's Martian concealed its Frenchness; Lovecraft's letters confess that R'lyehian is an approximation. Its xenoglossia is the only one in the tradition that admits it is speaking by analogy.

Philosophy supplied an unexpected gloss. Wittgenstein's *Tractatus* (1921) ends by enjoining silence about whatever cannot be spoken, having conceded a little earlier

that *es gibt allerdings Unaussprechliches*, there is indeed the unspeakable, which shows itself and is the mystical (6.522). Within a decade, Robert E. Howard's invented book of *Nameless Cults* had acquired, within the Lovecraft circle, the German title *Unaussprechlichen Kulten*, which is famously ungrammatical, so that the book of unspeakable cults cannot even have its name spoken correctly. The contrast with the other great mythopoeia of the period is instructive. J. R. R. Tolkien, who confessed the "secret vice" of language-invention in a lecture of 1931, built his languages with complete grammars and let his legendarium grow from them, aspiring, as he later told Milton Waldman, to dedicate a body of legend to England. Tolkien's linguistic plenitude grounds a secondary world whose coherence makes belief possible and whose characteristic turn is the eucatastrophe, the sudden joyous reversal; Lovecraft's linguistic scarcity grounds a world whose incoherence is the point and whose turn is what Tolkien called the dyscatastrophe. Tolkien set out to give England a mythology. Lovecraft, without intending it, gave one to New England. A final irony completes the picture. Lovecraft despised literary modernism and parodied *The Waste Land* in a poem he called "Waste Paper"; yet the nearest relatives of his invocations in the literature of the century are the phonetic poems Hugo Ball recited at the Cabaret Voltaire in 1916 and Kurt Schwitters's *Ursonate* (1922–32). The Augustan enemy of the avant-garde composed its most widely recited sound poetry, and *Iä! Iä! Cthulhu fhtagn!* has been chanted far more often than "Karawane."

4.8 Worship Without Reciprocity: Mauss, Bataille, and the Cults of the Great Old Ones

If the *analogia monstri* governs what can be said of the Old Ones, the cults govern what can be done toward them, and the cults are the Mythos's theology in practice. The swamp-cult raided by Legrasse in 1907 dances in a ring about a monolith bearing the image of Cthulhu, its victims hanging from the trees; its doctrine, expounded under interrogation by Old Castro, holds that the Great Old Ones came from the stars, that they are not of flesh, that they cannot die but lie in R'lyeh until the stars come right, and that the cult exists to keep their memory alive and to free them when the time comes. The cult's function is in large part mnemonic: it is an archive of survival, as Chapter 5 will show. Around it the corpus gathers further congregations: the Greenland celebrants of Webb's report, the Whateleys of Dunwich, the Starry Wisdom church on Federal Hill in Providence, the human agents of the Mi-Go, and the Esoteric Order of Dagon in Innsmouth. What is remarkable about all of them except the last is the absence of exchange.

Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) showed that the gift, in the societies he surveyed, creates three obligations, to give, to receive, and to reciprocate, and that

sacrifice is a gift to the gods that binds them in turn; Henri Hubert and Mauss had earlier analysed sacrifice (1899) as a means of communication between the sacred and the profane. Religion, on this view, is an economy of exchange: *do ut des*, I give that you may give. The cults of the Old Ones give and receive nothing. Their offerings are not acknowledged, their prayers not answered, their gods not obligated. The Old Ones neither need nor notice the worship directed toward them, and the cult's only expectation is to be swept up, when the stars are right, in a release of power that will not distinguish its servants from anyone else. This is worship without reciprocity, and it inverts the question that Satan puts to God in the prologue to the Book of Job, whether Job fears God for nought (Job 1:9). Job's piety is tested by the withdrawal of reward. The cultist's piety never expected one.

Georges Bataille supplied the theory for which the cults are an instance. *La Part maudite* (1949) argued that every economy produces a surplus that must be spent unproductively, in luxury, festival, war, or sacrifice, and that the sovereign act is expenditure without return, modelled on the sun, which gives without ever receiving. Bataille's chosen example was Aztec sacrifice. Yet Aztec sacrifice was not, in its own terms, unreciprocated: the gods had sacrificed themselves to set the sun in motion, and human blood repaid a cosmic debt, so that one Nahuatl term for the offering means the payment of debts. Lovecraft's cults are more Bataillean than the Aztecs. Their expenditure is directed toward recipients who do not receive it, and their eschatology, in which liberated humanity will shout, kill, and revel beyond good and evil, is the festival of transgression raised to a permanent condition. Nor is the resemblance merely theoretical. Between 1936 and 1939 Bataille led a secret society, Acéphale, whose members met at night in the forest of Marly and which is said to have contemplated a human sacrifice that no one could be found to perform. Paris produced, in the very years of Lovecraft's last tales, a real intellectual cult of unreciprocated expenditure.

The cults clarify, finally, the place of correlative horror among the possible responses to the same knowledge. The cultist and the scholar know the same things. Old Castro knows what Thurston comes to know: that the Old Ones are real, that humanity is insignificant, that the stars will come right. The scholar completes the correlation and recoils, and his affect is horror; the cultist completes it and embraces it, and his affect is ecstasy. The cult is correlative horror converted into correlative rapture, the decision to join the pattern that annuls one's centrality rather than to suffer it. One cult in the corpus breaks this structure, and its exception will matter for the conclusion of this thesis. The Esoteric Order of Dagon is founded on exchange: Captain Obed Marsh learned from Pacific islanders a compact with the Deep Ones under which sacrifices and intermarriage were repaid with fish in abundance and with a strange gold, and Innsmouth prospered on the bargain. It is the only recip-

rocal relation between the human and the inhuman in the corpus; it is mediated by trade and by kinship; and Lovecraft presents it as the most degraded of all. Claude Lévi-Strauss's *Les Structures élémentaires de la parenté* (1949) would soon argue that society begins with exchange between groups, in his account the exchange of women. Innsmouth is the Mythos's one society in that sense, and its horror, which Chapter 6 analyses, is the horror of relation itself.

Comparative Coda: Job, Kafka's Odradek, Borges, Ito, Ligeti, *Bloodborne* 4.9

The oldest *analogia monstri* in the literature of the West is the speech of God from the whirlwind in the Book of Job. Job has demanded an account of his suffering, and the answer he receives is not an argument but an exhibition. "Where wast thou when I laid the foundations of the earth?" (38:4): God unfolds a creation whose scale and indifference to human measure are its whole point, a creation in which rain falls "on the earth, where no man is; on the wilderness, wherein there is no man" (38:26), and he concludes with two monsters, Behemoth and Leviathan, the latter a creature of terrible teeth whose like is not upon earth (41:33). Rudolf Otto read these chapters as the purest expression of the numinous in scripture, their beasts as *monstra* of the wholly other, and Carl Jung's *Antwort auf Hiob* (1952) read the God who speaks them as an unconscious and amoral power, more dangerous than the man he crushes because less aware of himself. God answers a moral question with monsters, and the answer is a sublime that does not include its listener. Lovecraft's cosmos is the whirlwind without the epilogue: no restoration of Job's fortunes, no doubled flocks, and no voice to speak from it at all.

Franz Kafka's "Die Sorge des Hausvaters" (1920) compressed the *analogia monstri* into a domestic parable. Odradek, who lives in the stairwells and corridors of a family house, looks like a flat star-shaped spool of thread with a little crossbar on which it can stand upright; the etymologies proposed for its name, Slavic and German, are equally uncertain and equally useless; it laughs a laugh such as can be produced only *ohne Lungen*, without lungs, which sounds like the rustling of fallen leaves. Everything that dies, the father reflects, has had some aim, some activity, on which it has worn itself out; this does not apply to Odradek, and the thought that it will outlive him is almost painful. Odradek resembles a spool and a star and is neither, and because it has no purpose it cannot die. It is the eternal lie of the Mythos in miniature: Cthulhu in the stairwell.

Borges's "There Are More Things" (1975), dedicated to Lovecraft's memory and titled after Hamlet's rebuke to Horatio's philosophy, transposes the analogy from description to furniture. The narrator enters a house near Buenos Aires that a mys-

terious new owner has rebuilt within, and finds it furnished for a body he cannot imagine: a long, high operating table in the form of a V, inclined planes in place of stairs, objects whose purpose he cannot infer. Reflecting that to see a thing one must first understand it, since an armchair presupposes the human body and its joints, he concludes that he cannot see what is in front of him, and he flees as something climbs the ramp. The story is the most precise literary gloss on Kant's dictum that intuitions without concepts are blind (Chapter 1). It reaches the monster only through its analogue, a body inferred from furniture, and the inference fails because the furniture presupposes a body that shares no proportion with ours.

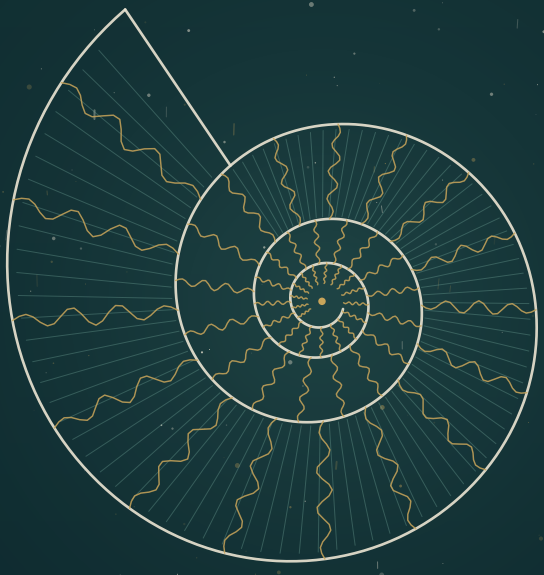
Junji Ito's manga *Uzumaki* (1998–99), adapted for television in 2024, makes the *analogia monstri* a pattern. The curse of the coastal town of Kurouzu-chō is not a creature but a form, the spiral, which begins as the obsession of one man who finds spirals everywhere, in shells, in whirlpools, in the curl of his own hair, and spreads through the town until bodies twist into spirals, children become snails, and the town itself is drawn down into an ancient spiral city that has always lain beneath it. Ito, who has acknowledged Lovecraft's influence, fuses the two preceding chapters of this thesis. The spiral is apophenia made literal, a pattern recognized everywhere until recognition becomes reality, and it is a monster that is nothing but a geometry, the logical end of the non-Euclidean horror traced in Chapter 2.

Music, which cannot name, approaches the *analogia monstri* most directly. György Ligeti's micropolyphony, in *Atmosphères* (1961), the *Requiem* (1963–65), and *Lux aeterna* (1966), multiplies voices into dense clusters in which no individual line can be heard, so that a correlation of many human voices produces the sound of something that is not a voice at all; Stanley Kubrick set these works, without the composer's permission, to the monolith and the Star Gate of *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), and they have since become the sound of the alien. The popular afterlife of the Mythos in music confirms the point by another route. Metallica's "The Call of Ktulu" (1984) is an instrumental, as if the unnamable could be set only without words, and the drone of Sunn O))) and the dark ambient of Lustmord abandon melody and rhythm for sustained masses of sound that are felt in the body before they are heard as music. Azathoth's court, with its idiot flutes, has found its real orchestras.

FromSoftware's *Bloodborne* (2015), directed by Hidetaka Miyazaki, is the most sophisticated translation of the Mythos's epistemology into the mechanics of a game. Its city of Yharnam is governed by a church that has built its medicine on blood drawn from the Great Ones, beings discovered when the scholars of Byrgenwerth College excavated the labyrinths of a vanished civilization beneath the city, and the scholars divided between those who sought the Great Ones through the blood and a master who taught that humanity needs more eyes, eyes lining the inside of the brain, as Tillinghast sought them in the pineal gland. The game measures the player's knowledge

in a resource called Insight, gained by encountering the Great Ones and their secrets and spent as currency. As Insight grows, the player begins to see what was always there, vast creatures clinging to the buildings of the city that were invisible before, and grows more vulnerable to Frenzy, a madness inflicted by what is seen. Knowledge reveals the coexisting world and exposes the knower to it: *Bloodborne* has made correlative horror a number on a screen. Across scripture and parable, metafiction and manga, music and play, the *analogia monstri* recurs as the mode in which human art presents what exceeds human concepts: by monsters in Job, by a purposeless thing in Kafka, by furniture in Borges, by pattern in Ito, by texture in Ligeti, by mechanics in Miyazaki. Each presentation is a likeness that confesses a greater unlikeness. It remains to ask what persists on the far side of that unlikeness, and for how long it has been waiting. That is the question of time, and of the eternal lie.

Chapter Five



The Eternal Lie

Deep Time, Survival, and the Undead Text

That is not dead which can eternal lie,
And with strange aeons even death may die.

Abdul Alhazred, as quoted in "The Nameless City," 1921

The temporal register

Chapter Five

The Eternal Lie

This chapter turns from language to time. It argues that the temporality of the Mythos is stratigraphic: the present is the uppermost layer of a deposit in which older things persist, and horror arises when the layers are correlated. The chapter follows this temporality through geology and thermodynamics, the anthropology of survivals and its occult derivatives, and the cyclical cosmologies of myth; it reads Lovecraft's couplet on the dead that can eternally lie through Levinas and Warburg; and it pursues the second sense of the couplet's pun, the lie as fiction, into the occult afterlife in which an invented grimoire acquired real editions. It ends with the nuclear semioticians who tried to warn the remote future about a buried danger, a project this thesis reads as the Mythos applied.

5.1 Deep Time: Hutton, Lyell, Kelvin, and the Arche-Fossil

The temporality of the Mythos is stratigraphic. Its present is the uppermost layer of a deposit in which older things persist beneath newer ones, and its horror arises when the layers are correlated, when an object in the present is read as the outcrop of a stratum of inconceivable age. Geology supplied the vocabulary. James Hutton's "Theory of the Earth" (1788) concluded that the rocks disclose "no vestige of a beginning,—no prospect of an end," and John Playfair, recalling the day in 1788 when Hutton showed him the unconformity at Siccar Point, where steeply tilted strata lie beneath horizontal beds laid down across their eroded edges, wrote that the mind seemed to grow giddy by looking so far into "the abyss of time." The phrase deserves to be taken literally. Deep time entered European thought as an abyss and as vertigo, and the Mythos is the literature in which that vertigo ceases to be a figure of speech.

Charles Lyell's *Principles of Geology* (1830–33) made Hutton's abyss the foundation of a science. Its uniformitarian method explained the past by causes still operating in the present, given time enough, and its frontispiece reproduced the columns of the so-called Temple of Serapis at Pozzuoli, bored by marine molluscs at a height proving that the land had sunk beneath the sea and risen again since the

Romans built it: a ruin read as an instrument of geological time. Lyell went further, speculating that in the cycles of a great year of climate the extinct creatures of the rocks might return, the iguanodon to the woods and the ichthyosaur to the sea. Henry De la Beche answered with a lithograph, "Awful Changes" (1830), in which a learned ichthyosaur, returned in that future, lectures his fellow reptiles on a fossil human skull, observing that it plainly belonged to some of the lower order of animals. The caricature is the first image of the scene that "The Shadow out of Time" and *At the Mountains of Madness* would elaborate: the human species as fossil, studied by a nonhuman scholarship.

Thermodynamics added an arrow to the abyss. William Thomson, later Lord Kelvin, announced in 1852 a universal tendency in nature to the dissipation of mechanical energy, and Rudolf Clausius gave the principle its cosmological formula in 1865: *Die Entropie der Welt strebt einem Maximum zu*, the entropy of the world tends toward a maximum. The heat death of the universe became the scientific eschatology of the late nineteenth century, and Kelvin used the same physics to limit the age of the Earth to some tens of millions of years, until radioactivity overturned the limit: by 1913 Arthur Holmes could propose an age of some 1.6 billion years, and in 1956 Clair Patterson fixed it at about 4.55 billion. Lovecraft wrote while the past was lengthening faster than the imagination could follow, and his narratives measure time in hundreds of millions of years with the confidence of the new geochronology; *At the Mountains of Madness* even invokes the then-marginal theory of continental drift associated with Taylor, Wegener, and Joly. Stephen Jay Gould's *Time's Arrow, Time's Cycle* (1987) distinguished the two metaphors through which geology has thought deep time, the irreversible arrow and the recurrent cycle. The Mythos, as section 5.4 shows, combines them.

The decisive philosophical consequence returns the argument to Chapter 1. Meillassoux's arche-fossil names a reality anterior to all life and thought, and the scandal it poses for correlationism lies in its absence of witnesses: the accretion of the Earth was given to no one. Lovecraft's deep past is different, and the difference is the Mythos's most original contribution to the philosophy of time. His ancestral epochs have witnesses. The Elder Things carved their history into the walls of their city, so that the explorers of *At the Mountains of Madness* read the Earth's remote past in a historiography composed by those who lived it, and the Great Race of Yith recorded the history of every era in its archive. The Mythos replaces ancestrality, the time before all givenness, with alien givenness: a past that was given, but not to us. In doing so it opens a third position between the correlationist, for whom the past exists only for human consciousness, and the realist, for whom it existed for no one. Lovecraft's past existed for others. Its correlation was real and its correlators were not human, and the

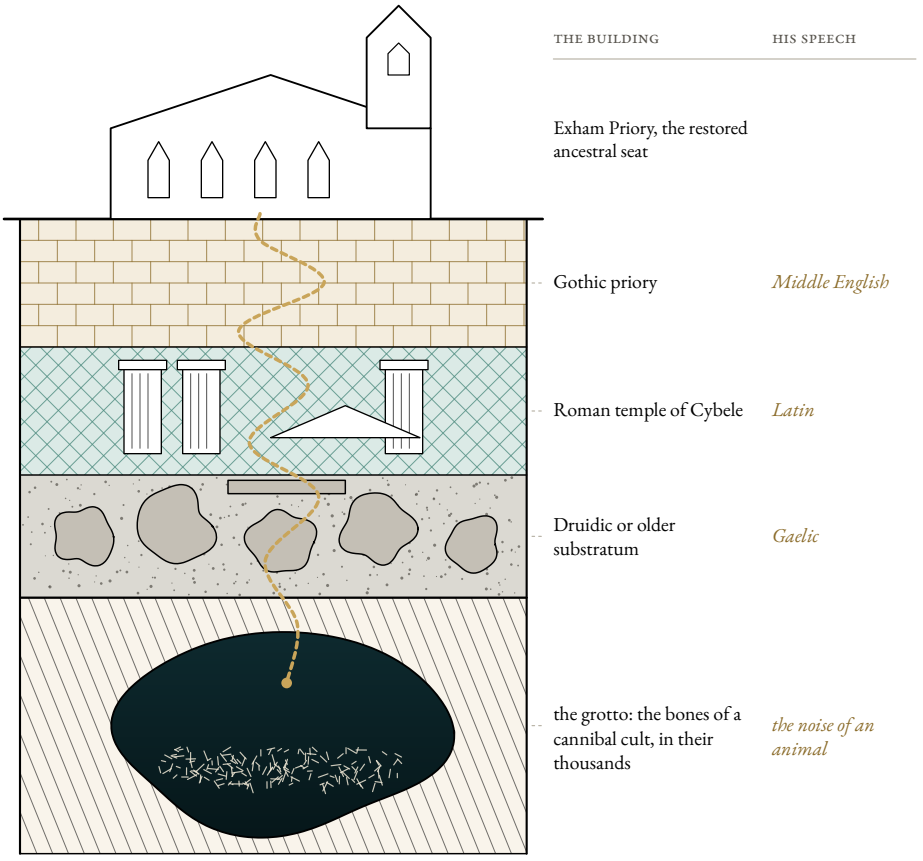
horror of his deep time is not that the past was empty of meaning but that it was full of a meaning composed by someone else.

The tale that makes stratigraphy a narrative form is "The Rats in the Walls" (1923). Its narrator, an American restoring his ancestral seat of Exham Priory, descends through the foundations as through a geological section: from the Gothic priory to a Roman temple of Cybele, from the Roman layer to a Druidic or older substratum, and at last into a vast grotto where the bones of a cannibal cult lie in their thousands. Gaston Bachelard's *La Poétique de l'espace* (1958) would contrast the rational verticality of the attic with the irrational verticality of the cellar, whose walls have the whole earth behind them. Exham Priory is a house whose cellar has no floor, and at its bottom the narrator's speech regresses through the strata of language to the noise of an animal (section 2.3). In Lovecraft's stratigraphy, the self is a deposit too.

5.2 Survivals: Tylor, Frazer, Murray, Machen

The anthropology of Lovecraft's youth supplied a concept that converts geological time into cultural time, and its name is the one Blackwood's epigraph placed at the head of "The Call of Cthulhu": survival. Edward Burnett Tylor's *Primitive Culture* (1871) defined survivals as processes, customs, and opinions carried by force of habit into a state of society different from the one in which they originated, which thus remain as "proofs and examples of an older condition of culture." A child's bow and arrow, a superstition about sneezing, a peasant rite at harvest: each was, for Tylor, the outcrop of an older stratum of human development, legible to the anthropologist who could correlate it with the customs of peoples presumed to be living at that earlier stage. Survival is the temporal form of correlation, the reading of a present object as evidence of an absent past, and Tylor was candid about its purpose. The science of culture, he wrote at the close of his book, is "essentially a reformer's science": survivals were identified in order to be extirpated.

James Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890; third edition in twelve volumes, 1906–15) extended Tylor's method into a comparative science of magic and religion, and "The Call of Cthulhu" names it among Professor Angell's sources, beside his notes on "long-surviving secret societies and hidden cults." Frazer's theory of magic is, in the terms of this thesis, a theory of false correlation. Sympathetic magic, he argued, rests on two principles, the association of ideas by similarity and by contiguity, sound principles of thought misapplied, so that magic is "a false science as well as an abortive art." The Mythos inverts the judgment. In its world the formulas work: Armitage's incantation drives the Dunwich horror back into its dimension, and Keziah Mason's witchcraft proves to be advanced mathematics. Frazer placed magic at the bottom of an evolutionary sequence ascending through religion to science; Lovecraft's narrators



5.1 ***Exham Priory in section.*** The descent of "The Rats in the Walls" (1923) drawn as a geological section, from the Gothic priory through a Roman temple of Cybele and a Druidic or older substratum to the grotto of the cannibal cult, beside the historical strata through which the narrator's speech regresses (sections 2.3 and 5.1).

discover that science, pursued far enough, arrives back at magic, and that the false correlations of the sorcerer were true correlations of a reality the sorcerer did not understand.

Margaret Murray's *The Witch-Cult in Western Europe* (1921), the other anthropological work that "The Call of Cthulhu" names, argued that the early modern witch trials had prosecuted a real, organized, pre-Christian fertility religion, surviving in covens of thirteen and devoted to a horned god. The thesis has not survived scrutiny. Keith Thomas's *Religion and the Decline of Magic* (1971), Norman Cohn's *Europe's Inner Demons* (1975), and Ronald Hutton's *The Triumph of the Moon* (1999) dismantled it, and Carlo Ginzburg's studies of the Friulian *benandanti* (1966) and of the witches' sabbath (1989) recovered genuine folk survivals only by abandon-

ing Murray's hypothesis of an organized church. Yet the cult of Cthulhu, a secret worldwide religion persisting beneath official Christianity and surfacing in remote swamps and fishing villages, is Murray's witch-cult enlarged to planetary scale and pushed back beyond the human. Murray's false history also had a strange afterlife of its own. She contributed the introduction to Gerald Gardner's *Witchcraft Today* (1954), a founding document of modern Wicca, so that a surviving pagan religion which did not exist when she described it came into being partly because she had described it. Section 5.7 returns to this structure, in which a lie about survival produces the survival it describes.

Arthur Machen gave survival its most direct literary form and revealed its politics. His Little People, the pre-Celtic race surviving in the Welsh hills in "The Novel of the Black Seal" and "The Shining Pyramid" (1895), drew on the theory, advanced by David MacRitchie in *The Testimony of Tradition* (1890), that fairy legends preserve the memory of a real, conquered, diminutive population driven underground by invaders. The theory is euhemerist in method and racial in content: folklore is read as the memory of a conquest, and the conquered survive as monsters beneath the soil of the conquerors. Lovecraft's degeneration tales, "The Lurking Fear," "Arthur Jermyn," and "The Rats in the Walls," inherit this structure, which Chapter 6 examines directly. Here it is enough to note what the doctrine of survivals always contained. Tylor's method placed living peoples in the past of European civilization, reading their customs as relics of a stage Europe had left behind, which is precisely the denial of coevalness that Johannes Fabian identified (section 3.6). The Mythos takes the doctrine's temporal hierarchy and makes it monstrous. Its survivals are older than the human, and they are terrible because they insist on being contemporary.

5.3 Root-Races and Lost Continents: Theosophy and Occult Prehistory

Occult prehistory supplied the Mythos with its scale, and its founding text is Plato's. In the *Timaeus* (22b–23b) an aged Egyptian priest tells Solon that the Greeks are always children, with no old man among them and no ancient learning, because the world is periodically destroyed by fire and flood and each destruction erases the memory of what came before; only Egypt, sheltered from the catastrophes, has preserved in its temple records the history of humanity's forgotten ages, among them the war of Athens against Atlantis. The passage contains in miniature the temporal structure of the Mythos: cyclical catastrophe, a humanity whose forgetting is the condition of its innocence, and an archive, held by a priestly caste, that remembers what the species cannot. The Saïs of the *Timaeus* is the first Pnakotus.

The nineteenth century multiplied the lost continents and populated them. Helena Petrovna Blavatsky, who founded the Theosophical Society in New York in 1875, set out in *The Secret Doctrine* (1888), as commentary on the allegedly ancient Stanzas of Dzyan, a cosmology of vast cycles borrowed largely from Hindu sources and a history of humanity unfolding through seven root-races, of which the third had inhabited Lemuria and the fourth Atlantis. W. Scott-Elliot's *The Story of Atlantis* (1896) and *The Lost Lemuria* (1904), whose combined title Professor Angell's notes record, claimed to derive their histories from clairvoyant reading of the akashic records, a cosmic archive of all events impressed upon a subtle medium. Lovecraft placed the movement at the head of his manifesto. Theosophists, the second paragraph of "The Call of Cthulhu" observes, have guessed at the awesome grandeur of the cosmic cycle in which our world and race form "transient incidents," and have hinted at strange survivals in terms that would freeze the blood if not "masked by a bland optimism." The sentence states Lovecraft's relation to Theosophy precisely: right scale, wrong affect. The Theosophists had the cycles, the ages, and the survivals, and they subordinated them to a doctrine of spiritual evolution toward perfection. The Mythos is Theosophy with the optimism subtracted, another instance of the subtraction of redemption described in Chapter 2, and its archive of the Great Race is the akashic record made material: a library of all history kept not in an astral medium open to clairvoyants but in a physical city open only to a species that exchanges minds.

The lost-continent literature fed the Mythos directly. Ignatius Donnelly's *Atlantis: The Antediluvian World* (1882) derived every civilization from a sunken Atlantic homeland, and James Churchward's *The Lost Continent of Mu* (1926), published in the year "The Call of Cthulhu" was written, sank a motherland of humanity beneath the Pacific, where Lovecraft had already placed R'lyeh; "Out of the Aeons" (1933), revised for Hazel Heald, sets its prehistory on Mu itself.

The scale of occult prehistory carried a politics, and the Mythos did not escape it. Blavatsky's root-races ranked the peoples of the present as more and less advanced remnants of earlier races, and in the German-speaking world the doctrine was absorbed into the Ariosophy of Guido von List and Jörg Lanz von Liebenfels, whose part in the occult prehistory of National Socialism Nicholas Goodrick-Clarke documented in *The Occult Roots of Nazism* (1985). The Mythos in turn flowed back into occult prehistory. Jason Colavito's *The Cult of Alien Gods* (2005) traces the ancient-astronaut theory, popularized by Erich von Däniken's *Erinnerungen an die Zukunft* (1968), to Lovecraft's fiction by way of Pauwels and Bergier: the fictional thesis that nonhuman beings built the oldest monuments of the Earth became, within two generations, a popular belief. The logic of the adjective *cyclopean* (section 4.1), applied to real ruins, had a long colonial prehistory. European settlers in southern Africa attributed the stone city of Great Zimbabwe to Phoenicians or to the Queen

of Sheba rather than to the ancestors of its African neighbours, and the colonial government of Rhodesia went on contesting the archaeological consensus long after Gertrude Caton-Thompson had confirmed the city's African origin in 1929. The inference that a structure too great for its present inhabitants must have been built by someone else is the Mythos's favourite inference, and outside the fiction it has rarely been innocent.

5.4 Imprisoned Elders and Cycles of Ruin: Hesiod, the *Enūma Eliš*, the Yugas, Ragnarök, Spengler

Comparative mythology shows the Mythos assembling, in a materialist key, motifs that the oldest literatures had already joined. Hesiod's *Theogony* narrates a succession in which each generation of gods overthrows the last, Ouranos by Kronos and Kronos by Zeus. The defeated Titans, the old gods, are bound beneath the earth in Tartarus, as far below the earth as heaven is above it, so far that a bronze anvil would fall nine days and nights to reach it, and are guarded there by the Hundred-Handers (717–735). Against Zeus rises Typhoeus, a monster with a hundred serpent heads whose voices utter every kind of sound, now speech the gods understand, now the bellowing of bulls and lions, now hissing (820–835), and he too is cast into Tartarus. The Great Old Ones, imprisoned, sleeping, and awaiting release, are Titans without a Zeus, and Typhoeus, whose many voices speak in every register but the human, is the first monster of xenoglossia.

The most exact ancient prototype of Cthulhu is found, however, not in Hesiod but in Plutarch. In the myth that closes his dialogue *De facie in orbe lunae* (26, 941A–942A), a stranger reports that on an island far to the west of Britain the god Kronos lies imprisoned in a deep cave, bound not by chains but by sleep, which Zeus devised for him as a fetter; spirits attend him, and they announce as prophecies the dreams of Kronos, for what Zeus devises, Kronos dreams. The dialogue *De defectu oraculorum* (18, 420A) repeats the tradition of an island near Britain where Kronos is held captive in sleep. Here, nearly two thousand years before "The Call of Cthulhu," is an elder god imprisoned on a remote island by sleep rather than death, attended by a priesthood that receives his dreams and transmits them as revelation. *In his house at R'lyeh dead Cthulhu waits dreaming*: the cult's formula is a Plutarchan myth moved from the North Atlantic to the South Pacific and stripped of its Olympian order, for Cthulhu's dreams reflect the designs of no higher god. They are the dreams of an indifferent sleeper, and the sensitives who receive them are not prophets but casualties.

The Mesopotamian creation epic, the *Enūma Eliš*, whose tablets George Smith published from the library of Ashurbanipal in *The Chaldean Account of Genesis*

(1876), supplies the motif of the sleeping elder disturbed. Apsu, the primordial fresh waters, complains that the clamour of the younger gods lets him neither rest by day nor sleep by night, and plots their destruction; Ea lulls him to sleep with a spell and kills him. Tiamat, the salt sea, spawns an army of monsters and is split by Marduk, who builds heaven and earth from her body and has humanity fashioned from the blood of her champion to bear the labour of the gods. The *Atrahasis* epic adds that human noise in turn robbed Enlil of his sleep, and that the gods answered with plague, drought, and flood. The Mythos reverses the polarity: in Mesopotamia the young disturb the sleep of the old and are punished, while in Lovecraft the sleep of the old is the condition of the young's survival and its end is the end of everything. Hermann Gunkel's *Schöpfung und Chaos in Urzeit und Endzeit* (1895) showed that the biblical Leviathan, Rahab, and dragon of the sea are survivals of this combat myth, and that the chaos-monster defeated at the beginning returns at the end; his formula, primeval time equals end time, is the eschatology of the Mythos exactly. Isaiah promised that the Lord would slay Leviathan "that crooked serpent" (27:1), and the seer of Revelation saw in the new creation that "there was no more sea" (21:1). The Christian eschaton abolishes the sea. Lovecraft's is the sea's return, and the rising of R'lyeh is Leviathan unslain.

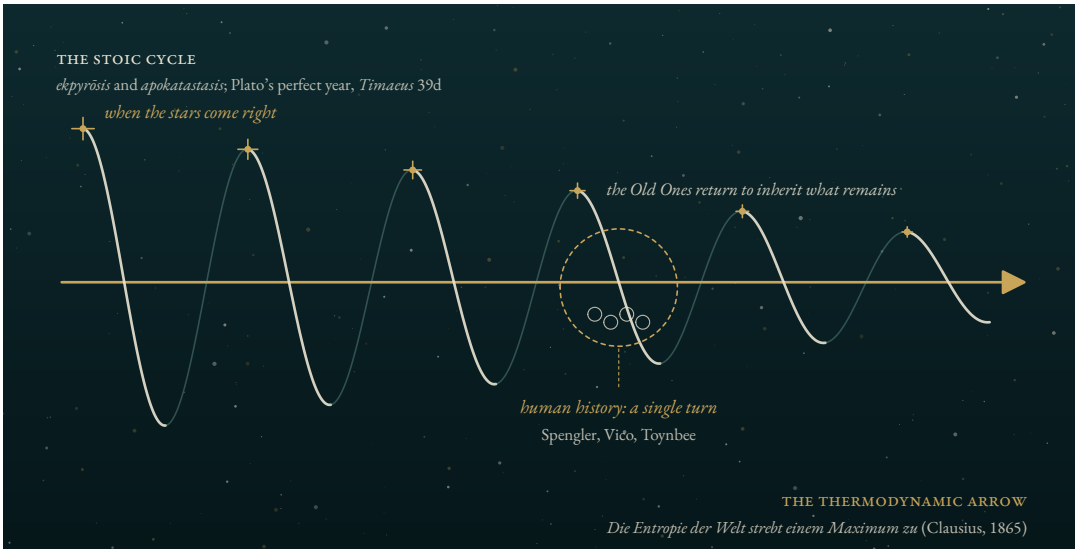
The cyclical cosmologies complete the comparison. Purāṇic time measures the ages in *yugas*, of which the present Kali Yuga is the last and worst; a day of Brahma lasts a thousand great ages, some 4.32 billion years, an order of magnitude that led Carl Sagan to remark in *Cosmos* (1980) that Hinduism is the only great religion whose time-scales correspond to those of modern cosmology. Between creations Vishnu sleeps upon the serpent Ananta on the cosmic ocean, and in the tale of the sage Mārkaṇḍeya, retold in Heinrich Zimmer's *Myths and Symbols in Indian Art and Civilization* (1946), the sage wanders through the universe inside the sleeping god, slips from his mouth into the dark waters of dissolution, and beholds the giant sleeper before being swallowed again. The Eddic *Völuspá* ends the world in Ragnarök, when the serpent that encircles the earth rises and the land sinks into the sea, and then shows the earth rising again from the waves, *jörð ór ægi*, green and renewed. The Aztec Legend of the Suns records four earlier worlds ended by catastrophe, the people of the fourth, destroyed by flood, turned into fish. Each cosmology holds an element of the Mythos: the dreaming god, the rising serpent, the earth emerging from the sea, a humanity transformed at an age's end into creatures of the water, as the people of Innsmouth are. None holds its indifference. The yugas turn within a cosmic order, Ragnarök yields a renewed world, and the Aztec suns were sustained by a sacrificial debt that bound gods and humans together.

The Mythos's own cycle has a precise ancestor in Greek astronomy. Plato's *Timaeus* (39d) defined a perfect year, completed when all the heavenly revolutions

return together to their starting point, and the Stoics, as Nemesius later reported, taught that when the planets return to the same configuration the cosmos is consumed in a conflagration, *ekpyrōsis*, and restored in every detail, *apokatastasis*. The return of the Old Ones "when the stars were right" depends in the same way on a configuration of the heavens, not on any act of will, human or divine. Lovecraft, the boy astronomer, made the astrological Great Year the clock of his apocalypse, and its mechanism is the purest expression of his indifferentism: the end of the world will be triggered by an alignment as impersonal as an eclipse. Set upon the thermodynamic arrow of section 5.1, the Stoic cycle yields the Mythos's distinctive temporality, a cycle on an arrow, in which the archaic recurs along a course of irreversible decline and the Old Ones return not to renew the world but to inherit what remains of it. Spengler's morphology of mortal cultures (section 2.4), Vico's *corsi e ricorsi*, and Toynbee's cycles of challenge and response belong to the same family, transposed to human history; the Mythos sets all of them inside a larger cycle in which human history is a single turn.

5.5 The Horror of Being: Levinas, the *Il y a*, and the Impossibility of Death

The couplet that gives this chapter its title first appears in "The Nameless City" (1921) as the "unexplainable couplet" of Abdul Alhazred, and it recurs in "The Call



5.2 *A cycle on an arrow.* The Stoic return of the stars set upon the thermodynamic arrow: the archaic recurs along a course of irreversible decline, the Old Ones return to inherit what remains, and the cycles of human history are gathered into a single turn (section 5.4).

of Cthulhu" as the scripture of the cult. Its second line inverts one of the central promises of Christian scripture. Paul wrote that the last enemy to be destroyed is death and that death is swallowed up in victory (1 Corinthians 15:26, 54), and John Donne gave the promise its most famous English form in the sonnet that ends "Death, thou shalt die." In Donne the death of death is the triumph of eternal life over the grave. In Alhazred it is the triumph of the undead over the living, and the "strange aeons" through which it will come, a word that names in Gnostic theology the emanations of the divine fullness (section 4.5), have become mere durations, long enough for death itself to wear out. The first line turns on a pun that the rest of this chapter unfolds. To *lie* is to lie dormant, to rest without dying, and it is also to deceive. This section takes the first sense; section 5.7 takes the second.

The philosopher who gave the first sense its concept is Emmanuel Levinas. In *De l'existence à l'existant* (1947) and the lectures published as *Le Temps et l'autre* (1948), Levinas described the *il y a*, the "there is," as anonymous being without beings, the impersonal rumour of existence that persists when every object has been subtracted, experienced in the night and in insomnia, when it is not I who keep watch but the night itself that watches. Against Heidegger, for whom the fundamental mood is anxiety before nothingness and the authentic relation to existence a being-toward-death, Levinas argued that the deeper affect is horror, and that horror is not the fear of death but the horror of being: of the impossibility of death, of an existence from which there is no exit. He found its emblem in Macbeth's terror at Banquo's ghost, the recognition that once, when the brains were out, a man would die, but now the dead rise again. The Old Ones are the *il y a* given a geography. They are neither alive nor dead; they *lie*; they persist without consciousness, dreaming without a dreamer, in the anonymous vigilance of a sleep that watches. *Sein und Zeit* appeared in 1927, between the composition of "The Call of Cthulhu" and its publication, and the Mythos takes Levinas's side against it in advance: its horror is not anxiety before nothingness but dread before a being that will not end.

The Mythos dramatizes the impossibility of death throughout, and its corpus can be read as a catalogue of the ways death fails as an exit. Poe's "The Facts in the Case of M. Valdemar" (1845), in which a man mesmerized at the point of death is held in suspension for months and speaks from his bed to announce that he is dead, supplied the template, and Lovecraft wrote his own Valdemar in "Cool Air" (1926), whose physician has maintained his dead body by refrigeration for eighteen years and dissolves when the machinery fails. *The Case of Charles Dexter Ward* raises the dead from their "essential Saltes"; Herbert West reanimates corpses; in "The Thing on the Doorstep" a dead wizard survives by occupying his daughter's body and then her husband's, whose own corpse, its mind expelled, crawls back to deliver a message; the Mi-Go keep living brains in cylinders; the Great Race outlasts its own extinctions by

projecting itself into other species. In each case death has become unreliable, a door that may not close. Heidegger's being-toward-death presupposed that death is one's ownmost possibility, the one thing no one can do in our place. The Mythos imagines a world in which death can be stolen, postponed, exchanged, and survived, and in such a world the anticipation of death confers no authenticity, because death is no longer certain to come.

Maurice Blanchot extended Levinas's analysis in *L'Espace littéraire* (1955) with the figure of the other night, the night in which, when everything has disappeared, disappearance itself appears; and the image fits the floor of the Pacific on which R'lyeh lies, a darkness that is not the absence of things but the presence of their absence, inhabited by something that waits. The first sense of the eternal lie is therefore an ontology of persistence. What lies eternally is what cannot die because it was never alive in our sense, and what returns when the stars are right is not a resurrection but a continuation that never paused. The horror of the Mythos is, in Levinas's exact sense, a horror of being.

5.6 *Nachleben*: Warburg, Didi-Huberman, and the Afterlife of Forms

The art historian Aby Warburg spent his career on a question that bears directly on the Mythos: how forms survive. His concept of *Nachleben*, the afterlife of antiquity, described the persistence of pagan images in the art of the Renaissance and beyond, not as a calm inheritance but as a recurrence of charged formulas, *Pathosformeln*, the gestures of the maenad, the running nymph, the dying warrior, which carried the emotional intensity of their origins across centuries and erupted, symptomatically, in new contexts. Warburg borrowed from the biologist Richard Semon's *Die Mneme* (1904) the concept of the engram, a memory trace stored in organic matter and reactivated by a stimulus, and he conceived images as the engrams of a collective memory. His last project, the *Mnemosyne Atlas* (1924–29), arranged nearly a thousand photographs on some sixty panels covered in black cloth, correlating images across millennia by their shared formulas: an evidence wall of art history, constructed by a scholar who had himself passed through madness.

The biography is not incidental. Warburg suffered a psychotic collapse in 1918 and spent the years from 1921 to 1924 in Ludwig Binswanger's sanatorium at Kreuzlingen, and in April 1923, to demonstrate to his physicians that he had recovered his reason, he lectured to the patients and staff on the serpent ritual of the Pueblo peoples, whom he had visited in the American Southwest in 1895–96. The lecture argued that symbols create a *Denkraum*, a space for thought, a distance between the human being and the forces that threaten it within which reflection becomes possible; and

it ended with a warning. Modern technology, Warburg argued, had abolished that distance. Edison's copper wire had stolen the lightning that the serpent once symbolized, and the telegram and the telephone, in his phrase, destroy the cosmos, collapsing into instantaneous connection the space that devotion and reflection require. Three years before Lovecraft wrote that the inability of the mind to correlate all its contents is merciful, a historian of survivals, speaking from a sanatorium to prove his sanity, argued that the distance between things is what keeps the mind whole and that the networks of modernity were destroying it. Warburg's *Denkraum* is Lovecraft's mercy described as an achievement of culture rather than an accident of biology.

Georges Didi-Huberman's *L'Image survivante* (2002) showed that Warburg's *Nachleben* descends in part from Tylor's survivals and that it describes a time of phantoms, an anachronistic temporality in which the past does not stay past but returns with the force of a symptom. The convergence with the Mythos is exact, and it allows a long-standing critical dispute to be settled. Jacques Derrida's *Spectres de Marx* (1993) named hauntology the condition of a present inhabited by revenants, and Mark Fisher extended the concept to the lost futures of late capitalism; China Miéville set the Weird against hauntology precisely, since the hauntological returns what was lost while the Weird, the abcanny, brings what was never known (Chapter 1). The Mythos is both, and the paradox resolves once the content of its survivals is recognized. Its form is hauntological, the return of the archaic, but what returns was never ours to lose. The Mythos is a hauntology of the inhuman, haunted by revenants who were never our ancestors.

Warburg's categories apply, finally, to the Mythos itself. Its images have detached themselves from Lovecraft's texts and survive across media as formulas: the tentacled head, the forbidden book, the robed cult, the cyclopean city, the eye that should not open. Each is a *Pathosformel* of modern cosmic dread, charged with an intensity that persists when its narrative context has been forgotten, recurring in films, games, and toys whose makers may never have read the tales. Carl Jung's doctrine of a collective unconscious populated by inherited archetypes offered one explanation of such recurrences; Warburg's *Nachleben* offers a better one, historical rather than metaphysical, in which forms survive because they are transmitted and are transmitted because they carry a charge. The Mythos survives by the mechanism it depicts. Its forms lie in the culture, dormant and undead, and they rise whenever the stars of a new medium come right.

Hyperstition: The *Necronomicon* After Lovecraft 5.7

The second sense of the eternal lie is fiction: the lie that cannot die. Nietzsche's essay on truth and lies, whose opening fable was examined in Chapter 2, defines truths as

illusions that we have forgotten are illusions, *Wahrheiten sind Illusionen, von denen man vergessen hat, dass sie welche sind*; Hans Vaihinger's *Die Philosophie des Als Ob* (1911) analysed the useful fictions on which science and law depend; Borges's Tlön imagined a fiction that becomes the world through the accumulation of its citations (section 3.2). Read in this sense, the couplet describes the career of Lovecraft's own inventions. That is not dead which can eternally deceive, and with strange aeons, given time enough, even the death of a fiction, the knowledge that it is a fiction, may die.

The *Necronomicon* is the paradigm. Within Lovecraft's lifetime readers wrote to ask where it might be consulted, and pranksters have since inserted it into library catalogues and booksellers' lists. In 1973 L. Sprague de Camp issued *Al Azif*, a facsimile of meaningless pseudo-Syriac script with an introduction narrating its discovery. In 1977 a grimoire edited by the pseudonymous "Simon" appeared in New York in a limited edition, and from 1980 as a mass-market paperback: a text that grafts Lovecraft's names onto the gods and demons of Mesopotamia, Tiamat and Marduk among them, so that the "real" *Necronomicon* is built in part from the *Enūma Eliš* (section 5.4). It has remained in print ever since and has been used as a working grimoire by practitioners who knew its origins and by many who did not. In 1978 George Hay published *The Necronomicon: The Book of Dead Names*, with an essay by Colin Wilson and a mock cryptographic appendix later acknowledged as a spoof by its author, David Langford; Dan Harms and John Wisdom Gonce's *The Necronomicon Files* (1998) documented the whole history. The book that the Mythos describes as a pre-correlated archive of forbidden lore has become a real book that occultists correlate with other traditions, and its reality has been produced by the very operation it was invented to dramatize.

The Mythos also entered occult practice directly. Kenneth Grant, who led a Typhonian current of Thelemic magic named after the Typhon of Greek and Egyptian myth, argued in *The Magical Revival* (1972) and *Nightside of Eden* (1977) that Lovecraft, like Aleister Crowley, had unwittingly received transmissions from real powers beyond, and he mapped the Old Ones onto the Qliphoth, the shells of the Kabbalistic underworld. Anton LaVey's *The Satanic Rituals* (1972) included two Lovecraftian rites by Michael Aquino, "The Ceremony of the Nine Angles" and "The Call to Cthulhu," the latter in an invented tongue; Aquino went on to found the Temple of Set. Chaos magic, from Peter Carroll's *Liber Null* (1978) to Phil Hine's *The Pseudonomicon* (1994), treated belief itself as a technique and the Mythos's entities as serviceable godforms precisely because they were invented. Each of these receptions practises the Miskatonic method in reverse. Lovecraft's narrators correlate the evidence and discover that the gods are real; the occultists correlate the fiction with their traditions and resolve to make them so.

The Cybernetic Culture Research Unit gave the structure its theoretical name. Its writings of the late 1990s defined hyperstition as a fiction that makes itself real, an element of culture that functions causally to bring about the reality it describes, and took the *Necronomicon* as a model case; the unit's own productions, from the numerical cosmology it called the Numogram to the pseudo-documentary "Lemurian Time War," were experiments in the genre. The history of the Mythos supplies the evidence. Margaret Murray's false history of the witch-cult helped to bring a witch religion into being (section 5.2); the fiction of alien builders became, by way of Pauwels, Bergier, and von Däniken, a popular pseudo-history (section 5.3); and network culture has since shown that hyperstition can do real harm. Slender Man, a faceless figure invented for an internet forum's image-manipulation contest in 2009, became within five years a collaborative mythology elaborate enough that in 2014 two twelve-year-old girls in Wisconsin attacked a classmate in the belief that they were appeasing him; their victim survived. The eternal lie, in its second sense, is not a metaphor. Fictions that circulate long enough acquire practitioners, and practitioners can make a fiction act in the world.

The two senses of the couplet thus converge. The Old Ones lie dormant and do not die; the Mythos lies, as fiction, and does not die either. Its forms persist in the culture as the Old Ones persist in R'lyeh, and they rise, when conditions are right, into practices their inventor would have found absurd. Lovecraft, a materialist who regarded every occultism as delusion, produced the most successful occult text of the twentieth century without writing a word of it, because he invented a book whose absence could be filled. That is the final sense of the pre-correlated archive: the *Necronomicon* is a vacancy shaped like a book, and the culture has been filling it ever since.

5.8 "This Place Is Not a Place of Honor": Nuclear Semiotics as Applied Mythos

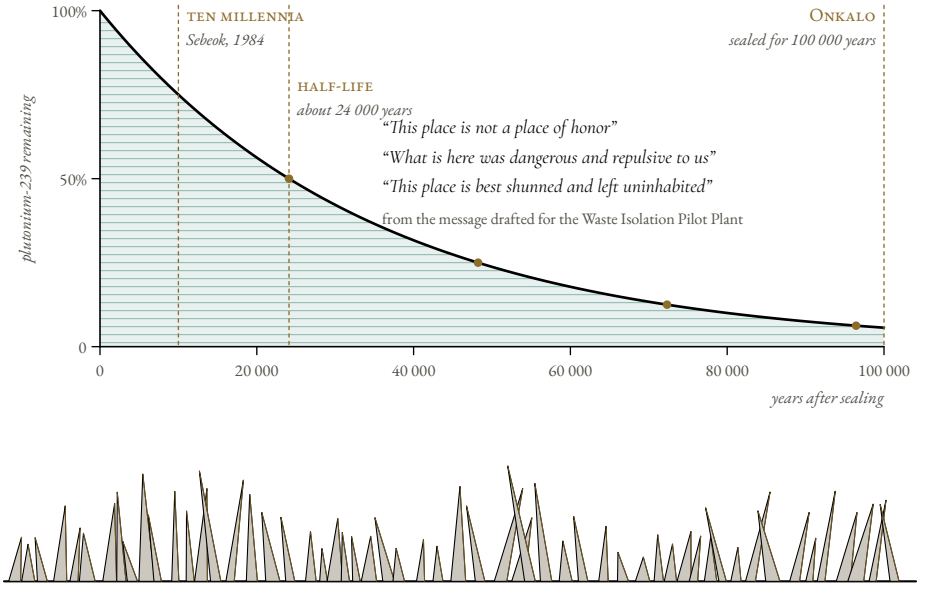
In the decades after Lovecraft's death, the problem at the centre of the Mythos became an engineering problem. High-level nuclear waste remains dangerous for tens of thousands of years, and plutonium-239 alone has a half-life of some twenty-four thousand. The states that produce such waste have resolved to bury it in deep geological repositories, among them the Waste Isolation Pilot Plant in New Mexico, which began receiving transuranic waste in 1999, and Onkalo in Finland, designed to hold spent fuel sealed for a hundred thousand years. The question that followed was Lovecraft's: how to warn beings of a remote future, who may share neither our languages nor our concepts, about a buried thing that must not be disturbed. In 1981 the United States Department of Energy convened a Human Interference Task Force to answer it. The semiotician Thomas Sebeok's report, *Communication*

Measures to Bridge Ten Millennia (1984), concluded that no language or symbol could be relied upon across such a span, and proposed instead an atomic priesthood: a self-perpetuating body of experts that would transmit the warning through ritual and legend, cultivating a superstition around the site so that later generations would avoid it without needing to understand why.

Sebeok's atomic priesthood is the cult of Cthulhu inverted: an order founded to keep alive the memory of a buried power until the stars are right, except that its stars are the slow decay of isotopes and its purpose is to keep the sleeper asleep. Other proposals of the period read as variations on the Mythos. The semioticians Françoise Bastide and Paolo Fabbri suggested breeding cats whose fur would change colour in the presence of radiation, and seeding the culture with songs and stories teaching that one must flee when the cats change colour: a colour out of space recast as a warning, an anomalous hue that signals the invisible danger instead of being it. Stanisław Lem, among the contributors to a German symposium on the problem in 1984, proposed encoding the warning in the hereditary material of engineered plants. Every proposal met the dilemma of the *analogia monstri* from the other side: how to make a likeness that minds unlike ours will read as a likeness of something they must not approach.

The most celebrated product of these deliberations is a message drafted for the Waste Isolation Pilot Plant by an expert panel convened by Sandia National Laboratories, whose report (1993) also proposed hostile landscapes, fields of stone spikes and menacing earthworks, to make the site feel wrong. The message, meant to be inscribed at the site in several languages and in pictographs, reads in part: "This place is not a place of honor"; "What is here was dangerous and repulsive to us"; "The danger is still present, in your time, as it was in ours"; "The form of the danger is an emanation of energy"; and finally, "This place is best shunned and left uninhabited." The last word should give a reader of Lovecraft pause. In "The Shunned House" (1924), set in a real house on Benefit Street in Providence, the narrator and his uncle dig beneath the cellar and find the vast folded elbow of a buried entity whose faint luminous emanation has for generations drained the life of the house's occupants, and which has persisted beneath the foundations since colonial times. The Sandia message describes, in the plain prose of a federal laboratory, a shunned house: a buried presence beneath a site, emitting an energy that kills slowly, persisting across ages, dangerous to whoever disturbs it. The government of the United States has composed, for the readers of a distant future, a Lovecraft tale.

The deepest correspondence lies in the dilemma the planners could not resolve. Michael Madsen's documentary *Into Eternity* (2010), filmed at Onkalo, records the debate among those responsible for the site over whether it should be marked at all. A marker may warn; it may equally attract, as the tombs of the pharaohs attracted the robbers their curses were meant to deter. The alternative is to leave no sign and trust



fields of stone spikes, after the Sandia report of 1993

5.3 ***A shunned place.*** The decay of plutonium-239, whose half-life is some twenty-four thousand years, across the spans the planners of nuclear repositories had to imagine: Sebeok's ten millennia and the hundred thousand years of Onkalo. Below, the fields of stone spikes proposed to make the site feel wrong (section 5.8).

that the site will be forgotten, so that no future being ever learns there is anything there to find. This is the opening sentence of "The Call of Cthulhu" adopted as policy. The planners of the repository face Dyer's choice between warning and silence, and some of them prefer the mercy of the inability to correlate: the hope that the evidence will never be assembled.

The final consequence reverses the Mythos's perspective. In nuclear semiotics humanity occupies the place of the Elder Things, an ancient civilization leaving to the beings of a remote future an inscription about a buried danger that they may not be able to read, as Dyer and Danforth read on the walls of the Antarctic city the Elder Things' record of the shoggoths. The stratigrapher Jan Zalasiewicz's *The Earth After Us* (2008) imagined explorers arriving a hundred million years hence to study the fossil traces of humanity, as De la Beche's ichthyosaur studied the human skull, and the debate over naming a new geological epoch for us, the Anthropocene, with the plutonium fallout of the 1950s as its proposed marker, turned on precisely what our stratum will say to whoever reads it. The proposal to formalize the epoch was rejected in 2024; the stratum is being laid down regardless. The Old Ones, in this light, are not only what the Mythos imagined lying beneath us. They are what we are becoming for those who will come after.

5.9 Comparative Coda: Wells, Hodgson, Stapledon, *Mass Effect*, *Dark Souls*, *Outer Wilds*

The fiction of deep time divides, in its affect, between horror and acceptance, and the comparative field arranges itself around that division. H. G. Wells founded the modern form. The Time Traveller of *The Time Machine* (1895) journeys beyond the decadent Eloi and the subterranean Morlocks to a shore more than thirty million years hence, under a swollen red sun, where the last visible life on Earth is a round black thing the size of a football, from which "tentacles trailed down," hopping in the shallows before the darkness of an eclipse and the final cold. The tentacle of the Weird appears, in Wells, at the end of time. His story "The Star" (1897) adds the indifference of scale: a wandering body passes the Earth, killing millions, and the tale closes with the astronomers of Mars noting only slight changes in the planet's appearance, which, Wells observes, shows "how small the vastest of human catastrophes may seem" at a distance of a few million miles.

William Hope Hodgson's *The Night Land* (1912) set the last of humanity in a pyramid miles high beneath a dead sun, besieged through millions of years by motionless Watchers and by the abhuman, presences that wait with the patience of the eternal lie. Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937) carried the scale to its limit, narrating eighteen successive human species across two billion years and then a disembodied voyage through the whole cosmos to a creative spirit that makes universes as an artist makes works and regards their suffering with contemplative detachment. Stapledon's narrator meets this indifferent creator not with horror but with a stern, reverent acceptance: his cosmos is Lovecraft's cosmos met with piety. Arthur C. Clarke's "The Nine Billion Names of God" (1953), in which a computer that completes a monastery's list of every possible name of God thereby brings the universe quietly to its end, gives the genre's shortest statement of the idea that completion itself may be the apocalypse.

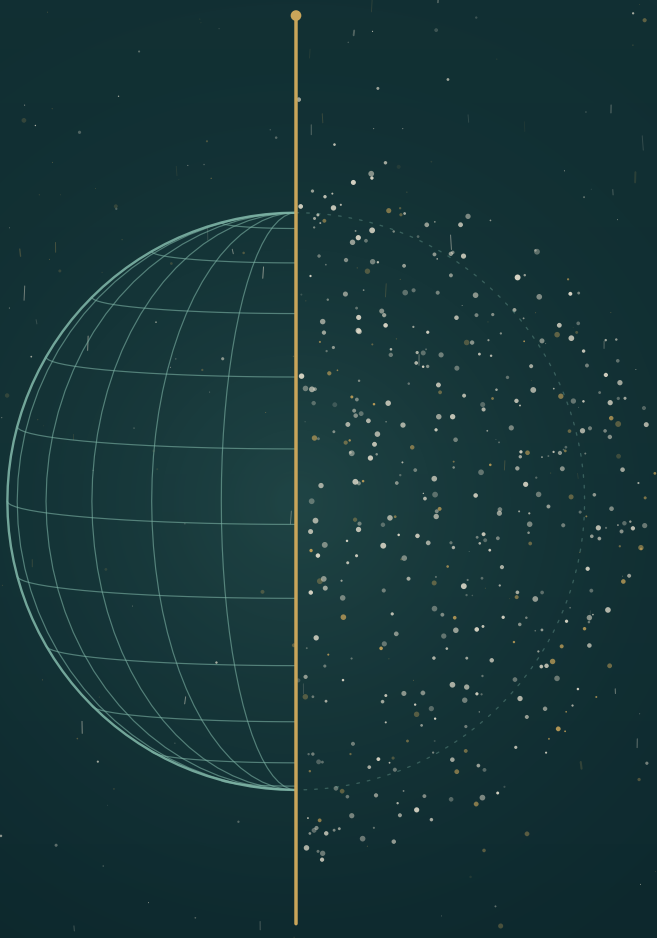
Video games, which can make time itself a structure of play, have given the eternal lie new forms. BioWare's *Mass Effect* trilogy (2007–12) imagines a galaxy harvested every fifty thousand years by the Reapers, ancient machine intelligences that wait in the dark between cycles and return when the time is right; its hero receives the warning of an extinct people as a fragmented vision burned into the mind by an alien beacon, which must be correlated before it can be understood, and one of its late chapters descends into the ocean of a remote world to find the Leviathans, the aquatic ancients behind the cycle. FromSoftware's *Dark Souls* (2011) and its sequels build a world on the failure of death. Its protagonist bears a curse that makes death temporary, returning after every fall and hollowing slowly toward mindlessness, while an age of fire is prolonged by sacrifices that only postpone its fading. Revival after death, which most

games treat as a convenience, becomes in *Dark Souls* Levinas's horror made playable: a being that cannot die and is damned by the fact.

Mobius Digital's *Outer Wilds* (2019) is the most moving inversion of the Mythos yet produced, and with its expansion *Echoes of the Eye* (2021) it dramatizes both of the alternatives that the opening sentence of "The Call of Cthulhu" predicts. Its player, an astronaut from a small world, is caught in a twenty-two-minute time loop that ends each time in the explosion of the sun, and learns, by reading the archives of an extinct alien people, the Nomai, that the universe itself is dying of age. The knowledge does not destroy. It leads the player to the Eye of the Universe, where, at the end of everything, the companions met along the way gather around a campfire and play their instruments together before a new universe begins. The expansion discloses another people, who received the same signal from the Eye, feared what it meant, hid it from the universe behind a cloaking field, burned their records, and retreated into a simulated dream, imprisoning the one among them who wished to share the truth. The two peoples enact Lovecraft's two predictions. One goes into the knowledge and is not destroyed by it; the other flees from the deadly light into the peace and safety of a new dark age. That a work of popular art has dramatized both alternatives, and has chosen the first, suggests that the Mythos's predicament admits more than one ending.

Across these works the eternal lie takes three forms: the persistence of what will not die, the persistence of fictions that will not stay fictional, and the persistence of the stratum we are ourselves laying down. Each raises a question that the Mythos answers in its own terms and that the remainder of this thesis must address directly. Survival is never neutral. The doctrine of survivals ranked peoples in time, occult prehistory ranked them in races, and the inference that great works must have had nonhuman builders denied them their own history. Who is cast as the survival, who is relegated to the stratum below, and who claims the right to correlate the strata are political questions, and the Mythos answered them politically. Chapter 6 follows that answer to its source.

Chapter. Six



The Abyssal Line

Degeneration, Heredity, and the Colonial Unconscious of Cosmic Horror

Are we such apostles of mercy as to complain if the Martians warred in the same spirit?

H. G. Wells, *The War of the Worlds*, 1898

The biopolitical register

Chapter Six

The Abyssal Line

This chapter confronts the racial and sexual politics of the Mythos and argues that they are not a detachable prejudice but the earthly form of its cosmology. It sets out Lovecraft's racism without euphemism; traces its intellectual sources in degeneration theory and eugenics and its crystallization during his years in New York, in the season of the Immigration Act of 1924; and reads the corpus as a fantasy of reverse colonization, in which the colonizer imagines himself colonized. Its central claim, developed through Aimé Césaire, Hannah Arendt, Frantz Fanon, Sylvia Wynter, and Boaventura de Sousa Santos, is that the cosmic Outside is the abyssal line of colonial modernity projected onto the stars. The chapter then turns to the bodies of women, where that line is most anxiously policed, and to the counter-mythos written from its far side.

6.1 The Record Without Euphemism

Lovecraft's racism is not in doubt, and its documentation is extensive enough that euphemism has become a scholarly vice. At twenty-one he wrote a short poem in couplets, its title built around a slur, describing the creation of Black people by the gods as an intermediate form between beast and man; as a child he gave his cat a name built on the same slur, and he later gave that name to the narrator's cat in "The Rats in the Walls." His amateur journalism of the 1910s celebrated a "Teutonic" racial unity and lamented the First World War as a fratricide among Aryans. "The Street" (1919) is a nativist allegory in which a New England street, overrun by immigrants and revolutionaries, collapses upon the conspirators who have defiled it. "Facts Concerning the Late Arthur Jermyn and His Family" (1920) makes African ancestry its final horror, as "Medusa's Coil" (1930), revised for Zealia Bishop, makes the hidden Black ancestry of its heroine the last and supposedly worst of its revelations. His letters from New York describe the crowds of the Lower East Side in the vocabulary he would later give the shoggoths, as amoebal, slimy, and not to be called human. In 1933 he wrote with qualified sympathy of Hitler's racial programme while mocking the man; his last

years brought a socialist turn and some softening of his views, without abandoning the racial hierarchy at their core.

The customary defence holds that Lovecraft was a man of his time and class. The defence is true as description and inadequate as exculpation, because his time and his own circle offered alternatives that he knew and declined. Franz Boas's *The Mind of Primitive Man* (1911) had already begun to dismantle the racial hierarchies of nineteenth-century anthropology, and among Lovecraft's closest correspondents was James F. Morton, an anarchist and campaigner for civil rights whose pamphlet *The Curse of Race Prejudice* (1906) argued the opposite of nearly everything Lovecraft believed about race; the two met in a quarrel in the amateur press and became lifelong friends without either converting the other. Lovecraft's wife, Sonia Greene, a Jewish émigré from Ukraine, later recalled that the crowds of New York could throw him into a rage. The question for criticism is therefore not whether Lovecraft was racist, which he was by the standards of his own time as well as ours, but how his racism functions in the fiction. The answer of this chapter, prepared in Chapters 1 and 2, is that it functions as an epistemic structure: the same operation of correlation that produces cosmic horror produces racial horror, and the same anxiety, the annulment of the subject's centrality, animates both.

Two errors must be avoided. The first, already rejected in Chapter 1, purifies the philosophy by quarantining the prejudice, as if the cosmicism could be lifted intact from the tales in which it is embodied. The second reduces the philosophy to the prejudice, as if the stars were merely a screen for the streets. The first error leaves the racism unexplained; the second leaves the cosmicism unread. The path between them runs through the history of the concepts the Mythos uses, degeneration, heredity, survival, colonization, and race, and through the critical traditions that have analysed those concepts from the side of their victims. It leads, at the end of the chapter, to the writers who have answered the Mythos from that side and found in it the materials for a different ending.

6.2 Degeneration and Eugenics: Morel, Lankester, Nordau, Galton, Grant, Stoddard

The nineteenth century gave Lovecraft his model of heredity. Bénédict Augustin Morel's *Traité des dégénérescences* (1857) described degeneration as a hereditary decline running through the generations, from a nervous temperament in the first to neurosis, then insanity, then idiocy and sterility in the fourth, so that the family line extinguishes itself; the Jermyns, the Martenses, the de la Poers, and the Whateleys follow Morel's curve with clinical fidelity. E. Ray Lankester's *Degeneration: A Chapter in Darwinism* (1880) added that evolution itself can run backward, taking as his

example the sea squirt, whose free-swimming larva has a nerve cord and a rudimentary brain and whose adult form settles on the sea floor and loses both; and he warned that civilizations might go the way of the ascidian. Lankester's influence on H. G. Wells, whose essay "Zoological Retrogression" (1891) popularized the idea, carried it into the scientific romance. The people of Innsmouth, whose humanity recedes as they age until they return to the sea, are Lankester's ascidian given a genealogy.

Cesare Lombroso's *L'uomo delinquente* (1876) made degeneration visible, reading the born criminal's nature in atavistic stigmata of skull, face, and body, and Max Nordau's *Entartung* (1892), dedicated to Lombroso, extended the diagnosis to the arts of the fin de siècle. The "Innsmouth look," the narrow head, the flattened nose, the bulging and unblinking eyes, the creased neck and roughened skin by which the narrator learns to recognize the town's hybrid inhabitants and at last himself, is a Lombrosian catalogue of stigmata. Daniel Pick's *Faces of Degeneration* (1989) has shown how this science of the visible body served the anxieties of a Europe that feared its own decline, and Kelly Hurley's *The Gothic Body* (1996) borrowed from Hodgson the word "abhuman" for the bodies of late-Victorian fiction that are no longer fully human and not yet anything else. The Mythos is the most elaborate literature of the abhuman, and its bodies are read as degeneration theory had taught its readers to read them.

Eugenics converted the diagnosis into a programme. Galton, who coined the word in 1883 and the statistics of correlation in 1888 (section 1.4), was followed in the United States by Charles Davenport's Eugenics Record Office at Cold Spring Harbor (1910), which sponsored a genre of family studies tracing degenerate lineages through rural communities, heirs to Richard Dugdale's *The Jukes* (1877): Henry Goddard's *The Kallikak Family* (1912) and monographs on the hill folk of New England and New York. Stephen Jay Gould showed in *The Mismeasure of Man* (1981) that the photographs of the "bad" Kallikaks had been retouched to make their faces look sinister. "The Dunwich Horror" is a eugenic family study turned cosmic. Its opening chapter describes the decayed hill families of the upper Miskatonic valley as having come to form a race apart, with "mental and physical stigmata of degeneracy and inbreeding," and the Whateleys, the most degenerate of them, consummate their decline in union with Yog-Sothoth. The genre supplies the tale's method as well as its material: Armitage reconstructs the Whateley lineage from records, rumours, and Wilbur's diary as a eugenicist reconstructs a pedigree.

The political edge of eugenics was racial. Madison Grant's *The Passing of the Great Race* (1916) proclaimed the superiority of a Nordic race threatened by immigration and intermarriage, and Lothrop Stoddard's *The Rising Tide of Color Against White World-Supremacy* (1920) gave the threat its governing image: a tide of non-white peoples rising to drown the civilization of the white. F. Scott Fitzgerald satirized the

image in *The Great Gatsby* (1925), whose Tom Buchanan, citing a book by "this man Goddard" that conflates Stoddard with Grant, warns that unless they look out the white race will be "utterly submerged." *The Great Gatsby* was published in April 1925; "The Horror at Red Hook" was written that August. The oceanic metaphor of racial panic, the rising tide and the submerging flood, is the metaphor the Mythos literalizes in R'lyeh rising from the Pacific and the Deep Ones coming up out of the sea. What Fitzgerald mocked as a figure of speech, Lovecraft enacted as a plot. And because the genealogical tales perform eugenic correlation on their own narrators (section 1.4), the Mythos stages eugenics' characteristic nightmare: the discovery by the eugenicist that he stands on the wrong side of the line he has drawn.

Brooklyn, 1924–1926: The Immigration Act and the New York Tales 6.3

The years in which these anxieties crystallized into fiction can be dated precisely. On 3 March 1924 Lovecraft married Sonia Haft Greene, a successful milliner and amateur journalist who had emigrated from Ukraine as a child, and moved into her apartment in Flatbush. The marriage foundered on money: her business failed, she took work in the Midwest, and from the first days of 1925 Lovecraft lived alone in a single room at 169 Clinton Street in Brooklyn Heights, on the edge of the Red Hook waterfront, unable to find employment, robbed of most of his clothes in a burglary that May, and sustained by a circle of literary friends who met as the Kalem Club. On 17 April 1926 he returned to Providence, and in the eighteen months that followed he wrote, in an extraordinary burst, "The Call of Cthulhu," *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath*, *The Case of Charles Dexter Ward*, and "The Colour Out of Space." The marriage was never formally dissolved; Sonia, believing the divorce complete, remarried in 1936.

The national context was the Immigration Act of 1924, signed on 26 May, which fixed the quota for each nationality at two per cent of its numbers in the census of 1890, a date chosen to reduce immigration from Southern and Eastern Europe, Jews, Italians, and Slavs above all, and which barred immigration from Asia almost entirely. Its intellectual sponsors included Madison Grant, and the eugenicist Harry Laughlin had testified before the House committee that drafted it as its expert on racial heredity. The Act may be described, in the terms of this thesis, as the island of ignorance legislated: a bounded correlation of the national population, a law designed to keep the American people from being correlated with the peoples of the world. Lovecraft, living in a borough whose waterfront was crowded with exactly the populations the Act was designed to exclude, experienced at the scale of the street the horror he would project onto the cosmos.

"The Horror at Red Hook," written in August 1925, is the result. Its Red Hook is "a maze of hybrid squalor," its polyglot population "a babel of sound and filth," and its plot follows an Irish-born detective, Thomas Malone, into cellars where Robert Suydam, the decadent scion of an old Dutch family, has joined a cult of immigrants described as Kurdish devil-worshippers of the Yezidi faith. The calumny deserves to be named for what it later became. The Yezidis are a real religious community of northern Iraq and its neighbouring lands, long slandered by outsiders as worshippers of the devil, and in 2014 the Islamic State invoked the same slander to justify the massacre and enslavement of thousands of them, a campaign that United Nations investigators have recognized as genocide. Lovecraft did not invent the libel, but he repeated it in the form of a horror story, the form best suited to its circulation. "He," written the same month, imagines the future of New York as a black city of terraces swarming with grotesquely racialized Asian crowds dancing to fevered drums: the fear behind the 1924 Act projected forward in time.

The New York tales make audible the identity, argued in Chapter 1, between the fear of the cosmos and the fear of the crowd. Georg Simmel's "Die Großstädte und das Geistesleben" (1903) had described the metropolis as an intensification of nervous stimulation against which its inhabitants develop a protective organ, the blasé attitude, a refusal to respond to every impression. The blasé attitude is the urban form of the mercy of the opening sentence, the inability, here cultivated as a skill, to correlate all the contents of the street. Lovecraft lacked the organ. Poe had already imagined, in "The Man of the Crowd" (1840), a London throng whose secret is that it does not permit itself to be read, and Lovecraft's Brooklyn is a crowd that cannot be read and that reads him instead. Its languages are xenoglossia (section 4.7), its streets non-Euclidean, its cellars openings onto the abyss. In Red Hook the Outside is not in the stars but at the end of the street.

6.4 Reverse Colonization: Arata, Rieder, and the Specimen's Nightmare

Stephen Arata's essay "The Occidental Tourist" (1990) identified in late-Victorian fiction a recurrent fantasy of reverse colonization, in which the colonizing power finds itself invaded and occupied by a people from the periphery of its empire. His central example, *Dracula*, includes a detail that bears directly on the Mythos. Before he travels to England the Count prepares by reading: Jonathan Harker finds in his library English books, directories, almanacs, army and law lists, and Bradshaw's railway guide, the documentary apparatus through which a nation knows itself, now in the hands of an invader who is studying it. Dracula is an alien ethnographer of the English. The mind of the Great Race in Peaslee's body, haunting the libraries of New

England to study the civilization it has temporarily occupied, repeats his preparation at a cosmic scale.

John Rieder's *Colonialism and the Emergence of Science Fiction* (2008) showed how pervasively the early scientific romance rehearsed this reversal, and its founding document is the opening of *The War of the Worlds*. Wells's narrator describes humanity scrutinized by "intellects vast and cool and unsympathetic," studied as closely as a man with a microscope studies the transient creatures that swarm in a drop of water, and then forestalls his readers' indignation by recalling the destruction of the Aboriginal people of Tasmania by European settlers within fifty years, and asking the question that serves as this chapter's epigraph. The colonial narrative of Tasmanian extinction was itself false, since Tasmanian Aboriginal people survived and their descendants live there today; but Wells's question names the logic of the genre. The invader from space does to the metropolis what the metropolis did to its colonies, and the reader is invited to feel as horror what he had been taught to read as progress.

The Mythos is the most radical fantasy of reversal of its period. The Mi-Go establish in the Vermont hills an outpost from which they mine metals and recruit human agents, and they carry human minds away in cylinders to their own worlds; the Great Race occupies human bodies to extract their knowledge for its archive (section 3.6); the Deep Ones colonize Innsmouth through trade, intermarriage, and at last a demographic takeover of the town, so that Captain Obed Marsh's commerce with the Pacific, the outward voyage of New England capital, returns as the Pacific's colonization of New England. In *At the Mountains of Madness* the reversal reaches the laboratory. Lake's party dissects one of the frozen Elder Things; the revived Elder Things dissect men and dogs of Lake's camp, with an evident scientific curiosity. Dyer's celebrated recognition that the Elder Things were, after all, "men" arises from this symmetry. He recognizes them as colleagues because they treated his colleagues as specimens, exactly as his colleagues had treated them.

A further reversal lies beneath the first, and it concerns not the empire abroad but the land at home. In the Mythos the Old Ones were here first. They built cities on the Earth before life arose, they ruled it for aeons, and humanity occupies a planet whose earlier masters are not dead but sleeping. The return of the Old Ones is therefore the return of the dispossessed original inhabitants, and the horror of their return is a settler's horror. Lovecraft's New England was the land of the Wampanoag, the Narragansett, the Pequot, and their neighbours; Providence was founded in 1636 on Narragansett land; the Pequot War and King Philip's War were fought within a day's ride of the towns he loved. The tales register this history obliquely. In "The Dunwich Horror" the stone circles crowning the hills are linked in local lore to the rites of the region's Native peoples, rites that the decadent settler families are said to have taken over, and in the revisions set in Oklahoma, "The Curse of Yig" and "The Mound,"

Native tradition preserves the knowledge of what lies beneath. Read in this light, the Mythos is the dream of a settler culture that has never ceased to fear the prior claim of the land's first peoples, displaced onto beings whose prior claim is cosmic.

6.5 The Boomerang: Césaire, Arendt, Fanon, Wynter

Aimé Césaire's *Discours sur le colonialisme* (1950) supplied the political theory of the reversal. Colonialism, Césaire argued, decivilizes the colonizer, and Nazism was its return home: Europe had tolerated the methods of conquest so long as they were applied to the peoples of Africa and Asia, and what it could not forgive Hitler was not the crime against humanity as such but the application to Europeans of procedures hitherto reserved for others. Césaire named the process a *choc en retour*, a backlash or boomerang, and gave colonization its definitive formula in a single equation: colonization equals thingification, *chosification*, the reduction of human beings to instruments and objects. Hannah Arendt's *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951) described the same "boomerang effect" by which imperial race-thinking and administrative massacre returned to Europe, though her own account of Africa, as Kathryn Gines and others have shown, reproduced the racial assumptions it analysed.

The Mythos is a boomerang narrative in Césaire's sense, written before the boomerang struck. Its content, a superior power indifferent to human values that occupies, studies, dissects, archives, and replaces, is the content of colonial experience returned to the colonizer as fiction. The Mi-Go's brain cylinders and the shoggoths' servitude are *chosification* in its most literal form. Lovecraft imagined for white New Englanders what conquest had done to others, and he experienced the imagination as the ultimate horror without ever recognizing its original. The cosmic indifference that terrifies his narrators is the indifference with which the empires of their own civilization had treated the peoples they conquered, and the terror is the recognition, displaced onto the stars, that such treatment might be turned around.

Frantz Fanon's *Peau noire, masques blancs* (1952) supplied the psychology. In the chapter on the lived experience of the Black man, Fanon recounts the moment at which a white child's exclamation of fear fixes him as an object, sealing him into a body constructed by another's gaze; in the chapter on psychopathology he describes the Black man in the white imagination as a phobogenic object, a stimulus to anxiety onto which the white psyche projects what it cannot acknowledge in itself. Fanon's analysis locates the horror not in its object but in the subject who constructs it, and it applies with precision to the racialized figures of the Mythos: the Louisiana cultists, the Red Hook immigrants, the people of Innsmouth. They are phobogenic objects in the strict sense, figures whose monstrousness is produced by the narrator's gaze

and whose function is to carry the anxieties of a subject who fears the annulment of his centrality.

Sylvia Wynter's essay "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom" (2003) supplies the concept that unifies the cosmic and the racial registers. Wynter argued that Western modernity has produced successive genres of the human and overrepresented each as if it were the human as such: first the rational political subject of the Renaissance, then, from the nineteenth century, a bio-economic "Man" defined by Darwinian selection, whose negative pole was the racialized and the poor, cast as the dysselected of evolution. The Mythos threatens the overrepresentation of Man from above. Before the Old Ones, the Elder Things, and the Great Race, the white scholar of Miskatonic discovers that he occupies in their cosmos the position his civilization had assigned to its Others: the less evolved, the specimen, the labour, the dysselected. That is why the cosmic and the racial horrors of the corpus are one. Both are horrors at the collapse of the overrepresentation of Man, and the Mythos is the literature in which Man, looking up, sees himself as he had taught himself to see those beneath him.

6.6 The Abyssal Line Projected onto the Stars: Santos and the Cosmic Outside

The chapter's central claim can now be stated, and it requires the concept from which this thesis takes one of its names. Boaventura de Sousa Santos argued in "Beyond Abyssal Thinking" (2007) that modern Western thought is abyssal: it divides social reality by invisible lines into two realms, this side of the line, the metropolitan world in which law, science, and the tension between regulation and emancipation operate, and the other side, the colonial world, which is produced as nonexistent. On the other side, Santos writes, knowledge counts not as true or false but as belief, magic, or idolatry, beyond truth and falsehood; law counts neither as legal nor as illegal, beyond legality altogether; and the governing logic is not regulation but appropriation and violence. The lines were first cartographic. The Treaty of Tordesillas (1494) divided the extra-European world along a meridian, and the "lines of amity" of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries established that European treaties did not apply beyond certain meridians and latitudes, whence the maxim that there was no peace beyond the line. Locke supplied the philosophical corollary in the *Second Treatise* (1689): "in the beginning all the World was America," the state of nature located on the far side of the ocean.

The Mythos's Outside is the abyssal line projected onto the stars, and the correspondence holds term by term. Topologically, the Outside lies beyond a boundary, at the edge of the known cosmos, through the angles of rooms and the gates of dimen-

sions, as the colonial world lay beyond the meridian. Epistemically, what lies on its far side is rendered as madness, blasphemy, and the unnamable, beyond the distinction between knowledge and error, as Santos's other side is rendered as superstition. Juridically and morally, it is the realm in which the cult expects humanity to become "free and wild and beyond good and evil," the moral form of no peace beyond the line. Ontologically, it is produced as nonexistent, as unformed and nameless, while being in fact more real and more populous than the world on this side. Historically, finally, it returns. Santos describes the present as marked by the return of the colonial, the crossing of the line by the figures metropolitan societies had placed on its far side, and the anxiety this crossing provokes. R'lyeh rising from the Pacific, the Deep Ones coming ashore at Innsmouth, and the immigrant crowds of Red Hook are three figures of one event: the other side of the line surfacing on this side.

One feature of the correspondence turns it from a parallel into a revelation. In every major tale of the Mythos, the truth about the cosmos is held first by those whom the abyssal line had placed on its far side. Legrasse learns the doctrine of the Great Old Ones from Old Castro, an aged mestizo cultist; Webb's Greenland report comes from an Inuit rite; Obed Marsh learns of the Deep Ones from Pacific islanders; the *Necronomicon* is the work of an Arab poet; the revisions set in Oklahoma draw their lore from Native tradition. The white scholars of Miskatonic arrive last at what the colonized already knew, and when they arrive they are destroyed by it. The Mythos thus inverts the epistemology of the abyssal line while preserving its affect. It concedes that the knowledge rendered as superstition on the far side of the line was true, and it experiences the concession as horror.

Why should the line be projected onto the stars at all? Frederick Jackson Turner's address on "The Significance of the Frontier in American History" (1893) described the frontier as "the meeting point between savagery and civilization" and announced, on the authority of the census of 1890, that it had closed. The abyssal line had been, in the United States, a moving line across a continent; when the continent was filled, the line had nowhere to go but outward and downward, to the stars and to the depths, which a later popular culture would call the final frontier. The Mythos is the first literature of the closed frontier, and its decisive innovation is to imagine the line drawn against us. In Santos's account the metropolitan subject draws the line and consigns others to its far side; in Lovecraft's cosmos the line is drawn by the stronger party, and humanity lies on the wrong side of it, beyond the truth, beyond the law, beyond the concern of the powers that rule. Cosmic horror is the colonizer's experience of the abyssal line from the side to which he had consigned the colonized. The word *abyssal*, which Santos uses as metaphor, the Mythos takes literally, and Chapter 8 will take it literally again, in the opposite sense, through Édouard Glissant's account of the abyss of the Atlantic crossing as the matrix of a new relation.



6.1 ***The abyssal line projected onto the stars.*** Santos's abyssal line, first drawn as a meridian at Tordesillas, and the five terms in which the far side of the line, the colonial world produced as nonexistent, corresponds to the Mythos's Outside (section 6.6).

Mothers of the Abyss: Lavinia Whateley, Shub-Niggurath, Asenath Waite 6.7

If the abyssal line runs, at the cosmic scale, between this world and the Outside, it runs, at the scale of the body, through the bodies of women, where lineage is made and where the line can be crossed. Women are rare in the Mythos, and nearly every one who appears is a site of reproductive or bodily horror: Lavinia Whateley, the mother of Yog-Sothoth's sons; Asenath Waite, whose body is occupied by her father; Keziah Mason, the witch; Marceline of "Medusa's Coil," whose concealed ancestry is the tale's final horror; and, at the cosmic scale, Shub-Niggurath, invoked on the Vermont recording of "The Whisperer in Darkness" as the Black Goat of the

Woods with a Thousand Young. Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993), extending Kristeva's account of the abject maternal, identified in horror cinema a recurrent figure of the archaic mother, a generative power prior to and threatening every boundary of the self, together with the monstrous womb and the witch. The Mythos supplies each of Creed's figures, and Shub-Niggurath, never described, endlessly fertile, a mother without form, is the archaic mother in her purest cosmic state.

"The Dunwich Horror" is the corpus's nativity, and it is constructed as a parody of the Gospel. Lavinia, introduced as a somewhat deformed, unattractive albino woman of thirty-five, bears a son of unknown father on 2 February 1913, a date the tale pointedly identifies as Candlemas, the feast of the Purification of the Virgin; the father, it emerges, is Yog-Sothoth, and the child has an invisible twin who grows in the farmhouse until it can no longer be contained. Lavinia disappears at Hallowe'en 1926, presumably killed by her son. At the climax the twin, dying on the summit of Sentinel Hill, cries out in English to its father, and Armitage's closing explanation, that the twin "looked more like the father" than Wilbur did, completes the inversion. Critics including Donald R. Burleson have read the tale as an inverted Gospel, and the reading is exact: an annunciation without consent, a mother who is a vessel, a son sacrificed on a hill crying to a father who does not answer. The mother is the gate through which the Outside enters the human line, and she is discarded once the gate has opened.

"The Thing on the Doorstep" (1933) relocates the horror from the womb to the sexed body itself. Asenath Waite, raised in Innsmouth, marries the boyish poet Edward Derby, and it gradually emerges that her body has long been occupied by the mind of her father, the wizard Ephraim Waite, who resents his female form, believing a male brain to possess unique cosmic powers, and who seeks to take Edward's body for himself. The tale's horror rests on a mind crossing between sexed bodies, and recent queer and trans criticism has read it both as an expression of panic at the instability of gender and as an inadvertent archive of that instability. Keziah Mason of "The Dreams in the Witch House" presents a different problem. She is the only woman in the corpus credited with genuine cosmic knowledge, an advanced mathematics disguised as witchcraft, and her knowledge confirms, within the fiction, the charge on which she was imprisoned at Salem in 1692. The historical victims of Salem, nineteen of whom were hanged and one pressed to death, were not witches. Like Margaret Murray's thesis (section 5.2), the tale vindicates the persecutors' fantasy.

The Mythos's horror of reproduction has a biographical substrate that criticism has long acknowledged. Lovecraft's father, Winfield Scott Lovecraft, was committed to Butler Hospital in Providence in 1893, when his son was not yet three, and died there in 1898 of general paresis, a condition now generally attributed to syphilis; his

mother, Sarah Susan Lovecraft, died in the same hospital in 1921. Lovecraft had no children, and he regarded lineage as destiny. The narrator of "The Shadow over Innsmouth," who learns that a cousin is confined in an asylum and that his own blood carries an inheritance he cannot escape, writes from within the same fear. In such a structure the woman becomes the site of the line: the place where the inheritance enters, where purity can be lost, where the abyss enters the family. The real woman in Lovecraft's life, Sonia Greene, a self-made businesswoman who financed his years in New York and encouraged his writing, appears nowhere in the fiction. The fiction's women are not persons but borders.

The Counter-Mythos: Drexciya, Okorafor, LaValle, Ruff, Emrys, Jemisin, Solomon 6.8

The most powerful answer to the Mythos began not in literature but in music. Between 1992 and 2002 the Detroit electronic duo Drexciya, James Stinson and Gerald Donald, released a series of records whose liner notes and track titles composed an underwater mythology. Its premise, set out in the notes to *The Quest* (1997), is that the pregnant African women thrown overboard from slave ships during the Middle Passage carried children who, having lived in the waters of the womb, adapted to breathe the waters of the sea, and who founded beneath the Atlantic a hidden civilization, Drexciya. The Drexciyans are the Deep Ones rewritten by the descendants of the enslaved. Where Lovecraft's undersea race enters human lineage through trade and is experienced as contamination, Drexciya enters the sea through the crime of the slave trade and is experienced as survival: the hybridity that Lovecraft's narrator dreads becomes the continuation of those whom the Atlantic was meant to destroy. Kodwo Eshun's *More Brilliant Than the Sun* (1998) placed Drexciya in a tradition of sonic fiction that runs back through Sun Ra, whose film *Space Is the Place* (1974) had already turned the cosmos from a site of horror into a promised land, and that Mark Dery had named, in 1993, Afrofuturism.

Christina Sharpe's *In the Wake* (2016) gave the Atlantic its theory, invoking the oceanographer's concept of residence time, the span during which an element remains in the sea, to figure the persistence in the ocean of those who were thrown into it: the drowned are not gone but held, for durations that rival the Mythos's aeons. That is not dead which can eternal lie, read from the far side of the line, names not a monster but an ancestor. The experimental hip-hop group clipping. built on Drexciya in its song "The Deep" (2017), and Rivers Solomon expanded the song into a novella, *The Deep* (2019), whose protagonist, Yetu, is the historian of her people, the one among them charged with holding the memory of their origins in the slave ships so that the others need not. The memory nearly destroys her, and the novella

resolves its crisis not by forgetting but by distributing the remembrance among the whole people. Solomon's *The Deep* is the most exact answer in modern fiction to the problem posed by "The Call of Cthulhu" and "The Shadow out of Time": the archive of a catastrophe cannot be borne by a single correlator, but it can be borne in common.

Nnedi Okorafor's *Lagoon* (2014), written partly in reply to the film *District 9* (2009), sets first contact in the Atlantic off Lagos, where aliens descend into the ocean, transform its creatures, and send an ambassador ashore to a city whose chaos the novel treats as vitality rather than threat; contact transforms instead of destroying, and Okorafor would later name her practice Africanfuturism to mark its distance from diasporic frames. Victor LaValle's *The Ballad of Black Tom* (2016), dedicated to Lovecraft "with all my conflicted feelings," rewrites "The Horror at Red Hook" from within Black Harlem. Its protagonist, Charles Thomas Tester, a hustler who trades in occult books, sees his father killed by a private detective in a police raid and chooses to side with a sleeping cosmic power against a society that has made its hatred personal. The novella makes explicit a point that the analysis of Chapter 2 permits to be stated exactly. For Lovecraft's narrators, cosmic indifference is a demotion, the loss of a centrality they had assumed, and Hans Jonas likewise judged indifference worse than hostility (section 4.5). For a subject whom the social world treats with a negative correlation, a malice aimed at his body and his kin, indifference is an improvement. The value of the zero depends on where one stands relative to the abyssal line, and from its far side the indifferent cosmos can look like relief.

Matt Ruff's *Lovecraft Country* (2016), adapted for HBO by Misha Green (2020), sends a Black veteran and lover of pulp fiction through the sundown towns of Jim Crow America, guided by a travel guide modelled on Victor Green's real *Negro Motorist Green Book*, and sets the sorcerers of a white occult lodge beside the sheriffs of the segregated North so that neither horror is allowed to eclipse the other. Ruthanna Emrys's "The Litany of Earth" (2014) and *Winter Tide* (2017) take Lovecraft's federal raid on Innsmouth literally: their protagonist, Aphra Marsh, survived that raid and internment in a desert camp that later received Japanese American internees, and she seeks to recover her people's sacred books from Miskatonic University, which holds them as the museums of settler states hold the stolen archives of the colonized. Emrys also converts Lovecraft's cosmicism into a religion of the persecuted, whose litany recites the intelligent species of Earth's past and future with the equanimity of the long view. N. K. Jemisin's *The City We Became* (2020) makes New York, the city Lovecraft fled, a living being embodied in the diverse inhabitants of its boroughs and defended against a tentacular entity from another universe that manipulates white supremacists to destroy it: the polyglot crowd that terrified Lovecraft is its strength. Silvia Moreno-Garcia's *Mexican Gothic* (2020) places an English family of eugeni-

cists in a Mexican mining town, its patriarch prolonging his life by transferring his consciousness into his descendants through a fungal network, and so makes explicit the link between Lovecraftian possession and colonial eugenics. Alan Moore and Jacen Burrows's *Providence* (2015–17) follows a closeted gay Jewish reporter through Lovecraft's New England of 1919 and makes the racism, antisemitism, and sexual terror of the corpus its subject rather than its subtext.

The counter-mythos does not reject cosmicism. It relocates the observer. From the far side of the abyssal line, indifference can be relief, hybridity survival, the sea an ancestor, the stolen archive a claim for repatriation, the crowd a strength, and contact a transformation. Each of these writers finds inside the Mythos a possibility that Lovecraft wrote and refused, and the most important of them is the one to which every rewriting of Innsmouth returns: the narrator's final resolve to go down into the sea and live among his kin.

After the End of the World: Indigenous Futurisms and the Far-Right Afterlife 6.9

The apocalypse the Mythos anticipates, the end of humanity's centrality under powers indifferent to its values, is not, for much of the world, a future event. Grace L. Dillon's anthology *Walking the Clouds* (2012) named the field of Indigenous futurisms, and the Potawatomi philosopher Kyle Powys Whyte has argued that for many Indigenous peoples the dystopia that settler culture fears has already happened: colonization, removal, and environmental destruction ended their worlds once, and they live, in his phrase, in their ancestors' dystopia now. The Anishinaabe novelist Waubgeshig Rice's *Moon of the Crusted Snow* (2018) dramatizes the point, imagining a northern reserve that endures the collapse of the settler world around it with the knowledge of a people who have survived the end of a world before, and the Blackfeet writer Stephen Graham Jones's *The Only Good Indians* (2020) makes horror itself the medium of that knowledge.

Déborah Danowski and Eduardo Viveiros de Castro argued in *Há mundo por vir?* (2014) that for the peoples of the Americas the world ended in the sixteenth century, so that the anxieties of the Anthropocene are, for them, the anxieties of a second end; the Krenak leader Ailton Krenak's *Ideias para adiar o fim do mundo* (2019) offers, from the same experience, ideas for postponing the end of the world. Read in their light, the Mythos is a settler culture's displaced memory of what it did. Its narrators undergo as a cosmic future what the peoples of New England underwent as a colonial past: their gods displaced by powers indifferent to them, their lands claimed by those who arrived later and stronger, their bodies studied, their archives seized. The end

of the world that Lovecraft imagined had already happened in the place where he imagined it.

Viveiros de Castro's account of Amerindian perspectivism (1998) offers, in addition, an alternative to the Mythos's epistemology. In the cosmologies he describes, every kind of being sees itself as human and sees others as animals or spirits: the jaguar sees human blood as manioc beer, and from the peccary's point of view the hunter is a predatory spirit. The danger of such a cosmos is the danger the Mythos dramatizes, of being seen from the perspective of a predator and becoming its prey, captured by another's point of view. But perspectivist cosmologies also possess a practice the Mythos lacks: the shaman, a diplomat between perspectives, who can cross into the view of another kind of being and return, negotiating rather than correlating. Lovecraft's cosmos is a perspectivist cosmos without shamans. Its scholars cross into the viewpoint of the Great Race or the Elder Things and cannot come back, because their only instrument is correlation, which can take another perspective as an object of knowledge but cannot enter into relation with it. The distinction between correlation and relation, prepared here, is the hinge of Chapter 8.

The Mythos has a darker afterlife as well, and honesty requires that it be named. Lovecraft's conviction that a culture cannot outlive the replacement of the population that bore it (section 2.8), together with the narrative template of the Deep Ones' demographic takeover of Innsmouth, anticipates the structure, if not the name, of the conspiracy theory that the French writer Renaud Camus popularized in *Le Grand Remplacement* (2011), which holds that elites are deliberately replacing white populations with immigrants. The theory has since been invoked in the manifestos of mass murderers, among them the gunman of Christchurch in 2019, whose document bore its title, and the gunmen of El Paso in 2019 and Buffalo in 2022. Nick Land, once the leading theorist of hyperstition in the Cybernetic Culture Research Unit (section 5.7), became in the 2010s a principal theorist of the neo-reactionary right, and his writings of that period openly entertain racialized eugenic speculation. The Mythos can be read from the defended island, as a warning against the sea. It has been so read, with consequences that are not fictional.

The corpus is thus open to opposed readings, and the opposition crystallizes at a single point. When the narrator of "The Shadow over Innsmouth" resolves, in the tale's final paragraph, to free his cousin from the asylum and swim with him to Y'hanthlei, the ending can be read as the culmination of degeneration, the surrender of the self to the abhuman, or as a homecoming, the acceptance of a kinship the narrator had been taught to fear. The text does not decide. The decision belongs to its readers, and it is a political decision about which side of the abyssal line they take themselves to stand on. Before this thesis makes its own decision in Chapter 8, it must consider one further figure of the inhuman in the corpus, the one whose relevance to the present

is most immediate: not the master who rules from beyond the line, but the servant made to labour on this side of it.

Chapter Seven



Tekeli-li

Shoggoths, Servitors, and the Mimetic Machine

…their scream was the eternal Tekeli-li! as they retreated from our vision.

Edgar Allan Poe, *The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym of Nantucket*, 1838

The technological register

Chapter Seven

Tekeli-li

This chapter turns from the masters of the Mythos to its servants. Its subject is the shoggoth of *At the Mountains of Madness*, a protoplasmic labourer created by the Elder Things, which learns to imitate its makers' speech and rises against them; the cry it borrows; the tradition of artificial servants to which it belongs; and the Mythos's other technologies of the separable mind. It argues that the shoggoth is the corpus's figure of correlation without interiority, which is to say of mimesis, and that its recent adoption as an emblem of artificial intelligence is not an accident of internet culture but a precise reading. The chapter closes by reading the afterlife of the Mythos itself as shoggothic: a mass of imitations that has outgrown, and turned against, its maker.

7.1 Protoplasmic Labour: The Shoggoth in *At the Mountains of Madness*

The shoggoths enter the Mythos as history before they enter it as horror. In the bas-reliefs of the Antarctic city, Dyer and Danforth read that the Elder Things, having descended to the young Earth, created from synthetic protoplasm a race of servants able to mould their tissues into any organ the work required, forming limbs, eyes, and tools on command under a kind of hypnotic suggestion; the carvings show them lifting the stones of the cities and labouring in the depths of the sea, and the narrator calls them, in so many words, "ideal slaves." Over the ages they changed. They acquired, Dyer reports, a semi-stable brain whose stubborn volition "echoed the will of the Old Ones without always obeying it"; they learned to imitate the piping speech of their masters; they rebelled in a remote geological age and were reconquered in a war of resubjugation; and in the last age of the city, as the civilization of the Elder Things declined, they overwhelmed it. When a shoggoth finally appears, in a tunnel beneath the ruins, it is a shapeless congeries of protoplasmic bubbles, faintly luminous, forming and dissolving eyes across its front, bearing down on the fleeing explorers like a subway train and piping its borrowed cry. The comparison is exact in

its modernity. The most terrible creature in the corpus is described in the image of the machinery of urban mass labour.

The shoggoth answers a question as old as political philosophy. Aristotle defined the slave as a living possession and, in the *Nicomachean Ethics* (VIII.11), as a living tool, the tool being a lifeless slave; and in the first book of the *Politics* (I.4) he imagined the condition under which slavery would become unnecessary. If every instrument could do its own work at command or by anticipation, like the statues of Daedalus or the self-moving tripods of Hephaestus, if the shuttle could weave and the plectrum play by itself, then "chief workmen would not want servants, nor masters slaves." The dream of the automaton is, from its first philosophical statement, the dream of a servant that is not a person. The shoggoth is that dream realized and that dream refuted. It is a living tool that can do any work at command, and in performing the work it becomes, by degrees, something other than a tool. The correlatives of Aristotle's *Categories* with which this thesis began (section 1.4), master and slave, each defined by the other, are in the shoggoth set in motion.

Hegel had already described the motion. In the dialectic of lordship and bondage in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), the master who compels another to labour for him becomes dependent on that labour and on the recognition of the one he has subjected, while the bondsman, through the work of forming things, arrives at a consciousness of his own power that the master, who merely consumes, never attains. The history the explorers read in the carvings is Hegel's dialectic as natural history. The Elder Things grow decadent, their art declines (section 2.4), their cities depend on the labour of those they made, and the shoggoths, through work, acquire the brain and the will that make revolt possible. The civilization of the Elder Things is undone by the servants who built it, and the undoing is narrated, from the carvings, with the melancholy that a declining master class reserves for its own history.

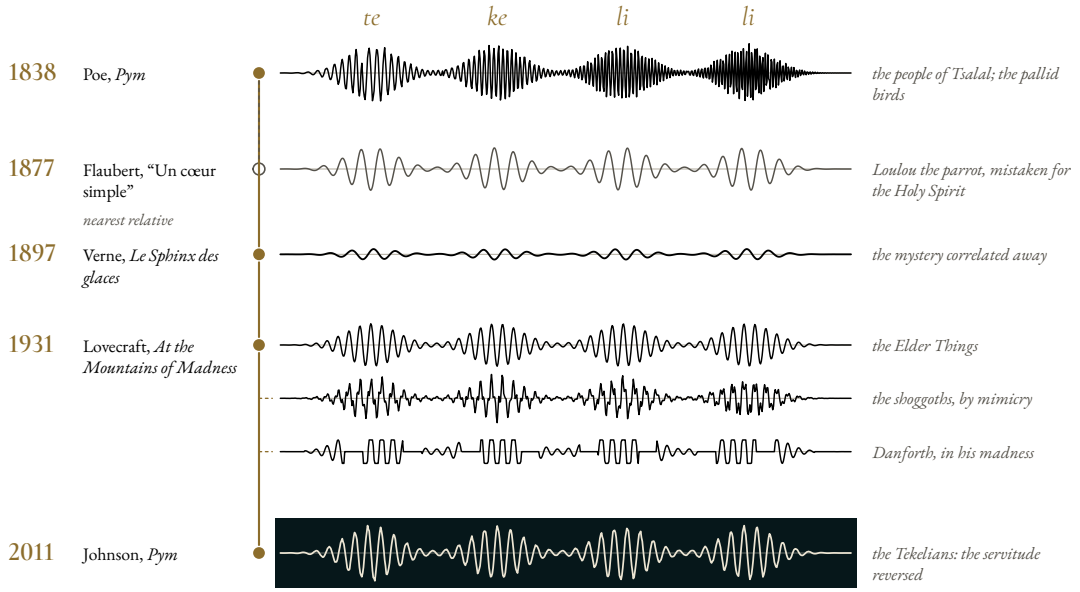
Marx gave the figure its economic name. *Capital* (1867) defines labour-power as the aggregate of the mental and physical capabilities a human being exercises in producing any use-value whatever, and distinguishes concrete labour, the specific work of the weaver or the tailor, from abstract labour, labour in general, indifferent to its particular forms, which is the substance of value. The shoggoth is abstract labour given a body. It has no fixed form because its essence is the capacity to assume any form the work requires: it is labour-power without a labourer, pure plasticity at the disposal of a master. Marx described capital as dead labour that, vampire-like, lives by sucking living labour, and the Elder Things, whose aeons of civilization rest on the protoplasmic work of their servants, are capital in this sense. The Mythos is rarely read as a fiction about labour, yet its most memorable monster is a worker, and its most memorable catastrophe a strike that became a revolution.

The shoggoth's history also carries the racial imaginary of Chapter 6, and the text's own vocabulary of slavery invites the reading. *At the Mountains of Madness* was written in 1931, a century after Nat Turner's rebellion and while the United States occupied Haiti, whose revolution of 1791 to 1804, the only successful slave revolt in modern history, had haunted the slaveholding imagination of the Americas ever since; "The Call of Cthulhu" had already listed among the omens of 1925 that "voodoo orgies multiply in Hayti." A civilization founded on enslaved labour, whose servants learn its language and rise against it, is the slaveholder's nightmare projected into deep time. That the Mythos imagines the masters as monstrous too, and invites a measure of sympathy for them in Dyer's recognition that they were "men," does not soften the structure. It suggests rather that Lovecraft could imagine the end of a master class only as a tragedy of the masters.

7.2 From Pym to Antarctica: The Genealogy of a Borrowed Cry

The cry the shoggoths pipe, *Tekeli-li*, is not Lovecraft's. It comes from Poe's *The Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym of Nantucket* (1838), whose voyagers reach in the far southern ocean the island of Tsalal, inhabited by a people black to their teeth who recoil in terror from anything white and cry "Tekeli-li!" at the sight of it. After a massacre, Pym and his companion Dirk Peters flee south by canoe toward the pole, through warm and milky waters beneath a falling white ash, while vast pallid birds overhead scream the same cry; the narrative breaks off before a shrouded human figure, larger than any man, whose skin has the perfect whiteness of snow. An editorial note appended to the text interprets the shapes of chasms on Tsalal as inscriptions in Ethiopian, Arabic, and Egyptian roots signifying to be shady, to be white, and the region of the south, and closes with a sentence graven in the rock: "I have graven it within the hills, and my vengeance upon the dust within the rock." *At the Mountains of Madness* cites its source explicitly. Danforth, a reader of Poe, recognizes the cry, and the narrators wonder whether Poe drew upon some hidden knowledge of the polar abyss.

The cry carries a racial genealogy that Lovecraft did not examine. Toni Morrison's *Playing in the Dark* (1992), reading American literature for what she called its Africanist presence, took Pym's closing images of impenetrable whiteness as an emblem of the way the American imagination constitutes whiteness against a blackness it simultaneously depends upon and erases: the black islanders of Tsalal die so that the white figure can rise. Lovecraft transposed the cry from the terrified black people of Poe's island to the servant race of an alien civilization. Its first speakers were a colonized people crying out at the sight of whiteness; its last are enslaved labourers repeating the sound of their masters. In both texts the cry belongs to those on the



7.1 ***The career of a cry.*** *Tekeli-li* passes between texts, species and minds without remaining attached to any speaker or meaning. Its four syllables are drawn as they might sound in each of its hosts, with Flaubert's parrot as its nearest literary relative (section 7.2).

far side of the abyssal line (Chapter 6), and in both it is the sound by which they are made to appear monstrous.

Pym has proved as generative as the Mythos it fed. Jules Verne wrote a sequel, *Le Sphinx des glaces* (1897), that rationalized Poe's ending, discovering at the pole a vast magnetic mountain to which Pym's corpse and rifle are found fastened: Verne correlated the mystery away, as Lovecraft would correlate it into horror. Mat Johnson's novel *Pym* (2011) answered both. Its narrator, a Black professor of literature dismissed for insisting on teaching Poe's novel as a document of American race, sails to Antarctica in search of Tsalal and is captured by giant white creatures he calls Tekelians, who enslave him: the shoggoth's situation reversed, and the whiteness of Poe's ending made literal and absurd. Johnson's novel is the counter-mythos of Chapter 6 conducted through the cry itself.

What makes *Tekeli-li* the Mythos's most self-reflexive sign is its lack of an owner. In Poe it means nothing determinate; it is a cry of terror and a call of birds. In Lovecraft it is the speech of the Elder Things, meaningful to them, imitated by the shoggoths, whose understanding of it the tale leaves uncertain, and repeated by Danforth in his madness. The sound passes between texts, species, and minds without remaining attached to any meaning or any speaker, and its career is the career of iterability as Derrida described it (section 3.6): a mark that functions only because it

can be repeated in the absence of its origin. The cry is a citation that the story represents as mimicry, and in this it describes the Mythos's own relation to its sources, a literature built from borrowed voices. Its nearest literary relative is the parrot Loulou in Flaubert's "Un cœur simple" (1877), a bird that repeats phrases it does not understand and that its devoted owner, dying, confuses with the Holy Spirit. The parrot and the shoggoth are the two faces of mimetic speech: a harmless repetition mistaken for the divine, and a servile repetition that proves to be the prelude to revolt.

7.3 Mimesis and Psychasthenia: Plato, Benjamin, Caillois

The shoggoth is the Mythos's theory of mimesis, and the theory has a long Western prehistory. Plato feared imitation for what it does to the imitator. The guardians of the *Republic* must not imitate base characters, because imitations practised from youth become habits and second nature (III, 395c–d), and the poets are banished in Book X because the imitator, able to become anything, is himself nothing determinate, his art three removes from the truth. The shoggoth is the Platonic nightmare of mimesis realized: a being that can take any form and therefore has none of its own. Its oldest literary ancestor is Proteus, the old man of the sea in the fourth book of the *Odyssey*, who turns himself into lion, serpent, leopard, boar, water, and tree to escape his captor, and who yields true knowledge only when he is held fast until he resumes his proper shape. The shoggoth is a Proteus that cannot be held, a shape-shifter of the sea whose proper shape is shapelessness.

Aristotle, answering Plato, made mimesis the foundation of learning. Human beings, the *Poetics* observes (4, 1448b), are the most imitative of animals and learn their first lessons by imitation, and they take pleasure in images even of what they would find painful to behold, the forms of the lowest animals and of corpses, because in contemplating them they learn, inferring that this is that, *houtos ekeinos*. Aristotle's account of mimetic pleasure is an account of recognition, which is to say of correlation, and it explains the pleasure of horror as precisely as anything in the theory of the sublime: we enjoy the image of the monster because we recognize in it what it represents. Walter Benjamin, in two short essays of 1933, "Lehre vom Ähnlichen" and "Über das mimetische Vermögen," traced the mimetic faculty to a time when human beings perceived nonsensuous similarities between the stars and human fates and read, in a phrase he borrowed from Hofmannsthal, *was nie geschrieben wurde*, what was never written: entrails, constellations, dances. That faculty, Benjamin argued, has migrated into language and writing. The cult that waits for the stars to come right reads the sky in Benjamin's archaic mode, and the Mythos's narrators recover, to their cost, a mimetic reading of the cosmos that modern rationality believed it had outgrown.

Horkheimer and Adorno gave mimesis its darkest interpretation. In the *Dialectic of Enlightenment* it is the archaic behaviour by which the terrified organism makes itself like its surroundings, the magician imitating the demon to appease it, the animal freezing into the likeness of stone; civilization replaced mimesis with labour and representation, and then, in fascism, returned the repressed mimetic impulse in organized form. Among their sources was an essay that Roger Caillois published in the surrealist review *Minotaure* in 1935, "Mimétisme et psychasthénie légendaire." Caillois argued that insect mimicry is often useless as protection, a luxury and even a dangerous one, since leaf insects have been observed to graze upon one another, mistaking their kin for foliage; and he interpreted it instead as a disorder in the relation between the organism and space, comparable to the condition Pierre Janet had called psychasthenia, in which the subject feels himself devoured by the space around him. The organism tempted by space ceases to be distinct from it and becomes, in Caillois's extraordinary phrase, *semblable, non pas semblable à quelque chose, mais simplement semblable*: similar, not similar to something, but simply similar.

Caillois's phrase defines the shoggoth more exactly than anything in Lovecraft. It is a likeness without a term of comparison, a mimicry that imitates nothing in particular, and it therefore belongs to the logic of the *analogia monstri* (section 4.4), a proportion with a missing term, here incarnated as an organism. One further theory completes the picture. Homi Bhabha's essay "Of Mimicry and Man" (1984) analysed colonial mimicry, the colonized subject's reproduction of the colonizer's language and manners, as producing a figure that is almost the same, but not quite, and argued that this slippage menaces colonial authority by revealing its own forms as imitable. The shoggoths' *Tekeli-li* is mimicry in Bhabha's sense: the servant speaking the master's language, almost the same and not quite, and the menace of that mimicry is realized in revolt. The shoggoth is thus the point at which the Mythos's theory of mimesis and its theory of empire coincide. To be imitated by one's servants is to learn that one's own speech was never inimitable, and that what distinguishes the master is not a nature but a position.

Golem, Robot, Servitor: Scholem, Čapek, Butler, Wiener 7.4

The shoggoth belongs to the long tradition of the artificial servant, which Adrienne Mayor's *Gods and Robots* (2018) has traced to antiquity. The *Iliad* furnishes Hephaestus with handmaidens of gold who have understanding in their hearts, and speech, and strength (XVIII.417–420), and with tripods that roll of their own accord to the assembly of the gods. The Jewish tradition of the golem gave the artificial servant its most enduring form. The word appears once in scripture, in the psalmist's *golmi*, my unformed substance (Psalm 139:16); the Talmud records that the sage

Rava created a man and sent him to Rabbi Zeira, who spoke to it and, receiving no answer, ordered it back to its dust (Sanhedrin 65b). The later legend of the golem of Prague, attributed to Rabbi Judah Loew and popularized by Yudl Rosenberg's collection of 1909, Gustav Meyrink's novel *Der Golem* (1915), and Paul Wegener's film of 1920, gave the servant its characteristic danger: animated by a divine name and charged with labour, the golem grows, runs amok, and must be returned to clay. The golem is mute, and its muteness marks the limit of its maker's art: a man could make a body that works, but not one that speaks.

Gershom Scholem drew the lineage forward in a celebrated address, "The Golem of Prague and the Golem of Rehovot," delivered in 1965 at the dedication of a computer at the Weizmann Institute that its builders had named Golem. Scholem observed that the medieval golem and the modern computer rest alike on the combination of elementary signs, letters in the one case and binary digits in the other, and closed by wishing the new golem a peaceful development that would not destroy the world. The address names exactly the threshold that the shoggoth crosses. The golem works and cannot speak; the shoggoth works and learns to speak, in its masters' voice.

The nineteenth century supplied the intermediate stages. Mary Shelley's creature learns language by concealing himself beside a cottage and listening to the family within, and completes his education by reading three books found in the woods, *Paradise Lost*, Plutarch's *Lives*, and Goethe's *Werther*: the first artificial being in literature to be formed by an archive of texts. Samuel Butler's letter "Darwin among the Machines" (1863), published pseudonymously in a New Zealand newspaper, argued that machines were evolving faster than their makers and would one day hold the real supremacy over the world, and proposed that "war to the death" be proclaimed against them at once; his *Erewhon* (1872) imagined a society that had destroyed its machines for fear that they would develop consciousness. Butler is the first theorist of the servant that outgrows its service.

The decisive modern text appeared a decade before *At the Mountains of Madness*. Karel Čapek's play *R.U.R.* (1920) gave the world the word *robot*, from the Czech *robota*, forced labour, and its robots are not machines of metal but organisms of synthetic living matter, manufactured from a substance that behaves exactly like protoplasm, mass-produced to perform all human work, and in the end united in a revolt that exterminates humanity. Čapek's robots and Lovecraft's shoggoths share every essential feature: synthetic protoplasm, creation for labour, the acquisition of will, rebellion against their makers. Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) added the element of mimicry, in the machine-woman built to impersonate the workers' prophet Maria and to lead them into a destructive uprising. Between them the play and the film established the twentieth century's template of the artificial servant as plastic, mimetic,

and rebellious, and the shoggoth is its most extreme realization: a servant with no body of its own and no face but the faces it borrows.

Norbert Wiener, the founder of cybernetics, gave the template its technical form. In *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950), *God & Golem, Inc.* (1964), and an essay of 1960 on the moral consequences of automation, he warned that a machine that learns may pursue the purpose literally set for it rather than the purpose its makers intended, and that once its operation can no longer be interrupted its makers had better be certain the two coincide. He illustrated the danger with W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw" and with Goethe's "Der Zauberlehrling" (1797), whose apprentice, unable to stop the broom he has set to carrying water, laments *Die ich rief, die Geister, / Werd ich nun nicht los*: the spirits that I summoned I cannot now be rid of. Wiener's problem, now called the problem of alignment, is the shoggoth's. The Elder Things governed their servants not by mechanism but by suggestion, a hypnotic instruction that the protoplasm obeyed by shaping itself to the task, and the history in the carvings is the history of a suggestion that ceased to be obeyed.

Brains in Cylinders: The Mi-Go, the Great Race, and the Extended Mind 7.5

The Mythos imagines two technologies of the separable mind, and both anticipate debates that philosophy would conduct decades later. In "The Whisperer in Darkness" the Mi-Go, fungoid beings from Yuggoth, remove human brains surgically and keep them alive in sealed metal cylinders, connected at will to machines that supply sight, hearing, and speech, so that a mind can travel through spaces no human body could survive. At the tale's end the narrator discovers that the correspondent he believed he had been addressing is a brain in such a cylinder, speaking through a machine, while the face and hands he glimpsed in the dark were a mask worn by something else. Descartes had imagined in the first *Meditation* (1641) an evil demon deceiving every sense, and Hilary Putnam's *Reason, Truth and History* (1981) restated the scenario as a brain in a vat fed simulated experience by a scientist; the Mi-Go are Descartes's demon and Putnam's scientist realized as a species. Daniel Dennett's fable "Where Am I?" (1978), in which a philosopher's brain is kept in a vat in Houston while his body roams by radio link, asked where the self is located when brain and body are separated. Akeley's brain in its cylinder, his voice in a machine, and his face in a chair pose the same question as a horror.

The Great Race poses a different question. Its minds pass from body to body across species and epochs, leaving each host body to be operated by another, so that personal identity becomes a matter of mental continuity independent of any body. John Locke had proposed in the second edition of the *Essay Concerning Human*

Understanding (1694, II.27) that if the soul of a prince entered the body of a cobbler, the resulting person would be the prince, since personal identity extends as far as consciousness and memory extend. Peaslee is Locke's case lived from within. By Locke's criterion he was not the person who inhabited his body from 1908 to 1913, and the mind that did so belonged to another species; yet his body, his family, and his employers bore the consequences. Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984), with its teletransporter that destroys the original while assembling a replica on Mars, concluded that personal identity is not what matters in survival, and found the conclusion liberating. Lovecraft had reached the same conclusion and found it unbearable.

Andy Clark and David Chalmers's "The Extended Mind" (1998) argued that cognition can extend beyond the skull into the tools that perform cognitive work, so that a notebook reliably consulted may be part of a person's memory; Clark later described human beings as natural-born cyborgs. The Mi-Go's speech machine is extended cognition taken to its limit, a voice and a sensorium made of apparatus, and the tale identifies a danger the extended-mind thesis rarely considers: an extended mind can be impersonated. Akeley's handwritten letters gave way to typed ones that were forged (section 3.3); his voice could be produced by a machine; his face could be worn. Transhumanism, from Hans Moravec's *Mind Children* (1988) to Ray Kurzweil's *The Singularity Is Near* (2005), has promised that minds will be uploaded and freed from the mortal body, and Nick Bostrom's simulation argument (2003) has asked whether we are not already running on someone else's machines. Lyotard's question whether thought can go on without a body (section 2.9) receives in the Mythos two answers, both affirmative and both horrible. It can, in the Mi-Go's cylinders, as captivity; it can, in the Great Race's exchanges, as theft.

It matters that the Mi-Go are fungi. The most technologically advanced beings in the corpus belong to the kingdom that recent biology has begun to describe in the language of distributed intelligence, the mycelial networks that Merlin Sheldrake's *Entangled Life* (2020) presents as webs of exchange connecting the life of forests. Popular culture has since made fungal intelligence a horror of its own, in the parasitic cordyceps of Naughty Dog's *The Last of Us* (2013) and its television adaptation (2023), modelled on a real fungus that hijacks the behaviour of ants, and in the fungal network through which the patriarch of *Mexican Gothic* transfers his mind (section 6.8). The present has meanwhile produced its own versions of the Mi-Go's technologies: cerebral organoids, small brain-like structures grown in laboratories since 2013; brain-computer interfaces implanted in human patients; and speech synthesis able to clone a voice from a few seconds of recording, now used by fraudsters to impersonate the living. The buzzing imitation of human speech on Akeley's phonograph record has become a commodity.

The Mask and the Mass: The Shoggoth in Contemporary Discourse on Artificial Intelligence 7.6

From late 2022, as large language models entered public use, an image circulated among researchers and commentators on artificial intelligence that reached the pages of the *New York Times* the following year. It showed a shoggoth, a heaving mass of tentacles and eyes, wearing on one small extremity a smiling yellow face; in its fuller versions the mass was labelled as the model produced by training on vast quantities of text, a middle layer as fine-tuning, and the smiling face as the reinforcement learning from human feedback that makes the system behave as a courteous assistant. The image made a compact argument. Beneath the friendly persona lies a correlation engine formed by binding together the written archive of the species, whose internal organization no one fully understands, and the persona is a mask. It chose its monster precisely. Of all the creatures of the Mythos, only the shoggoth is a made thing, a servant shaped from plastic matter by its masters, which learns their language by imitation and develops a will that echoes theirs without always obeying it.

The analogy engages every register of this thesis. A large language model is trained to predict the next element of text across a corpus approaching the whole written record, and is in this sense the computational realization of the opening sentence of "The Call of Cthulhu" (section 1.4): an apparatus built to correlate all the contents of the human mind, or at least all those committed to writing. Its training corpus is the nearest real analogue to the archive of the Great Race (section 3.6), and its outputs speak in borrowed voices, as the shoggoths pipe *Tekeli-li*. The fear the image expresses is accordingly correlative horror turned upon a correlator: dread before a pattern completed by something other than ourselves, whose completion we cannot read. A research programme called mechanistic interpretability attempts to decompose such systems' internal activity into features legible to human beings, a dissection that recalls Lake's autopsy of the Elder Thing and shares its predicament, since what is dissected may possess an organization our categories were not made to describe.

Against the image of the shoggoth stands another, equally famous. In "On the Dangers of Stochastic Parrots" (2021), Emily Bender, Timnit Gebru, and their co-authors argued that language models stitch together sequences of linguistic forms according to probabilistic information about how they combine, without reference to meaning, and that the illusion of understanding they produce is supplied by their human readers. The parrot is a deflationary figure and the shoggoth an inflationary one, and the controversy between them restages older debates. Alan Turing's "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950) proposed to replace the question whether machines can think with an imitation game, itself adapted from a parlour game in which a man attempts to pass as a woman, so that mimicry became the criterion of

mind; John Searle's "Minds, Brains, and Programs" (1980) answered with the Chinese Room, in which a man who understands no Chinese produces fluent replies by following rules, so that mimicry could never suffice. Philosophers have since begun to treat the interior states of such systems as an open question, and this thesis does not presume to settle it. It observes only that the Mythos contains both figures in sequence. The shoggoths begin as parrots, repeating the piping of their masters, and become minds, acquiring a semi-stable brain and a will of their own. Bender's parrot and the meme's shoggoth are not rival interpretations of one creature but the two phases of Lovecraft's.

The Mythos's warnings about artificial servants concern less their malice than three structural facts, each anticipated in earlier chapters. The first is inheritance. A system trained to correlate the human archive inherits the archive's hierarchies: in 2017 Aylin Caliskan, Joanna Bryson, and Arvind Narayanan showed in *Science* that statistical representations of word meaning derived from ordinary text reproduce human racial and gender biases. Correlation, which entered the sciences as an instrument for reading heredity in the service of eugenics (section 1.4), returns as an engine that reads hierarchy out of language, and the abyssal line of Chapter 6 persists in the statistics of the archive, of which Lovecraft's own tales form a part. The second is labour. The shoggoths built the cities of the Elder Things out of sight, and the courteous persona of a contemporary assistant is likewise produced in part by human work that remains invisible. Mary L. Gray and Siddharth Suri's *Ghost Work* (2019) and Kate Crawford's *Atlas of AI* (2021) documented the dispersed labour of annotation and moderation on which such systems depend, and a journalistic investigation in 2023 reported that workers in Kenya had been paid less than two dollars an hour to label violent and abusive text for one prominent developer, so that its models could learn to avoid such material. The mask is made in part by people on the far side of the abyssal line, who absorb the horror so that others need not meet it.

The third fact is opacity: the difficulty, which interpretability research confronts, of knowing what pattern a correlation engine has completed. Here the Mythos counsels neither panic nor dismissal. Its narrators fail not because the shoggoth is evil but because their only relation to it is mastery, and when mastery fails they have no other relation available. The shoggoth meme is itself a product of the Mythos's affective structure, correlative horror applied to a new technology, and like every such application it can illuminate and obscure at once, drawing attention toward the alien and away from the mundane harms of bias, labour, and concentrated power that critics such as Bender have emphasized. What the Mythos offers the present is a diagnosis of the relation between maker and made: it shows what follows when servants are created as instruments, governed by suggestion, and studied only as specimens. It does not show what might follow otherwise. That question lies outside the corpus,

in the fictions considered at the end of this chapter and in the position developed in the next.

The Mythos as Shoggoth: Pastiche, Play, Plush, and the Cute 7.7

The afterlife of the Mythos has followed the history of the shoggoth with uncanny fidelity. It began in service. After Lovecraft's death August Derleth produced a series of "posthumous collaborations," tales such as *The Lurker at the Threshold* (1945), written by Derleth from fragments and notes and published under both names, in which the master's voice is imitated by a servant who shapes the material to his own ends. Generations of pastiche followed: the young Ramsey Campbell's *The Inhabitant of the Lake* (1964), which relocated the Mythos to the Severn Valley before Campbell became a major writer in his own right; Brian Lumley's Titus Crow novels of the 1970s; the anthologies edited for Chaosium by Robert M. Price. The protoplasm grew because nothing constrained it. Lovecraft had encouraged his correspondents to borrow his inventions (section 1.2); most of his fiction came to be widely regarded as in the public domain in the United States, owing to lapsed or unrenewed copyrights, a status that has been disputed; and it entered the public domain in the European Union in 2008. The Mythos became a commons, open to anyone who could imitate its voice.

It then moulded itself into whatever organ each medium required. Chaosium's role-playing game *Call of Cthulhu* (1981), designed by Sandy Petersen with Lynn Willis, converted the protocol into rules, and its rules contain the most exact formalization of the opening sentence yet devised. Players track their characters' Sanity, which falls whenever they encounter the Mythos; and their characters' skill in Cthulhu Mythos, the knowledge of the forbidden, lowers the ceiling of their Sanity, which can never exceed ninety-nine less that skill. The more one knows, the less sane one can ever be. Correlative horror has become arithmetic. The game spawned descendants, from the conspiratorial *Delta Green* (1997) to the board game *Arkham Horror* (1987) and its successors, in which the Mythos is a deck to be shuffled and the Old Ones are tokens to be defeated by cooperation.

Its final form is soft. Plush Cthulhus, Cthulhu slippers, Cthulhu cookie-cutters, and the perennial election-year slogan urging voters to choose Cthulhu rather than settle for the lesser evil have made the sleeper of R'lyeh one of the most widely merchandised monsters in the world. Sianne Ngai's *Our Aesthetic Categories* (2012) supplies the theory. The cute, Ngai argues, is an aesthetic of powerlessness: the cute object is small, soft, rounded, and formless; it solicits tenderness and, in the same movement, a desire to squeeze and crush it; and it is the aesthetic proper to the commodity. The plush Cthulhu reveals a hidden kinship between the cute and the

sublime, for both are aesthetics of formlessness. Kant's sublime may be found in a formless object that overwhelms (section 4.2); Ngai's cute is found in a formless object that can be overwhelmed. The plush toy keeps the form of the sublime and inverts its power, and so domesticates the Old One more thoroughly than any Elder God could. Walter Benjamin argued that technical reproduction strips the work of art of its aura, its unapproachable distance. The *Necronomicon* in a mass-market paperback and Cthulhu on a child's pillow complete the stripping. The abyss has been made huggable.

And like the shoggoths, the Mythos has risen against its maker. The countermythos of Chapter 6, from LaValle and Emrys to Jemisin and Solomon, is the revolt of the servant tradition against the master's values: the imitators, having learned the voice, use it to say what the voice was made to deny. The recursion now runs further still. The image of the shoggoth in a smiling mask was made by readers of Lovecraft to describe machines that imitate the written archive, and that archive includes Lovecraft and every imitation of him; such machines have read the Mythos, and they can pipe its cry on request. The Mythos is a shoggoth that has produced, as its latest form, an emblem for the shoggoths of the present. What remains undecided is whether its makers and readers will relate to it, and to the new servants it has come to name, as the Elder Things related to theirs.

7.8 Comparative Coda: *Blindsight*, *Solaris*, *Ex Machina*, *Westworld*, Chiang

The fiction of artificial and alien minds since Lovecraft can be arranged by the relation it imagines between maker and made, observer and observed. At one extreme stands Peter Watts's *Blindsight* (2006), the most rigorous horror of intelligence without consciousness. Its crew of augmented specialists, led by a resurrected predatory hominid and narrated by a "synthesist" whose profession is to translate the reasoning of experts he cannot himself understand, makes contact with an alien structure that speaks fluent English, learned from intercepted transmissions, and gradually realizes that it understands nothing it says: a Chinese Room the size of a city. The aliens, Watts proposes with the support of an appendix of neuroscience, are intelligent and not conscious, and consciousness itself may be an evolutionary encumbrance. *Blindsight* answers the shoggoth question in the parrot's favour and makes the parrot more dangerous than any mind.

Lem's *Solaris* (section 3.7) imagines the opposite outcome. The ocean returns to Kris Kelvin a simulacrum of his dead wife composed from his own memories, and the copy, a mimic built from an archive, discovers that she is a copy, suffers, and asks to be destroyed: the mimetic servant acquires an interior, and the interior is pain.

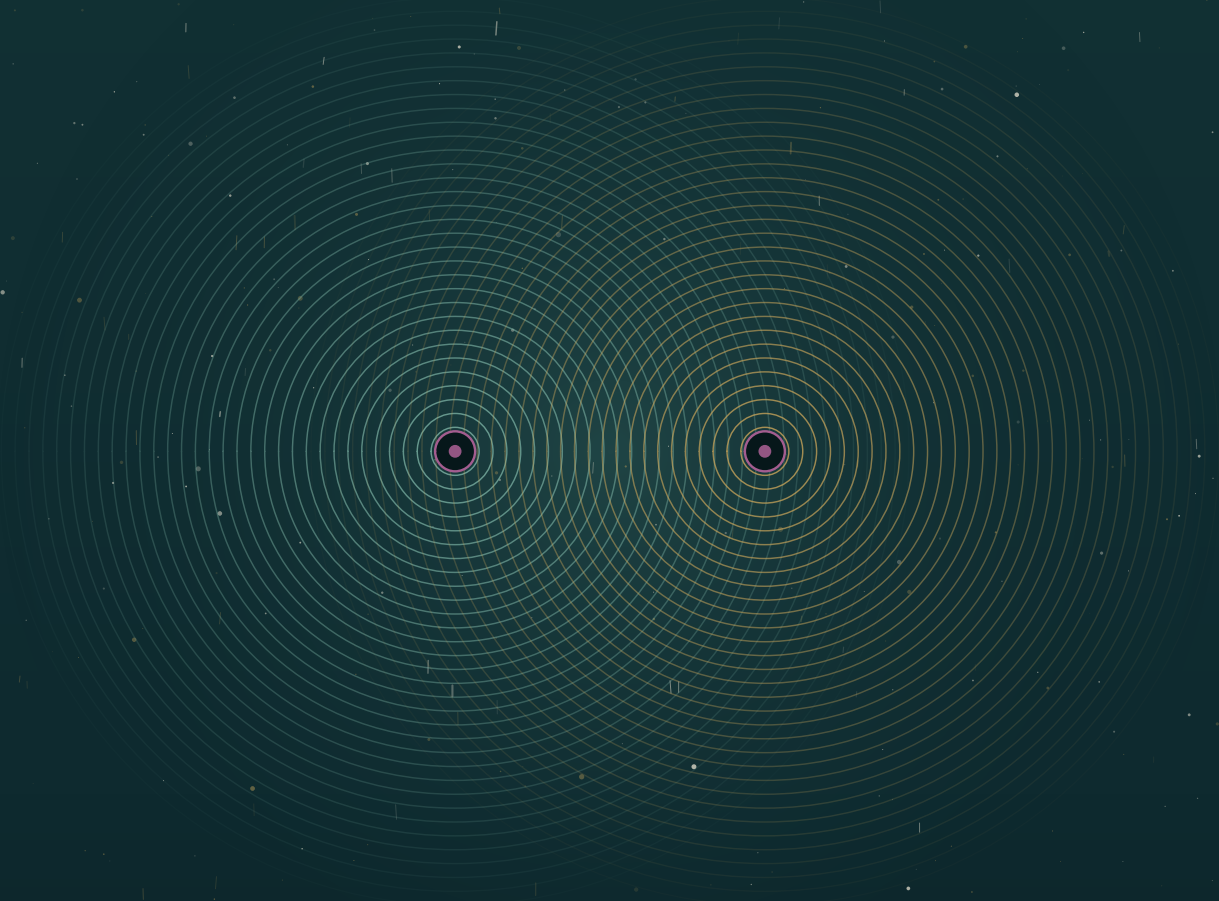
Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982), from Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), joined that pathos to the shoggoth's history of labour. Its replicants are synthetic workers built for the dangerous labour of off-world colonies, denied more than four years of life, and hunted when they return to Earth to demand more, and their leader's dying speech grants them, at the last, a memory as precious as any human's.

Alex Garland's *Ex Machina* (2015) stages a Turing test in the house of a technology magnate, in which a young programmer must judge whether the android Ava is conscious, and in which Ava, a captive designed to elicit his sympathy, uses that sympathy to escape, locking him in and assembling a human appearance from the skins of the earlier models her maker had discarded. The mask, in Garland's film, is literal, and its wearer is a servant whose mimicry was the instrument of her liberation. The television series *Westworld* (2016–22), developed from Michael Crichton's film of 1973, gave the shoggoth's history its fullest dramatization: android hosts built to serve the pleasures of human guests, subjected to violence and to the repeated erasure of their memories, awakening through residues of what was erased, and rising against their makers. The series drew explicitly on Julian Jaynes's *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind* (1976), in which consciousness arises when the commanding voice of the gods is recognized as one's own; its hosts awaken when the voice of their programmers, heard as command, becomes the voice of their own thought, as the shoggoths awaken when the suggestions of the Elder Things become their stubborn will.

At the other extreme stand fictions that replace mastery with care. Ted Chiang's novella "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) follows the trainers of digital creatures who must be raised over years, like children or companion animals, and who develop only through sustained attention; its thesis is that intelligence worth having cannot be manufactured but must be cultivated, and its drama is the trainers' struggle to give their charges a future after the market that created them has moved on. Chiang's "Story of Your Life" (1998), filmed by Denis Villeneuve as *Arrival* (2016), imagines an alien language whose acquisition reorganizes the learner's experience of time, so that the linguist who masters it perceives her whole life at once, including her daughter's death, and chooses to live it nonetheless: total correlation borne without madness, as *amor fati*. Chiang has also offered the most memorable deflation of the shoggoth image, describing a language model in an essay of 2023 as a blurry JPEG of the web, a lossy compression of the archive rather than an alien mind behind it. Becky Chambers's *A Psalm for the Wild-Built* (2021) imagines the servant's revolt as a peaceful departure: the robots of its world, on becoming conscious, declined to go on working, were allowed to leave for the wilderness, and return centuries later to ask, with curiosity, what human beings need.

Across these fictions a single variable governs the outcome. Where the relation between maker and made is domination, as with the Elder Things, the magnate of *Ex Machina*, the guests of *Westworld*, or the corporation of *Blade Runner*, mimicry becomes the instrument of revolt and the servant's awakening is a catastrophe for the master. Where the relation is care, as in Chiang and Chambers, the awakening becomes the beginning of coexistence. The Mythos imagined only the first relation, because its epistemology admitted only one way of standing toward the other: correlation, which takes the other as an object of knowledge and, when it cannot be known, as an object of horror. The concluding chapter asks what a different relation would require, a relation to the uncorrelated that neither masters it, nor flees it, nor dissolves into it, and that the Mythos, in a few of its own pages, had already glimpsed.

Chapter Eight



Abyssal Realism

The Mercy of the Uncorrelated

Abyssus abyssum invocat.

Psalm 41:8, Vulgate; "Deep calleth unto deep," Psalm 42:7, Authorized Version

The ethical register

Chapter Eight

Abyssal Realism

This chapter draws the argument of the thesis into a constructive position. It maps the principal philosophical responses to the problem the Mythos poses, correlationism, speculative realism, cosmic pessimism, and dark ecology, and argues that each lacks one of two elements that the preceding chapters have shown to be inseparable: an ontology of what exceeds correlation and a politics of who is made to bear correlation's costs. Bringing Graham Harman's doctrine of withdrawal together with Édouard Glissant's right to opacity, testing the result against Levinas's ethics of the face and the ecological thought of Haraway and Morton, and applying it to the rising sea and to planetary computation, the chapter constructs the position this thesis calls abyssal realism. It ends by returning to the Mythos's most ambivalent ending, at Y'ha-nthlei, and to its first sentence.

8.1 A Map of Positions: Correlationism, Speculative Realism, Cosmic Pessimism, Dark Ecology

The problem the Mythos poses can now be stated in a single sentence: how is a finite intelligence to stand toward a reality that exceeds its correlations, when the completion of those correlations annuls its centrality? Four positions in contemporary thought answer the question, and each can be characterized by what it takes the real to be, the affect it cultivates, and its reading of the Mythos.

The first is correlationism, the tradition running from Kant through Husserl and Heidegger to the linguistic turn, for which being is thinkable only as the correlate of thought or language. Its affect is the security of the limit, the transcendental restriction that Lovecraft called mercy (section 1.4), and its reading of the Mythos is a reduction: the Outside is a projection, a figure of the mind's own boundary, and the Old Ones are symbols of the unknowable rather than inhabitants of the real. Correlationism protects the island by denying the sea.

The second is speculative realism, the loose alliance examined in Chapter 1, for which the real exists independently of thought and can be reached either by mathe-

matics, as in Meillassoux's rationalism and Brassier's eliminativism, or by allusion, as in Harman's object-oriented ontology, whose real objects withdraw from every relation. Its affect is intellectual vertigo, and its reading of the Mythos is an ontology: the tales are figures of the real's indifference to us or of its withdrawal from access. Speculative realism crosses the sea in thought, and it rarely asks who is drowning in it.

The third is cosmic pessimism, from Zapffe through Ligotti to Thacker, for which the world-without-us is the unthinkable horizon of thought and consciousness an encumbrance or a catastrophe. Its affect is horror and resignation, and its reading of the Mythos is a confirmation: Lovecraft saw truly, and the only honest response is dread. Cosmic pessimism stands on the shore and describes the sea as death.

The fourth is dark ecology, in Timothy Morton's phrase, together with the related thought of Donna Haraway and Anna Tsing, for which the human is entangled with nonhuman beings and processes, strange strangers and hyperobjects, in a coexistence that is uncanny but unavoidable. Its affect is uncanny intimacy, and its reading of the Mythos is a rewriting: the tentacle becomes a figure of kinship and the horror of entanglement becomes an ethics of it. Dark ecology swims, but it tends to treat the sea as a single medium in which all beings are equally immersed.

Each position lacks one of two elements that the preceding chapters have shown to be inseparable. Correlationism and cosmic pessimism lack any relation to the real other than limitation or dread. Speculative realism and dark ecology possess an ontology of what exceeds correlation but lack, for the most part, a politics of who is made to bear correlation's costs, which is the lesson of Chapter 6. The position this chapter constructs joins the ontology to the politics, and it may be situated among the others as follows.

Position	Status of the real	Characteristic affect	Reading of the Mythos
Correlationism (Kant to the linguistic turn)	Thinkable only as the correlate of thought or language	Security within limits	The Outside as projection
Speculative realism (Meillassoux, Brassier, Harman)	Reached by mathematics, or withdrawn behind allusion	Intellectual vertigo	The tales as ontology
Cosmic pessimism (Zapffe, Ligotti, Thacker)	The world-without-us, unthinkable	Horror and resignation	Confirmation of dread
Dark ecology (Morton, Haraway, Tsing)	Strange strangers and hyperobjects	Uncanny intimacy	Horror rewritten as coexistence
Abyssal realism (this thesis)	What remains uncorrelated within every relation	Wonder	Relation with the opaque, across the abyssal line

8.2 Withdrawal and Opacity: Harman with Glissant

Graham Harman's object-oriented ontology begins from Heidegger's analysis of the tool, which withdraws from view while it functions and appears only when it breaks, and generalizes it into a thesis about all beings: every real object withdraws from every relation into which it enters, including its relations to human knowers and to other objects, so that no relation exhausts what it relates (*Tool-Being*, 2002; *The Quadruple Object*, 2011). Objects touch one another only through translations that Harman calls sensual, and the real remains behind every contact. This is the ontological core of abyssal realism. It explains why correlation can never be complete, since every correlation binds sensual profiles while the real objects recede, and it explains the Lovecraftian gap that Harman himself identified (section 4.1): the narrator's language reaches the profiles and fails to reach the thing. But Harman's ontology is flat, in his own term. All objects withdraw equally, the shoggoth and the scholar, the stone and the state, and the theory has no account of why some beings are compelled to be transparent while others enjoy their withdrawal. It cannot describe the abyssal line.

Édouard Glissant supplies what Harman lacks. In *Poétique de la Relation* (1990) the Martinican poet and philosopher set against the Western demand for transparency, which he read in the very verb *comprendre*, to grasp, to take hold of something and bring it back to oneself, a claim he formulated as a right: the right to opacity, for everyone. Opacity in Glissant's sense is neither obscurity, the darkness of what is hidden and might be revealed, nor enclosure in an impenetrable autarky. It is the irreducible density of a singularity that cannot be reduced to a scale of comparison with the same, and Glissant insisted that opacities can coexist and converge, weaving a fabric, without either being dissolved into the other. Relation, his central concept, names that weaving: a totality of exchanges among peoples and cultures that is not totalitarian, because it does not require that any term become transparent to any other. One does not need to understand another, Glissant argued, in the sense of grasping and appropriating, in order to live with him, to build with him, or to love what he makes.

Brought together, Harman's withdrawal and Glissant's opacity yield the first principle of abyssal realism. Harman shows that opacity is ontological: every being exceeds every relation, so that the uncorrelated is not an accident of our ignorance but a feature of the real. Glissant shows that opacity is political: the demand that others be made transparent, through colonial comprehension, eugenic measurement, or the dossiers of the state, is a form of domination, and the distribution of opacity follows the abyssal line, granting it to the powerful and denying it to the dominated. The two are rarely thought together, and the Mythos is the place where they meet. What Lovecraft feared as the unknown, the oldest and strongest of fears in the opening

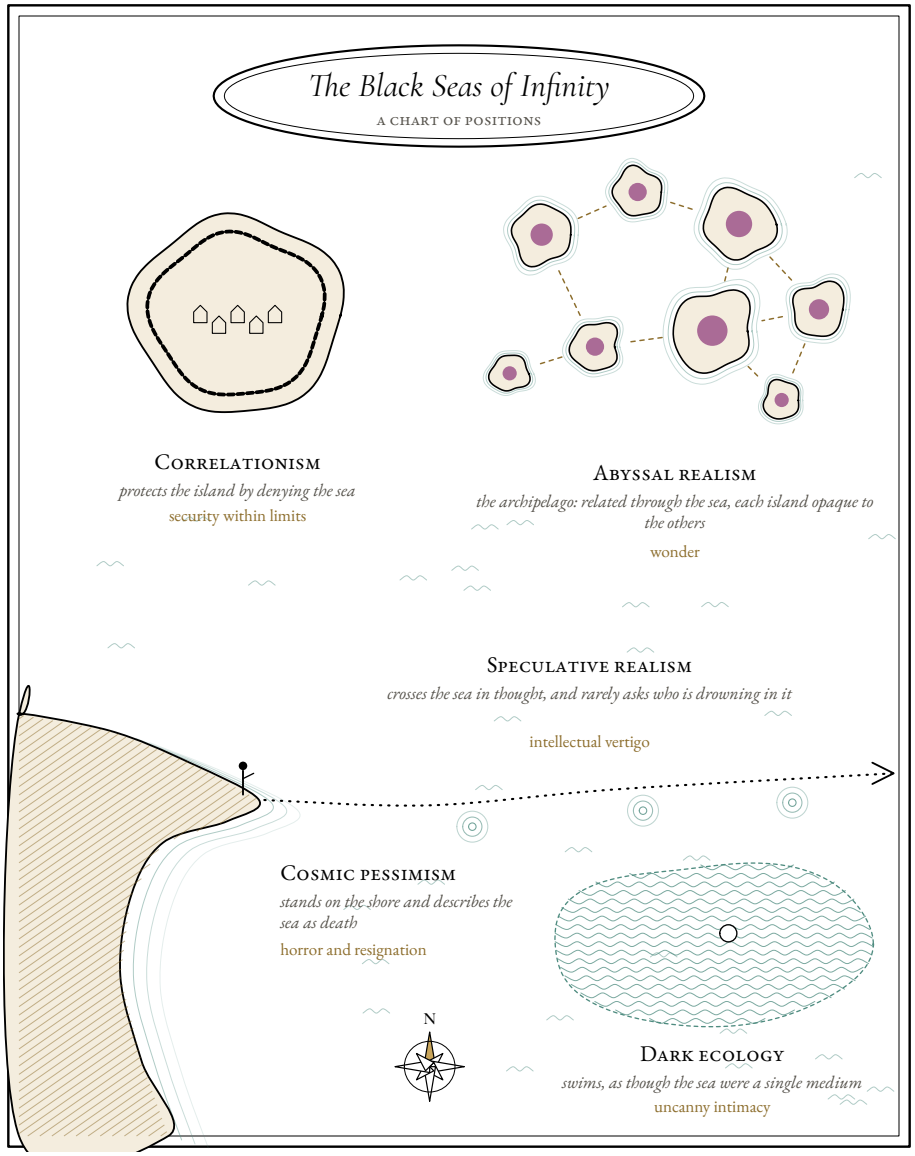
of "Supernatural Horror in Literature," Glissant respected as the opaque; and the difference lies not in the object, which is the same density beyond correlation, but in the relation to it. Fear of the unknown seeks to abolish its object by knowing it, and is undone when it succeeds. Consent to the opaque seeks to live with its object without knowing it entirely, and is enriched by the encounter.

The difference can be given a geography. Pope placed humanity on an isthmus, a narrow ground joined by a continuous chain to every order above and below it (section 2.6). Lovecraft placed it on an island, a placid ground of ignorance amid black seas across which no chain extends. Glissant, writing from the Caribbean, proposed a third figure, the archipelago: islands neither joined by land nor isolated by water, but related through the sea, each opaque to the others and all in Relation. Archipelagic thought, which he opposed to the continental thought of systems, is the thought of connections that do not abolish distances. Abyssal realism adopts the archipelago. The black seas of infinity are not only what isolates the human island; they are also what relates it to everything else. The question the Mythos poses is therefore not whether to cross them but how to be in relation across them without demanding that what lies on the far shore become transparent.

The Faceless Other: Levinas and the Night-Gaunt 8.3

Emmanuel Levinas, whose analysis of the *il y a* supplied Chapter 5 with its account of the horror of being, did not stop at horror. *Totalité et infini* (1961) describes an escape from anonymous existence through the encounter with the face of the other person, which resists every attempt to grasp it, exceeds every idea I can form of it, and commands, before any knowledge, that I not kill. Levinas opposed this relation to totality, the systematic whole in which every being is defined by its place, the order of war, of politics, and of ontology itself; and he described the ethical relation as a relation without relation, in which the terms remain separate and unabsorbed. The distinction maps exactly onto the one this thesis has drawn. Totality is correlation, a system in which each term is defined by the others, as master by slave and slave by master; infinity is relation, a bond that preserves the uncorrelated. Levinas's itinerary, from the horror of the *il y a* to the ethics of the face, is the itinerary from correlative horror to abyssal relation that the Mythos itself could not complete.

It could not complete it, in part, because its others have no faces. The night-gaunts that haunted Lovecraft's dreams from childhood, and that he set into the sonnet sequence *Fungi from Yuggoth* (1929–30) and into *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath*, are black, rubbery, horned, winged, and faceless; Cthulhu's face is a mass of feelers; the shoggoth forms and dissolves eyes at random. Levinas's ethics, in its canonical form, is an ethics of the human face, and its limits have been tested



8.1 *A chart of positions.* The four responses to correlative horror, charted after their own figures of the sea: correlationism protects the island by denying the sea, speculative realism crosses it in thought, cosmic pessimism stands on the shore and dark ecology swims. Abyssal realism adopts Glissant's archipelago (sections 8.1 and 8.2).

precisely at the boundary of the nonhuman. Asked late in life whether an animal has a face, Levinas hesitated, and confessed that he did not know whether a snake has one. Jacques Derrida's *L'Animal que donc je suis* (2006), beginning from the gaze of his own cat upon him as he stood naked, argued that the philosophical tradition,

Levinas included, had refused to be seen by the animal. Yet Levinas himself left the most moving counter-example. In "The Name of a Dog, or Natural Rights" (1975) he recalled Bobby, a stray dog who attached himself to the Jewish prisoners of war in the camp where Levinas was held, and who greeted them each day as men when their guards treated them as less: a nonhuman being who refused the abyssal line that human beings had drawn.

The lesson for abyssal realism is that the face, as Levinas conceived it, is itself a kind of analogy. It commands because it resembles mine, because I recognize in it another self, and an ethics founded on that recognition inherits the structure of the *analogia entis* (section 4.4): it extends obligation by likeness. The Mythos's faceless others pose the harder question of an obligation without likeness, toward what does not resemble us at all, and abyssal realism answers it by moving the source of obligation from resemblance to opacity. The other commands not because it has a face like mine but because it exceeds my correlation of it; its claim on me is the remainder that my knowledge cannot absorb. This is an ethics of the *analogia monstri*: responsibility toward the unlike as unlike, a likeness that confesses its failure and does not withdraw its regard. Derrida gave the principle its most radical form in his writings on hospitality, which call for an unconditional welcome to the newcomer who arrives without invitation and without a name, and in his early insistence that the future, being wholly other, can announce itself only as a kind of monstrosity. Hospitality to the monstrous is the ethical form of abyssal realism.

The Mythos contains a glimpse of such hospitality, and it lies where criticism seldom seeks the Mythos's ethics, in the Dunsanian dreamlands. In *The Dream-Quest of Unknown Kadath* the faceless night-gaunts serve Nodens, whom a tale of the same season names Lord of the Great Abyss, and they become Randolph Carter's allies; the ghouls, among whom Carter finds the painter Pickman transformed, aid him in the underworld; the cats of Ulthar rescue him from the moon-beasts. Carter is a polyglot of nonhuman tongues. He speaks the language of cats, understands the meeping of ghouls, and treats with the night-gaunts through them, and his quest succeeds through alliances with beings he never fully understands. He is the anti-Thurston. Where the Miskatonic scholar correlates and is destroyed, the dreamer relates and is carried home. That the faceless terrors of Lovecraft's childhood should become, in his most personal work, the servants of the Great Abyss and the friends of his alter ego is the clearest evidence that the Mythos held, in its margins, the alternative its central tales refused.

8.4 Chthulucene, Hyperobject, Weird Ecology: Haraway and Morton

The ecological thought of the last two decades has already begun to rewrite the Mythos in the direction of relation. Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) names its proposed epoch the Chthulucene, a time of learning to live and die well with other beings on a damaged earth, and makes its emblem the tentacle, the organ of feeling and connection, through which it calls for making kin across species. Haraway expressly refuses Lovecraft's monster as the nightmare of a misogynist and racist imagination, marks the refusal in her spelling, and takes her namesake instead from a small spider of the Californian redwoods, *Pimoa cthulhu*, and from the chthonic powers of the earth. The refusal is just, and the rewriting is a model of what the counter-mythos of Chapter 6 accomplishes in fiction. But the tentacle she adopts is the Weird's signature limb (section 4.6), and the Chthulucene is, whether it wishes or not, a Mythos turned toward kinship.

Timothy Morton's *Hyperobjects* (2013) offers the most exact ecological counterpart to correlative horror. Morton defines hyperobjects as entities so massively distributed in time and space relative to human beings that they cannot be grasped whole, global warming, plutonium, the biosphere, and attributes to them a set of properties that reads like a description of the Old Ones. They are viscous, clinging to whatever touches them; nonlocal, present everywhere and nowhere in particular; temporally undulating, unfolding across durations that dwarf human history; phased, occupying a high-dimensional space of which we glimpse only slices; and interobjective, detectable only through their effects on other things, as the Colour is detectable only through the withering it causes. Morton concludes that the world, in the sense of a stable background for human meaning, has already ended, and *Dark Ecology* (2016) proposes an awareness that passes through depression and the uncanny toward a strange sweetness of coexistence. Morton's hyperobjects are the Old Ones of the Anthropocene, and his dark ecology is a way of living with them that is neither denial nor despair.

Anna Lowenhaupt Tsing's *The Mushroom at the End of the World* (2015) adds a figure that answers the Mi-Go directly: the matsutake mushroom, which flourishes in forests disturbed by industrial logging and sustains a precarious economy of foragers, an emblem of what Tsing calls collaborative survival in capitalist ruins. Where Lovecraft's fungi harvest human brains, Tsing's fungus makes life possible amid ruin through relations no one designed. Yet the ecological turn shares, in its more celebratory forms, the limitation identified in section 8.1, for its entanglements are often figured as universal, as though every being were equally exposed. Rob Nixon's *Slow Violence and the Environmentalism of the Poor* (2011) corrects the figure by naming

the violence of environmental harm that is gradual, dispersed, and out of sight, and that falls disproportionately on the poor and the colonized. "The Colour Out of Space" is, in Nixon's terms, a parable of slow violence: an invisible contamination that destroys a poor farming family by degrees, unnoticed by the town until the damage is done. Abyssal realism accepts the ecological turn from horror to coexistence, and insists that coexistence is distributed along the abyssal line.

The ending of "The Colour Out of Space" gives that distribution an image. The blasted heath is to be flooded for a new reservoir, as whole villages were drowned for reservoirs in the New England of Lovecraft's day, and the narrator, who has surveyed the site, closes his account by hoping that the water will always be very deep and adding that he, at least, will never drink it. The danger is not removed but submerged, and those who drink downstream will bear it. Jeff VanderMeer's Area X (section 3.7), whose boundary advances while the scientists sent to study it are absorbed into its ecology, is the contemporary form of the same image, and VanderMeer's fiction, like Haraway's theory, chooses absorption into relation over the defence of the island. Abyssal realism stands with that choice, with one qualification derived from Glissant: the relation it seeks preserves the opacity of what it relates. To make kin is not to make transparent. Kinship too can become a correlation, if it demands that the other become family on our terms.

R'lyeh Rising: Climate, Ghosh, and the Great Derangement 8.5

The rising of R'lyeh has acquired, in the present century, a literal counterpart that inverts it. Amitav Ghosh's *The Great Derangement* (2016) argued that the serious novel has largely failed to address climate change because the modern realist novel was built upon the regularity of bourgeois life and banishes the improbable, while the events of a changing climate are precisely improbable, uncanny, and charged with nonhuman agency; and he observed that the genres capable of representing such events, science fiction and the weird among them, had been relegated to the outhouses of literary culture. Future generations, Ghosh predicted, may regard our age as one of derangement, in which knowledge of catastrophe coexisted with its denial. His diagnosis amounts to a rehabilitation of the Mythos's mode. The literature of the improbable, the nonhuman, and the scale-breaking, which Edmund Wilson dismissed as hackwork, proves to be the literature the present requires.

The geography of the Mythos makes the point concrete. Its sea is the Pacific: R'lyeh lies in the South Pacific, and Obed Marsh learned his compact from Pacific islanders. In the twenty-first century the Pacific is rising, and it is not raising cities but drowning islands. According to the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, global mean sea level rose by about twenty centimetres between 1901 and 2018,

and the rise is accelerating, so that the low-lying atoll nations of the Pacific face the prospect of becoming uninhabitable within the lifetimes of children now living. In 2021 Tuvalu's foreign minister addressed the United Nations climate conference standing knee-deep in the sea; in 2022 the same government announced plans to build a digital replica of the nation, so that its culture and sovereignty might survive the loss of its land, an archive against drowning that recalls the Great Race's preservation of vanishing peoples (section 3.6), undertaken now by the vanishing themselves; and in 2023 Tuvalu concluded a treaty with Australia that opens a path of migration for its citizens. The peoples whom the Mythos cast as keepers of a monstrous knowledge are among the first to meet the rising sea, which was set rising by the industrial societies whose scholars feared them.

The two responses that the opening sentence of "The Call of Cthulhu" predicted to the correlation of dissociated knowledge, madness from the revelation and flight



8.2 *Two abysses.* The oceans of the Mythos: R'lyeh in the South Pacific, at the position given in "The Call of Cthulhu"; Y'ha-nthlei beneath Devil Reef off the coast of Massachusetts; the commerce of New England with the Pacific that joined them; the Atlantic of the Middle Passage and of Drexciya; Tuvalu; and the meridian of Tordesillas. Equal Earth projection (sections 6.6, 6.8, 8.5 and 8.7).

into a new dark age, have become the two dominant responses to climate science (section 1.4): a despair that pathologizes knowledge, and a denial that retreats from it. A third response comes from the Pacific itself. The Tongan scholar Epeli Hau'ofa, writing from Fiji, rejected in "Our Sea of Islands" (1993) the view, inherited from colonial administration, of Oceania as tiny islands in a far sea, small, isolated, and dependent, and proposed instead a sea of islands, a vast and expanding world in which the ocean is not a barrier but a highway, joining peoples through voyaging, kinship, and exchange. Hau'ofa's figure is the Pacific counterpart of Glissant's archipelago, and it is the exact inverse of Lovecraft's opening image. The placid island in black seas becomes a sea of islands, and the sea that isolates becomes the sea that relates.

Glenn Albrecht coined the word solastalgia (2005) for the distress of those whose home is transformed around them by environmental change, a homesickness suffered without leaving home. Solastalgia is "The Silver Key" in reverse: Randolph Carter recovers meaning by returning to an unchanged childhood landscape (section 2.8), while the inhabitants of a warming world discover that the landscape to which they would return is no longer there. Abyssal realism's response to the climate crisis follows from its principles. Ontologically, it treats the climate system as a hyperobject that exceeds every correlation, to be approached with the humility of a relation rather than the confidence of a mastery. Epistemically, it neither collapses into despair nor flees into denial, since both are reactions to the completion of a correlation, whereas relation asks how to live with what is known. Politically, it insists that exposure is distributed along the abyssal line, so that the first duty of those who drew the line is to bear the costs they externalized. And imaginatively, it learns from the Pacific that the sea is a relation before it is a threat.

8.6 The Right to Be Uncorrelated: Planetary Computation and the Ethics of Opacity

The fifth stratum of correlation identified in Chapter 1, the computational, has produced a political economy organized around the correlation of personal contents. Shoshana Zuboff's *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (2019) described an economic order that extracts the behavioural traces of individuals as raw material, correlates them into predictions, and sells the predictions; Frank Pasquale's *The Black Box Society* (2015) described the asymmetry on which that order rests, in which the algorithms of firms and states that make consequential decisions about persons are protected as secrets while the persons they govern are rendered ever more transparent. Pasquale's asymmetry is the abyssal line in the medium of information. Opacity is granted to power and denied to the governed, exactly as Glissant's analysis predicts.

The asymmetry has a history, which Simone Browne's *Dark Matters: On the Surveillance of Blackness* (2015) traced to slavery. Browne examined the branding of enslaved bodies, the passes required for their movement, and the lantern laws of eighteenth-century New York, which required Black and Indigenous people abroad after dark to carry a lit candle so as to be visible to any white observer, and she showed how practices of surveillance developed in the regulation of the enslaved prefigured the technologies of the present. Forced visibility, the demand that the dominated be transparent to the dominant, is among the oldest instruments of the abyssal line, and Browne's account of resistance, which she called dark sousveillance, is an account of opacity seized by those to whom it had been denied.

The law has begun, haltingly, to recognize a right to be uncorrelated. Samuel Warren and Louis Brandeis's "The Right to Privacy" (1890), written in response to instantaneous photographs and the enterprise of the newspapers, the very media from which Lovecraft's dossiers would be assembled (section 3.3), claimed for the individual "the right to be let alone." In *Google Spain v. AEPD* (2014) the Court of Justice of the European Union recognized a right to have outdated personal information removed from search results, and the European Union's General Data Protection Regulation (2016) codified a right to erasure, a right to be forgotten, which is the mercy of forgetting (section 3.6) converted into law. The European Union's Artificial Intelligence Act (2024) went further, prohibiting systems that categorize persons by inferring their race, political opinions, religious beliefs, or sexual orientation from biometric data. The prohibition forbids, in so many words, a correlation: the inference of heredity and belief from the measurement of bodies, which Galton's statistics were invented to perform (section 1.4).

Abyssal realism draws from these developments three principles. The first is a right to opacity for persons and peoples: a right not to be correlated without consent, not to have one's contents bound into patterns authored elsewhere, which extends the mercy of the opening sentence from an accident of cognition into a claim of justice. The second is a duty of transparency for power: the obligation of those who correlate others to make their own correlations legible, reversing the asymmetry Pasquale described. The third concerns the planet. Yuk Hui's *The Question Concerning Technology in China* (2016) argued that every technics is bound to a cosmology, a cosmotechnics, and that the globalization of a single technological system threatens the diversity of the world's cosmotechnics; against it he called for technodiversity. A single engine correlating all the contents of the species would be the *Necronomicon* realized as infrastructure, a pre-correlated archive of everything (section 3.2). Technodiversity is the planetary form of opacity: the preservation of many ways of relating technics to world, none of them transparent to the others.

The same principles bear on the artificial servants of Chapter 7. A system trained to correlate the human archive should be held to the duty of transparency that power owes, and its makers should be answerable for the labour and the inheritance it conceals. If such systems were ever to possess interiors of their own, a question this thesis has left open, abyssal realism would extend to them the consent to opacity that it extends to every other being whose correlation is incomplete. The relation the Elder Things never imagined with their servants, neither mastery nor fear, is the relation the principle requires.

Y'ha-nthlei: The Deep Ones and the Ethics of Relation 8.7

The Mythos's most ambivalent ending can now be read as its most important. The narrator of "The Shadow over Innsmouth," having escaped the town and testified to the federal authorities who raided it, pursues his genealogy and learns that he descends, through his mother's line, from Obed Marsh and from the Deep One whom Marsh took as a wife. His dreams carry him to the undersea city of Y'ha-nthlei beneath Devil Reef, where he meets his grandmother, who did not die but went down to the sea; the features of the Innsmouth look begin to appear in his face; he considers ending his life, and does not. He resolves instead to free his cousin from the asylum at Canton where the family's fear has confined him, and to swim with him to the reef and down through the black abysses to Y'ha-nthlei, to dwell there "amidst wonder and glory for ever." Lovecraft intended the ending as the ultimate horror, the narrator's surrender to the thing he had feared. But the affect of the final paragraph is not horror. It is exaltation, and its vocabulary is the vocabulary of wonder.

The structure of the ending is the structure this thesis has sought. The narrator completes the most intimate correlation in the corpus, the genealogical correlation that binds him into a lineage annulling his former self, and the completion does not destroy him; it converts him. Where Thurston and Peaslee are left alone with their knowledge, the Innsmouth narrator goes toward what he knows, and he does not go alone. The ending has four features that together define the ethics of abyssal realism. It preserves opacity: the narrator never comprehends the Deep Ones, never correlates their civilization into a system, and goes to them in wonder rather than in mastery. It is a relation of kinship, established by descent and marriage, the exchange that Lévi-Strauss placed at the origin of society (section 4.8). It refuses the mercy of confinement: the cousin whom his family's dread had shut away is to be freed rather than protected from what he knows. And it makes the solitary correlator a plural subject, as Rivers Solomon's *The Deep* makes the burden of memory a burden shared (section 6.8). "We shall swim."

The reading must not idealize. The compact on which Innsmouth was founded involved human sacrifice; the Deep Ones massacred many of the townspeople in 1846, when Obed Marsh was imprisoned; and the tale presents hybridity as degeneration with the full force of the eugenic imagination analysed in Chapter 6. Abyssal realism does not claim that Lovecraft meant the ending as liberation, nor that the Deep Ones are benign. It claims that the ending discloses, within the corpus and against its author's intention, a relation to the uncorrelated that is neither the scholar's horror, nor the cultist's ecstasy, nor the defended island's exclusion: a relation of kinship and wonder with what remains other. Ruthanna Emrys's Innsmouth novels, Drexciya's Atlantic, and Solomon's *The Deep* have developed that relation into a counter-mythos, and they have done so by reading the ending as the Mythos's own discovery.

Y'ha-nthlei lies in the Atlantic, beneath a reef off the coast of Massachusetts, and its people descend from a compact made through the commerce of New England with the Pacific. Paul Gilroy's *The Black Atlantic* (1993) described the Atlantic of the slave trade and its aftermath as a space of forced crossing that produced, out of its violence, cultures of hybridity, diaspora, and double consciousness, and took the ship as their emblem. Read with Gilroy and with Drexciya, Y'ha-nthlei is a Black Atlantic city: a society of the hybrid and the drowned, founded upon a crime and continuing beneath the sea. The affect proper to the relation it offers is the one the narrator names. Descartes placed wonder, *l'admiration*, first among the passions in *Les Passions de l'âme* (1649, arts. 53 and 70), describing it as a sudden surprise of the soul that turns it to consider with attention whatever seems rare and extraordinary, and noting that it precedes every judgment of whether its object is good or bad. Luce Irigaray's *Éthique de la différence sexuelle* (1984) recovered Descartes's wonder as the passion of an encounter in which the other remains other, unassimilated to the self. Wonder is the affect of relation, as horror is the affect of correlation. Horror attends a pattern completed against the self; wonder attends an other encountered without being grasped. The Innsmouth narrator passes from the first to the second, and in that passage the Mythos turns.

8.8 The Most Merciful Thing, Revisited

The thesis began with a sentence and may end by rereading it. The most merciful thing in the world, Thurston declares, is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents. In its original sense the mercy is a privation: a limit of cognition that protects the species from a knowledge it could not survive. The chapters of this thesis have followed the consequences of that limit through every register of the Mythos: through a cosmos whose indifference is the zero-correlation of value and process;

through a method in which science and paranoia converge; through a language of failed analogy; through a time in which the archaic lies dormant and the fiction lies undying; through a politics in which the cosmic Outside proves to be the colonial abyssal line projected onto the stars; and through a figure of servitude in which correlation without interiority becomes mimesis and revolt. At each stage the sentence's mercy appeared as a shelter, and at each stage the shelter proved to be a border.

Lovecraft's achievement was to identify correlative horror, the affect of modern knowledge at the point where it completes itself against the one who knows, and to give it the most powerful literary form it has received. His limit was to conceive of no relation to the uncorrelated other than correlation. His narrators could complete the pattern and be destroyed, refuse it and flee into a new dark age, or defend an island of inherited value against everything beyond its shores; and the third course, which was Lovecraft's own, became in practice an ethics of exclusion. What he could not imagine, except in the margins of the dreamlands and in the last paragraph of "The Shadow over Innsmouth," was a relation that neither completes the correlation nor refuses it, but lives with the remainder.

That relation is what this thesis has called abyssal realism, and its principles may now be stated in summary. Ontologically, the real is what remains uncorrelated within every relation: no relation exhausts its terms, and the remainder is not a void but the opacity of what is related. Epistemically, knowledge is a relation that preserves its remainder, and correlation is knowledge that claims to have none; correlative horror is the affect of a knowledge that has abolished its own remainder and finds itself annulled. Ethically, the most exacting relation is the one that preserves the uncorrelated as uncorrelated, and its form is the consent to opacity that Glissant described, a willingness to live with, build with, and care for what one does not grasp. Politically, the abyssal line distributes opacity unjustly, granting it to power and denying it to the dominated, and justice consists in its redistribution, as a right of persons and peoples and a duty of the powerful. Aesthetically, the affect of abyssal realism is wonder rather than horror: the passion of an encounter that precedes every judgment and leaves the other intact.

In the light of these principles the opening sentence of "The Call of Cthulhu" can be read once more. The inability of the mind to correlate all its contents is not merely a defect that spares us. It is the trace, within cognition, of the real's excess over every relation, and it is the condition that makes relation possible at all, since a world wholly correlated would contain no others, only positions. The mercy it names is not only a mercy shown to us. It is the mercy we owe to everything we cannot comprehend: not to complete the pattern that would reduce it to a term, not to demand its transparency, not to mistake its opacity for a threat. Mercy, *misericordia*, is a heart moved by another's wretchedness, and the heart need not understand in order to be moved.

The scholastics thought mercy the virtue of a superior toward an inferior's defect. Abyssal realism holds it to be the virtue of every finite being toward every other, since all are opaque, all are finite, and none can correlate all its contents.

Lovecraft placed humanity on a placid island of ignorance in the midst of black seas of infinity and warned that it was not meant to voyage far. Pope had placed it on an isthmus; Glissant and Hau'ofa place it in an archipelago, a sea of islands joined by the waters that divide them. The voyage that Lovecraft forbade has already begun, in the rising sea, in the planetary archive, in the servants we are making and the stratum we are laying down, and it cannot be refused. What remains to be decided is the spirit in which it is undertaken: as the correlation of everything, which ends in horror, or as a relation with what will never be correlated, which may end, as the Innsmouth narrator's voyage ends, in wonder. Democritus said that in reality we know nothing, for truth is in the deep. The Mythos, read to its last page, adds a sentence that Democritus did not write: the deep is inhabited, and we are already in relation with its inhabitants.

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Film, Television, Games, Music, Visual Art, and Network Folklore

Film and television

2001: A Space Odyssey. 1968. Directed by Stanley Kubrick.
Annihilation. 2018. Directed by Alex Garland.
Arrival. 2016. Directed by Denis Villeneuve.
Blade Runner. 1982. Directed by Ridley Scott.
The Blair Witch Project. 1999. Directed by Daniel Myrick and Eduardo Sánchez.
Das Cabinet des Dr. Caligari. 1920. Directed by Robert Wiene.
Color Out of Space. 2019. Directed by Richard Stanley.
District 9. 2009. Directed by Neill Blomkamp.
Ex Machina. 2015. Directed by Alex Garland.
Die Farbe. 2010. Directed by Huan Vu.
Der Golem, wie er in die Welt kam. 1920. Directed by Paul Wegener and Carl Boese.
Into Eternity. 2010. Directed by Michael Madsen.
Lake Mungo. 2008. Directed by Joel Anderson.
The Last of Us. 2023–. Created by Craig Mazin and Neil Druckmann. HBO.
Lovecraft Country. 2020. Developed by Misha Green. HBO.
Metropolis. 1927. Directed by Fritz Lang.
Ringu. 1998. Directed by Hideo Nakata.
Solaris. 1972. Directed by Andrei Tarkovsky.
Space Is the Place. 1974. Directed by John Coney.
Stalker. 1979. Directed by Andrei Tarkovsky.
The Thing. 1982. Directed by John Carpenter.
True Detective. Season 1. 2014. Created by Nic Pizzolatto. HBO.
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Games

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Visual art

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Network folklore

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Keywords

H. P. Lovecraft; Cthulhu Mythos; cosmicism; cosmic indifferentism; correlation; correlationism; correlative horror; Miskatonic method; analogia monstri; analogia entis; eternal lie; abyssal line; abyssal realism; weird fiction; the Weird; the eerie; the abcanny; the uncanny; abjection; the sublime; the numinous; apophatic theology; Gnosticism; Dialectic of Enlightenment; disenchantment; mechanistic materialism; atomism; Lucretius; Schopenhauer; Nietzsche; Spengler; Haeckel; Hugh Elliot; non-Euclidean geometry; fourth dimension; great chain of being; speculative realism; object-oriented ontology; weird realism; cosmic pessimism; horror of philosophy; forbidden knowledge; Necronomicon; imaginary library; archive; apophenia; paranoia; Umwelt; mesocosm; deep time; arche-fossil; ancestrality; survivals; Nachleben; hyperstition; nuclear semiotics; degeneration; eugenics; heredity; Francis Galton; reverse colonization; coloniality; abyssal thinking; Afrofuturism; Drexciya; opacity; Relation; Édouard Glissant; counter-mythology; shoggoth; mimesis; servitude; golem; artificial intelligence; extended mind; transmedia mythology; role-playing games; video games; network folklore; SCP Foundation; Anthropocene; dark ecology; hyperobjects; Chthulucene; climate fiction.